

COMMANDER

PREMIUM PROFILE



16 Personalities

What's in This Profile?

This profile is designed to cover all the main aspects of Commanders' personality as it affects different areas of their life, including Commanders' key strengths and weaknesses, relationships, academic path, career and professional development, as well as their communication and social skills, parenting tips and advice, and much, much more. It combines personality type theory with practical, real-world advice from others who share the Commander personality type.

As Aristotle said millennia ago, "The hardest victory is the victory over self" – and, to this end, personality types have been considered and studied throughout human history, from the four humors of ancient Greece to the work of Carl Jung. The information in these pages provides profound personal insight that can help with handling day-to-day situations in more healthy, balanced ways. Consider this profile a plan for success.

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The Puzzle of Personality



When they receive their personality test results on our website, most people's first question is, "What do these letters mean?" We are of course referring to those mysterious acronyms – INTJ-A, for example, or ENFP-T. As you may have already learned from the type descriptions or articles on the website, the five letters of these acronyms each refer to a specific trait, with certain trait combinations forming various types and type groups. But before we discuss those traits in depth, let's explore their historical foundations.

Since the dawn of time, humans have drawn up schematics to describe and categorize our personalities. From the four temperaments of the ancient civilizations to the latest advances in psychology, we have been driven to fit the variables and complexities of human personality into well-defined models. Although we are still some time away from being able to do that, the current models account for our most important personality traits and can predict our behavior with a high degree of accuracy.

Personality is just one of many factors that guide our behavior, however. Our actions are also influenced by our environment, our experiences, and our individual goals. This profile describes how people belonging to a specific personality type are *likely* to behave. We will outline indicators and tendencies, however, not definitive guidelines or answers. Significant differences can exist even among people who share a personality type. The information in this profile is meant to inspire personal growth and an improved understanding of yourself and your relationships – not to be taken as gospel.

Our approach has its roots in two different philosophies. One dates back to the early 20th century and was the brainchild of Carl Gustav Jung, the father of analytical psychology. Jung's theory of psychological types is perhaps the most influential creation in personality typology, and it has inspired many different theories. One of Jung's key contributions was the development of the concept of Introversion and Extraversion – he theorized that each of us falls into one of these two categories, either focusing on the internal world (Introvert) or the outside world (Extravert). Besides Introversion and Extraversion, Jung coined the concept of so-called cognitive functions, separated into Judging or Perceiving categories. According to Jung, each person prefers one of these cognitive functions and may most naturally rely on it in everyday situations.

In the 1920s, Jung's theory was noticed by Katharine Cook Briggs, who later co-authored one of the most popular personality indicators used today, the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator® (MBTI®). Briggs was a teacher with an avid interest in personality typing, having developed her own type theory before learning of Jung's writings. Together with her daughter, Isabel Briggs Myers, they developed a

convenient way to describe the order of each person's Jungian preferences – this is how four-letter acronyms were born.

Of course, this is just a very simplified description of the Myers-Briggs theory. Readers interested in learning more should read *Gifts Differing: Understanding Personality Type* by Isabel Briggs Myers. As we define personality traits and types differently in our model, we will not go deeper into Jungian concepts or related theories in this profile.

Due to its simplicity and ease of use, the four-letter naming model is now shared by a number of diverse theories and approaches, including Socionics, Keirsey Temperament Sorter®, and Linda Berens' Interaction Styles, among many others. While the acronyms used by these theories may be identical or very similar, however, their meanings do not always overlap. As a result, if you meet five people who say, "I am an INFJ," their understanding of what that means may vary significantly.

Regardless of its structure, any type-based theory will struggle to describe or characterize people whose scores lie near the dividing line. A different way to look at personalities is through the lens of a trait-based rather than a type-based model. What do we mean by that? Instead of creating an arbitrary number of categories and attempting to fit people within them, a trait-based model simply studies the degree to which people exhibit certain traits.

You may have heard the term Ambivert, which is a perfect example in this case. Ambiversion means that someone falls in the middle of the Introversiion-Extraversiion scale, being neither too outgoing nor too withdrawn. Trait-based theories would simply say that an Ambivert is moderately Extraverted or moderately Introverted and leave it at that, without assigning a personality type.

A trait-based approach makes it easier to reliably measure correlations between personality traits and other characteristics – for example, political attitudes. This is why trait-based approaches dominate psychometric research, but that’s more or less the only area where these approaches are dominant. Because they don’t offer types or categorizations, trait-based theories don’t translate as well as type-based theories into specific recommendations and takeaways. Assigned categories such as Extravert or Introvert may be limiting, but they allow us to conceptualize human personality and create theories about why we do what we do – something that a more scientifically reliable but colorless statement, such as you are 37% Extraverted, simply cannot do.

With our model, we’ve combined the best of both worlds. We use the acronym format introduced by Myers-Briggs for its simplicity and convenience, with an extra letter to accommodate five rather than four scales. However, unlike Myers-Briggs or other theories based on the Jungian model, we have not incorporated Jungian concepts such as cognitive functions, or their prioritization. Jungian concepts are very difficult to measure and evaluate scientifically, so we’ve instead chosen to rework and rebalance the dimensions of personality called the Big Five personality traits, a model that is very popular in psychological and social research.

Our personality types are based on five independent spectrums, with all letters in the type code (e.g. INFJ-A) referring to one of the two sides of the corresponding spectrum. We’ll talk more about these concepts in the next chapter. This approach has allowed us to achieve high test accuracy while also retaining the ability to define and describe distinct personality types.

During the last few years, we have conducted more than 800 studies to uncover trends and correlations between personality traits and various behaviors. Many of

these studies will be referenced in this profile, and additional information can be found in our [Academy](#). Our goal is to give you access to our sources without repeating ourselves or overwhelming you with information. If you are particularly interested in a specific study or its statistical characteristics, please feel free to contact us via our website, and we will do our best to provide additional information.

With that aside, let's dig deeper into the five personality aspects!

Five Personality Aspects

Mind: Introverted (I) vs. Extraverted (E)

The distinction between Introverts and Extraverts may be the oldest notion in the history of personality theories. It has long been observed that some people are expressive and outgoing, while others are reserved, quiet, and more comfortable alone. The first group recharges by engaging with the external world and communicating with other people, whereas members of the second group are energized by spending time alone and connecting with their own inner world.

We focus on these differences in our first scale, which we call Mind. This scale – which is based on a person's level of expressiveness and the degree to which he or she seeks external stimulation – determines how we see and approach the outside world, including people, objects, and activities. This scale correlates with a number of other personality traits, such as willingness to volunteer, desire to engage in thrill-seeking activities, and romantic assertiveness, to name just a few.

On one side of this scale, we have Introverted individuals (the I letter in the type acronym). You might associate Introversion with being private or withdrawn – or even clumsy or antisocial – but our studies show a far more complex picture. Generally speaking, Introverts do

not seek or require much external stimulation. As you might expect, an Introvert requires less communication with others than an Extravert would, but an Introvert's preference for less stimulation can also influence his or her hobbies, political attitudes, and even eating or drinking habits. To give a practical example, our studies have found that Introverts are less likely than Extraverts to enjoy coffee and energy drinks.



But what about Extraverts? Compared with Introverts, Extraverts are more interested in engaging with the people, objects, and environment around them. This preference manifests itself in many ways: Extraverts are less sensitive than Introverts to noise, for example,

and they are likelier to wear bright and colorful clothes. Extraverts not only tolerate external stimuli, however; they actually need these stimuli in order to support their own energy.

Extraverts are often energetic and willing to take the lead, especially in social situations. They enjoy pushing themselves to the limit and challenging themselves and those around them. Unlike Introverts, who are more cautious in their approach, Extraverts are likely to feel that they can handle life's challenges without much forethought. Whether that turns out to be true depends on many other circumstances, but overall, Extraverts tend to be more proactive in experiencing – and embracing – the world around them.

Worldwide, the three most Extraverted countries are Oman (61.66%), Yemen (59.44%), and Saudi Arabia (58.95%). The most Introverted countries are Japan (59.88%), Lithuania (55.85%), and Portugal (54.25%). In the United States, New York (50.92%), Mississippi (50.87%), and Illinois (50.64%) top the list for Extraverts, while West Virginia (53.62%), Alaska (53.6%), and Maine (53.41%) report the highest percentages of Introverts. Interestingly, if the District of Columbia were included in the comparisons, it would easily top the Extraverted list. In our study, the average Extraversion score for the capital city's 23,310 respondents was 53.06% – significantly above New York, its closest competitor.

Commanders are Extraverted – they tend feel recharged after spending time in the company of other people, and consequently often have excellent social skills. As Extraverts, Commanders enjoy taking the lead and speaking their mind, often going ahead and voicing their opinion as they develop it. People with this personality trait tend to instinctively connect with others, regardless of their background or personality, making them popular and well-liked in many circles.

Energy: Intuitive (N) vs. Observant (S)

Energy is the second scale in our model, and in our opinion it is the most important. While the other four scales determine how you interact with the world (Mind), make decisions (Nature), schedule your activities (Tactics), or react to external feedback (Identity), the Energy scale actually determines how you see the world and what kind of information you focus on.

All personality types can be divided into those that favor the Intuitive energy style and those that favor the Observant energy style. Intuitive individuals tend to be visionary, interested in ideas and abstractions, and attracted to novelty. Observant individuals, on the other hand, prefer facts, concrete and observable things, and the tried and true.

It is important to stress that this scale has nothing to do with how we absorb information: Intuitive and Observant types use their five senses equally well. Instead, this scale shows whether we focus on what is possible (making connections *intuitively*) or what is real (*observing* the environment). If you are familiar with the Big Five personality traits, you might recognize this scale as a reworking of the openness to experience concept, with a focus on preference for (and tolerance of) novelty and ambiguity.

Individuals with the Intuitive trait rely on their imaginations and think in terms of ideas and possibilities. They dream, fantasize, and question why things happen the way they do, always feeling slightly detached from the actual, concrete world. Although they observe other people and events, their minds remain directed both inwards and somewhere beyond – always questioning, wondering, and making

connections. When all is said and done, Intuitive types believe in novelty, in the open mind, and in never-ending improvement.

In one 16Personalities study, we asked people whether they wish they had been born in the Age of Discovery (roughly speaking, the 15th through the 18th centuries). Our results showed that Intuitive types were much more willing to give up the convenience, comfort, and predictability of modern life in exchange for the excitement of exploration, distant civilizations, and the undiscovered mysteries of the New World.



In contrast, individuals with the Observant trait focus on the actual world and things happening around them. Preferring to see, touch, feel, and experience, they are happy to leave theories and possibilities to others. They keep their feet on the ground and focus on the present, instead of wondering why or when something might happen. Consequently, people with this trait tend to be better at dealing with facts, tools, and concrete objects as opposed to brainstorming, theorizing about future events, or handling abstract theories. Observant types are also significantly better at focusing on just one thing at a time instead of juggling multiple activities.

The Energy scale influences communication style as well. Intuitive individuals talk about ideas and have no difficulties with allusions or reading between the lines, while Observant types focus on facts and practical matters. This is why Intuitive types may find it challenging to understand someone with the Observant trait, and vice versa. Intuitive types may think that Observant individuals are materialistic, unimaginative, and simplistic, and Observant types may see their Intuitive conversation partner as impractical, naïve, and absent-minded. These assumptions and biases can be quite damaging, and it takes a mature person to get past them.

Geographically, the Middle East and Asia have the largest percentage of Observant individuals, with 8 countries in the top 10 list. Saudi Arabia (71.94%), Oman (71.03%), and Yemen (69.76%) have the top scores among Observant countries, while Nepal (48.92%), Albania (48.51%) and Maldives (48.44%) top the Intuitive table.

In the United States, North Dakota (59.43%), Minnesota (59.23%), and Iowa (59.04%) are the most Observant states. On the opposite side of the table, we have Nevada (43.92%), Rhode Island (43.75%), and West Virginia (43.47%).

Commanders are Intuitive individuals. This is why they are so good at seeing possibilities and honoring different points of view. People with this personality type spend more time engaging in various internal discussions than observing things around them. Commanders are not that concerned about what *is* happening; instead, they focus on what *might* happen or *why* something has happened. Commanders hone this focus throughout their lives, which makes them passionate and insightful thinkers.

Of course, every stick has two ends, and focus on novelty and change comes at a cost. By directing their mental resources toward possibilities and the future, Commanders

inevitably lose sight of what is happening around them. They may have difficulties dealing with practical matters or data. If they aren't paying attention, they may even miss something right under their nose. Because the majority of the population has the Observant trait, Commanders may have difficulty finding a partner and connecting with others.

Nature: Thinking (T) vs. Feeling (F)

The third scale, which we call Nature, determines how we make decisions and cope with emotions. While we all have feelings, there are significant differences in how different types react to them. This scale influences a number of areas of our lives, particularly our interactions with other people.



People with the Thinking trait seek logic and rational arguments, relying on their head rather than their heart. They do their best to safeguard, manage, and conceal their emotions. “Whatever happens, you must always keep a cool head” – this is the motto of Thinking individuals. These

types are not cold-blooded or indifferent, however. People with the Thinking trait are often just as emotional as those with the Feeling trait, but they subdue or override their feelings with their rational logic.

In several of our studies, we analyzed the attitudes of different personality types toward philanthropy and charitable causes. Thinking types are significantly less likely to engage in charitable giving or to be touched by charities’ emotional appeals. Does

this mean that they are unwilling to help? Not necessarily. It turns out that Thinking personalities don't believe that giving money to charity is the best way to make a difference. They may look for other ways to be of assistance – for example, investing in education for the disadvantaged.

In contrast, people with the Feeling trait follow their hearts and care little about hiding their emotions. From their perspective, we should not be afraid to listen to our innermost feelings and share them with the world. These individuals tend to be compassionate, sensitive, and highly emotional. They would rather cooperate than compete, although they are not naïve or easily swayed.

In fact, people with the Feeling trait are likely to fight tooth and nail for their values and beliefs. For many Feeling types, principles and ideals are much more important than, say, professional success. Although this perspective might not seem rational, Feeling types generally adhere to their own highly individualized – and perfectly valid – logic.



Worldwide, Iran (51.91%), Georgia (50.74%), and Albania (48.94%) report highest scores on the Thinking side of the scale. On the Feeling side, we have Singapore (61.41%), Australia (60.1%), and New Zealand (59.98%).

In the U.S., northern states tend to be slightly more Feeling, but not significantly so. One interesting example is the contrast between Utah and Nevada: two neighboring states that are each first on opposite sides of the scale. In Utah, the average score is

61.19% on the Feeling side, well above Minnesota (59.61%) and Idaho (59.54%), which take second and third place, respectively. Nevada, on the other hand, is the most Thinker-heavy state in our study, with its 34,576 respondents getting an average score of 42.99% on the Thinking side of the spectrum. While that still means Feeling personality types outnumber Thinking types significantly, we rarely see such differences between neighboring regions. Other top Thinking states include Delaware (42.71%) and New Mexico (42.7%).

Commanders have the Thinking trait. These types trust and prioritize logic, and they rely on rational arguments over emotional appeals. They try to keep their true feelings and emotions deep below the surface, and focus instead on what can be assessed, compared, and verified.

Individuals with the Thinking trait, like Commanders, bring tremendous value to enterprises that need careful assessment and calculation to succeed. Unfortunately, for all the good it represents, the Thinking trait may distance Commanders from much of the population, as connecting at an emotional level takes more effort for these intellectual types.

Tactics: Judging (J) vs. Prospecting (P)

The Tactics scale determines how we approach planning and how we handle available options. The implications reach well beyond our calendars, however. At its core, this scale determines our attitudes toward certainty and structure in our lives.

People with the Judging trait do not like to keep their options open. They would rather prepare five different contingency plans than wait for challenges to arise. These individuals enjoy clarity and closure, always sticking to the plan rather than going

with the flow. It's as if Judging types keep a mental checklist, and once a decision is crossed off that list, it is not open to reassessment. This mentality applies as much to grocery shopping as it does to life goals, like buying a house.



Individuals with the Judging trait tend to have a strong work ethic, putting their duties and responsibilities above all else. Our research indicates that Judging types are also strict when it comes to law and order. Of course, this doesn't mean that Prospecting individuals

are lawbreakers, but if you see someone go out of his or her way to use a crosswalk, that person is likely a Judging type.

In contrast, Prospecting individuals are flexible and relaxed when it comes to dealing with both expected and unexpected challenges. They are always scanning for opportunities and options, willing to jump at a moment's notice. People with this trait understand that life is full of possibilities, and they are reluctant to commit to something that might prove an inferior option in the future. They also focus more on what makes them happy than what their parents, employers, or teachers expect. If a specific task is not particularly important or interesting, a Prospecting individual will always come up with something better to do.



Looking at the geographical data, the global Judging-Prospecting chart has interesting similarities with the Extraverted-Introverted one. While these scales do not influence each other from a statistical perspective, many of the countries topping the Extraverted-Introverted charts have correspondingly high Judging-Prospecting scores. At the top of the Judging table we have Oman (58.05%), Yemen (57.78%), and Kuwait (55.8%), while the most Prospecting countries are Japan (55.21%), Nepal (53.74%), and Lithuania (53.62%).

The map of the United States, however, does not show significant overlaps between these two scales. On the Judging side of the spectrum, we have South Carolina (51.05%), Alabama (50.97%), and Tennessee (50.8%). On the other side, the most Prospecting states are Alaska (51.2%), Vermont (50.86%), and West Virginia (50.76%).

Commanders are Judging individuals. Decisive and proactive, they often find it difficult to cope with uncertainty and unpredictability. This is what makes Commanders not just visionaries, but also implementers, both willing and able to bring their ideas to life. That being said, people with this personality type are not overly meticulous or rule-bound. They seek closure rather than obsess over tiny details or procedures. Commanders are idea people rather than logisticians.

Identity: Assertive (-A) vs. Turbulent (-T)

The last scale, Identity, affects all others, reflecting how confident we are in our abilities and decisions. In a way, this scale acts as an internal sensor, reacting to the input we get from our environments – for instance, success or failure, feedback from others, or pressure caused by unexpected events. The Mind and Identity scales are the alpha and the omega of our model, acting as an external shell that we wear in all of our interactions with the outside world. Later, we will discuss the four possible

combinations of these traits, which we call “Strategies,” but in the meantime, let’s take an in-depth look at the Identity scale.



Assertive individuals are self-assured, even-tempered, and resistant to stress. They refuse to worry too much, and they don’t push themselves too hard when it comes to achieving goals. Similarly, they are unlikely to spend much time thinking about past actions or

choices. According to Assertive types, what’s done is done and there is little point in analyzing it. Not surprisingly, people with this trait are generally satisfied with their lives, and they feel confident in their ability to handle challenging and unexpected situations.

In contrast, Turbulent individuals are self-conscious and sensitive to stress. They experience a wide range of emotions and tend to be success-driven, perfectionistic, and eager to improve. Always feeling the need to do more, have more, and *be* more, Turbulent types may forget how exhausting this dissatisfaction can be – both for themselves and for the people around them.



While the Assertive variant may seem more positive on the surface, that is not necessarily the case. Turbulent individuals are more willing than Assertive types to change jobs if they feel stuck in their current roles, and they think deeply about the direction of their lives. Turbulent individuals may also outperform Assertive types in certain instances, because they may care more about the outcome. The willingness of Turbulent types to push themselves may ultimately enable them to achieve their goals.

Worldwide, Japan is by far the most Turbulent country, with an average score of 57.48% on the Turbulent side. Italy (53.8%) and Brunei (52.89%) come in second and third, respectively. On the Assertive side of the spectrum, we have Uganda (57.91%), Barbados (57.11%), and Nigeria (57.01%).

In the United States, there is a clear east-west divide, with the East Coast being significantly more Turbulent. West Virginia (49.3%) takes the lead on the Turbulent side, followed by Rhode Island (48.84%) and Maine (48.73%). The most Assertive states are New Mexico (54.7%), Colorado (54.66%), and Hawaii (54.28%).

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

Our system has two layers: the first (inner) one defines our Roles, the second (outer) one, our Strategies.

Roles

The Role layer determines our goals, interests, and preferred activities. Each of the four Roles covers a set of personality types that are very similar, and we will use these groups later in this profile to draw contrasts and similarities between personalities. They also serve to highlight the importance we have placed on the Energy trait. Each personality type will share either the Observant or the Intuitive trait with all other members of their group, as well as one other key trait. Commanders belong to the Analyst Role group, along with three other personality types: Architects, Logicians, and Debaters.

Analysts

Shared traits: *Intuitive* and *Thinking*

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects, Logicians, Commanders, and Debaters – embrace rationality, excelling in intellectual and technological pursuits. The Thinking trait makes Analysts exacting, and the Intuitive trait lets them apply their minds to almost anything, with their imaginations aiding calculated, strategic thinking, or seeing just how far the rabbit hole goes with a crazy scheme or thought experiment.

These personalities are driven to understand and create, and have no problem switching between speculative musing and frank, solutions-oriented approaches to whatever problems are at hand. Broad, intelligent vision gives Analysts an ingenious air, but they can become overwhelmed and scattered if they don't learn to hone these abilities and use them to advance a worthwhile cause or project.

The biggest pitfall is that their intellect can give them a false sense of accomplishment. They tend to prefer the world of ideas to the sober reality of follow-through, and by assuming the role of critic instead of participant, Analysts sometimes risk being functionally outpaced by those who simply sit down and do the work. They can earn themselves the unsavory title of “armchair analysts” while those with more real-world experience continue to create real results. Analyst personality types can lack a proper respect for those of simpler vision and expression, whatever their background, and it can hold them back.

Analysts value their intellect above all else, and it can be a challenge convincing them it’s worth checking their many hypotheses with an experiment or proper evidence to be sure. To many Analysts, if something makes sense in their minds, that’s as good as proved, and a great deal faster. Analysts can be brilliant, but they’re still human; under the influence of ego, these personality types can get in the habit of advancing clever opinions instead of objective facts.

Analysts’ positive self-identity stems largely from their formidable drive to learn, and their clever and sharply witty banter can make them excellent debate partners. Often insatiable readers as well, Analysts can be found stockpiling books, questioning teachers, and driving conversations in forums across the world wide web. These types prefer their own processes and pace, and are energized by exercising their minds on their own time.

Analysts are also relentless self-improvers. Once they’ve recognized a flaw, they apply all of this cold rationality, honest reflection, imagination, and desire for results to make it right. Analysts’ forceful, imaginative vision, when trained and focused, enables these personalities to conceive and accomplish things most thought impossible.

Diplomats

Shared traits: *Intuitive* and *Feeling*

Diplomats – Advocates, Mediators, Protagonists, and Campaigners – tend to be warm, caring, and generous individuals, shining in diplomacy and counselling. These personality types promote cooperation and harmony, tolerating discord only as a step towards positive change. Their perceptive abilities seemingly go deeper than the traditional senses – it's as if they have a full set of tuning forks in their hearts that can resonate with people's emotional states, and this empathetic sensitivity creates deep connections with others.

This is not as mystical as it can seem. Diplomat personalities deeply value understanding, and a lifetime of self-reflection grants them insights into others' motivations that they might not even understand themselves. Diplomats can use this to shape the way others feel, but it would be out of character for them to use this for ill.

Diplomats' people skills nurture friendship and healing with pure, genuine empathy. Causing distress feels to them like wounding their own psyche, so they prefer to gently nudge loved ones and strangers alike in a positive direction. Diplomats find the ideals of humanism rewarding: kindness, understanding, altruism, and growth warm them like a bonfire on a chilly autumn day. These personality types envision a prismatic, kind world.

The Intuitive trait plays a big part in this optimism, but it also makes Diplomats sensitive to injustices that would jeopardize that ideal world. They can be aggressive against forces they perceive as evil, and are capable of steely action when they feel they have moral high ground. Diplomats' sensitive emotions may flare to outright

combativeness if provoked; with self-righteous momentum and weighty ideals, these personality types can steamroll others. If they let inspiration trump rationality unchecked, they can sometimes go too far, damaging the very causes they hold dear, however justified the outrage.

Tempering this passion with cold practicality is a challenge for Diplomats. They are often reluctant to make and carry out tough decisions or plans lacking in empathy, and often struggle with carrying out a plan at all. They find greater satisfaction in abstract self-exploration and understanding the issues that affect those least able to defend themselves than mundane accomplishments and day-to-day tasks. Diplomats emphasize experience and understanding rather than calculable achievement.

Among friends and family, Diplomat personalities can range from quietly caring to brightly gregarious, so long as they can pursue the mutual exchange of thoughts and feelings they value so highly. But they can overextend themselves in this more personal aspect of their lives as well – emotionally, physically, or even financially. Diplomats' open hearts make them vulnerable when others aren't as considerate, though they wouldn't have it any other way. Someone must trust first, and they will almost always be the volunteer.

Diplomats embrace travel as readily as anyone – they like exploring other cultures and people's colorful ways. These personality types are creatively inclined, often practicing artistic expression in diverse forms, and see magical beauty where others see the hum-drum of daily life. For a group with such progressive attitudes, they also appreciate seeing things as they are, a pure expression of a way of thinking and being. Diplomats can be passionately inspired by experiences: music, cuisine, theater,

nature, and anything else that goes beyond the obvious can rise to divine art in their eyes.

Like a gardener planting in fertile earth, Diplomats seed the world around them with progressive change and gentle beauty. Diplomats feel connected to forces they may not fully understand, a deep sense of faith that may express itself, if not always through traditional religion, as spiritual belief. Diplomats pursue things with an underlying idealism and a sense of higher purpose; activism, spirituality, healing, the arts, and charity are common interests for these personalities. They have a conviction to serve a greater good, motivated by intangible rewards felt in the heart and soul.

Sentinels

Shared traits: *Observant* and *Judging*

Sentinels – Logisticians, Defenders, Executives, and Consuls – are cooperative and practical. Their grounded approach helps them feel comfortable with who they are, defining themselves not by individualism, but by character and competence. These personality types seek order, security, and stability, and tend to work hard to maintain the way of things, leading to a deserved reputation as the core of any group or organization, from family to church to the office and the factory floor.

These types embrace teamwork, but expect the same performance and respectability from others that they strive for themselves. Sentinels often dislike strident nonconformity because they envision progress through collaboration and hard work within a known set of rules – to let everyone do their own thing on a whim would be anarchy. Sentinels prefer proven methods and honest accomplishment to self-indulgent exploration and esoteric ideas. Because these personalities are deeply

prudent, they also tend to be self-motivated, and rarely need external inspiration to be productive.

Their grounded perspective leaves little room for random musings, but Sentinels are not unimaginative. They experiment for anticipated gain rather than intellectual thrills, and excel in making challenging situations work. Revolution does not appeal to people from this Role, who tend to learn from the past and remain loyal to the tested truths and traditions they were brought up with. Where some see fascinating philosophy, Sentinels may see preposterousness: these personality types favor practiced methodology over abstract theory.

Having authority allows Sentinels to practice their virtues. Effective in leadership roles, these types motivate others by energetic example and feel satisfaction from guiding a well-functioning group – they tend to make excellent teachers, managers, and community officials, as well as parents and hosts. These personalities are meticulous and traditional, excelling in logistical and administrative fields with clear hierarchies and rules as well. Opting for successful completion whenever they can, Sentinels can be controlling, but gladly compromise when needed to get things done.

Sentinels feel rewarded by shepherding others, and enjoy coordinating and sharing fun social experiences with friends and family. They believe it is their responsibility to give their families safe, happy lives that prepare them for the real world. An appreciation of strong relationships allows them to share generously with those they respect and love – these types feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and will do what they can to make sure they hold up their end of the bargain. Birthdays, dinner parties, and camping trips are delightful events under their enthusiastic direction.

These personality types are happiest without drama, though their admirably stubborn loyalty can certainly attract it if they feel they need to stand by a friend, regardless of whether they're in the right or wrong. Inconsistent people can test Sentinels' tolerance and provoke harsh judgement. Sentinels tend to prefer predictability over novelty and familiar pleasures more than cutting-edge excitement. It can be difficult for Sentinel personalities to accept people who lack their studious ideals, but they often respond as engaged and caring mentors to those who wish to grow in that direction.

Explorers

Shared traits: *Observant and Prospecting*

Explorers – Virtuosos, Adventurers, Entrepreneurs, and Entertainers – possess a self-reliant mix of enthusiasm, quick thinking, and ingenuity that can lead to impressive personal and professional accomplishments. Comfortable with uncertainty and minimally concerned with preparation, these personality types simply adapt and overcome as events present themselves. Explorers' flexibility helps them make snap decisions in the moment, and they're unlikely to dwell on the future or the past.

They aren't obsessed with precise detail (unless they're really in the zone, in which case they can muster a level of precision and focus that would make a seasoned engineer blush). Usually, they require workability rather than perfection. Explorer personalities are utilitarian masters of diverse tools and techniques, ranging from instruments and engines to the art of persuasion, and they distinguish themselves in crises, crafts, and sales.

This versatile decisiveness doesn't mean commitment, however. Explorers can change their minds with minimal regret or second-guessing. People in this Role

dislike monotony, and often feel tempted to stray from obligations in favor of entertaining new things. They experiment with many interests and live and breathe whatever they connect with – for a time. If these personality types sometimes leave business unfinished, let clutter build up, or misplace important things, it's because they've moved on to something fresh.

Explorers enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. An Explorer might design and build their own dream house, enthralled with the process, but end up procrastinating on simple repairs after a few years. They are highly motivated when steering themselves through something interesting, but don't like being restrained by anything “mandatory.”

Their relaxed, free-form attitude makes Explorer personalities socially dynamic as well. They often seek out people and experiences that cater to their senses, finding more pleasure in stimulation than planning. They happily approach appealing strangers and interesting experiences, and when things get in the way of a good time, they apply their ingenuity to getting around it. Explorers want to see what happens next!

The same themes run through their friendships and families, though these relationships have much more staying power than most other interests. Rather than forcing relationships into or out of existence though, Explorers let things flow naturally according to their desires. Compatible people simply become a part of their lives. These personality types tend to be individualistic and freedom-loving, going their own way with little regard for naysayers, but they do enjoy knowing that the people they trust will be around in the end.

Explorers are highly spontaneous, connecting with and adapting to their environment in a way that is almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. It can be a challenge for them to work for things with a distant or unexciting payoff, as they need a sense of immediacy to feel truly engaged, but when they are passionate, Explorer personalities can move heaven and earth.

Strategies

The Strategy layer reflects our preferred ways of doing things and achieving our goals. There are four strategies: Confident Individualism, People Mastery, Constant Improvement, and Social Engagement. Depending on their type variant, Commanders fall under either People Mastery (Assertive Commanders) or Social Engagement (Turbulent Commanders).

Confident Individualism

Shared traits: *Introverted* and *Assertive*

Confident Individualists typically trust in themselves, and they often embrace solitude to pursue their own interests rather than seeking out social activity. Fascinated by personal projects, people following this Strategy often have an impressive range of skills and interesting ideas. But projects are usually only pursued for their own merit – Confident Individualists tend to feel that social displays and bragging are time and energy wasted. These personality types are proud of who they are, what they know, and what they can do, but they don't feel the need to prove themselves to others.

Confident Individualists engage their internal inspiration instead of searching for motivation outside themselves. They favor privacy, and aren't particularly fond of

interacting with society, whether in a strictly social sense or when embracing broader societal goals. These personalities often favor substance over superficiality and personal honesty over playing along, and prefer a utilitarian approach, even when pursuing esoteric goals.

This utilitarianism also means that Confident Individualists are not easily drawn into emotional drama. They hold their own opinions firmly, but tend to see little reason to try to convince others. When drama does arise, these personality types express their truth with little concern over whether they'll cause friction or offense. Confident Individualists tend to endorse self-reliance over cooperation, and are rarely pressured into agreeing with or lending support to others unless they believe in the cause.

This relaxed self-assurance means that Confident Individualists may not push their boundaries. Their live-and-let-live attitude goes both ways: they don't need to convince others, and they tend to expect others to return the favor. While highly capable, they can miss information and opportunities that challenge their views because they simply don't place much importance on factoring in others' approval. They can be tolerant in disagreement though, respecting others' individualism just as they respect their own.

When these personality types form friendships, they tend to be strong and honest. Because these types don't feel like they need other people's approval, their loyalty and affection is a deliberate expression of affection. Impressing a Confident Individualist earns their respect and care, and these types make for dedicated, passionate friends.

Self-reliance is central for these types, and they handle difficult situations well because they tend to be emotionally secure, bold, and resistant to stress. They rarely seek leadership or the spotlight, but when they do find themselves in these positions, these personalities lead by an example of self-determination and uncomplicated honesty – they appreciate grace, class, and form, and rarely seek to impress by appearances alone. When acting with knowledge and wisdom, Confident Individualists can be noble pillars of strength.

People Mastery

Shared traits: *Extraverted* and *Assertive*

People Masters are highly stress-resistant, maintaining confidence through life's challenges, social pressures, and any questions of their capabilities. These personality types seek social contact and have solid communication skills, feeling at ease when relying on or directing other people. People Masters' mantra is fearless engagement – to be is to do. This is not a group known for its timid opinions or idleness.

People Masters feel rewarded by stimulation and challenging experiences. They like travelling to see things, people, and places, where they can experience a richer understanding of the world around them. These personalities like sampling new foods, lifestyles, and cultures; even things they don't end up liking can be entertaining excitement for them.

Sometimes, though, People Masters are too confident. Insulated against self-doubt and the need to prove themselves, they don't always test, or even consider, their own limits or ambitions. They can slip into a pattern of endless fun and comfort-seeking, rolling their eyes at those who press themselves towards more intimidating goals. At

the other end of the spectrum, these personality types can just as easily ignore sensible caution, putting themselves in extraordinary and dangerous situations, confident they can find their way through.

Most fall somewhere in the middle, embracing healthy ambition and competition so long as they play a meaningful part in social circles and leadership. Social interaction plays a big part in People Masters' happiness. While not dependent on people's approval for emotional security, they appreciate acclaim for their accomplishments and bright personalities, and can be a touch showy from time to time. These types are self-confident, but they are often lost without people to lead, laugh with, and love.

Their charisma, self-assurance and boisterousness can sometimes be trying qualities. People Masters prefer cooperation, but have few qualms about dominating their opposition to achieve their goals, boldly promoting themselves and using their social skills to get ahead. This Strategy understands people's needs, but can just as easily use this as a weapon rather than a tool of compassion if they have their sights set on something big.

People Masters can compromise when needed, but these personality types tend to be better talkers than listeners. They can be very demanding, criticizing people's performance regardless of their feelings because they expect no less of themselves. That said, these types are moderate in their disagreements because their ego and confidence aren't at stake the way they often are for Turbulent Strategies. People Masters are not fond of grudges, content to let bygones be bygones. They are more likely to be socially idealistic, with the intent of bringing people together to make things happen – petty grievances just get in the way.

People Masters' charismatic virtues shine in social contexts, and these types have little fear of rejection and a passion for inclusion. They prefer to take the lead, but sharing the journey through other people's eyes enhances their own enjoyment as well. People Masters share in all aspects of people's lives, making these personalities strong, honest friends, parents, spouses, and colleagues, serving as wellsprings of energy, joy, and mutual success.

Constant Improvement

Shared traits: *Introverted* and *Turbulent*

Constant Improvers are sensitive and contemplative individuals who enjoy having their own space and freedom. They are often deep and creative individuals, though often tense and more comfortable on their own than mixed up in the judgment of the real world. With the two personality traits most representative of a sensitivity to their environment – Introversion and Turbulence – they are reserved when dealing with strangers or new situations, often turning inwards or focusing on peacekeeping instead.

These personalities' caution in the face of unfamiliar challenges can sometimes look like a lack of motivation, but this is usually just self-doubt – Constant Improvers have a strong drive, but it comes paired with a strong fear of failure. They invest a great deal of their identity in their successes, and even a minor misstep or embarrassment can be crushing.

The vigilance learned from a lifetime of ups and downs gives these personality types a knack for sensing trouble. This is a strategic wariness that can be quite useful in situations that need to balance risk and reward, whether a financial investment or a romantic opportunity. Though they can seem frustratingly over-cautious to others,

Constant Improvers would rather not face calamity, so they excel at avoiding it with preventive insights.

Since they aren't always comfortable with energetic exchanges with other people, Constant Improvers often direct their attention elsewhere, striving to master hobbies, careers, bodies of knowledge, or new means of self-expression. Their restless drive, self-doubt, and solitary mentality can combine to create impressive, beautiful results.

High-achieving and perfectionistic, Constant Improvers generally try to do their best in their endeavors, dedicating tremendous time and energy. These personalities can put so much pressure on themselves that they diminish their own impressive accomplishments by fixating on the slightest flaws or dismissing successes as luck rather than skill or dedication.

Taken too far, this perfectionism can also drive endless rumination – an unhealthy obsession with perfection will reveal flaws in the best plans, and Constant Improvers often feel forced to abandon a course of action because something doesn't line up right. Whether working feverishly or picking at the threads of an idea though, Constant Improvers can be intense about their goals, and progress towards internal balance can lead them to amazing personal accomplishments.

Alongside their personal efforts, these personality types also care a great deal what others think of them. This can be very useful, but they can take this to a fault: fixating on others' expectations can sour social efforts into awkwardness. Constant Improvers are easily thrown off-balance by conflict, and may communicate timidly, or not at all, for fear of hurting people's feelings, provoking a confrontation, or looking the fool.

Sometimes it takes peer approval and active encouragement for this Strategy group to recognize their own virtues. These personalities often benefit from friends and colleagues patient enough to get to know them and who give them a chance to speak their minds. When treated considerately, these types become devoted partners and begin to reveal their kindness, insights, heartfelt support, and the complexities of their approach to the world, from sometimes (oddly specific) plans for obscure situations to starry-eyed ambitions.

Social Engagement

Shared traits: *Extraverted* and *Turbulent*

Those with the Social Engagement Strategy are an interesting group. In some ways, Extraversion and Turbulence conflict with each other: Extraversion leads to risk-tolerance and boldness; Turbulence reflects self-doubt and sensitivity. Turbulence also contributes to impulsivity, which Extraversion makes highly visible. This means Social Engagers tend to do what comes naturally first and think about it later. In this way, they are almost an exaggeration of their underlying personality types. This isn't a bad thing.

Social Engagers enthusiastically engage the external world, not content to live in their minds, drawing emotional security from positive interactions. In business and among loved ones, these types are usually the center of attention. Social Engagers meet the needs of the crowd in social settings, but they sometimes hide their true selves to impress other people. They appreciate social status, and often portray themselves as the person they aspire to – usually a purer form of their personality type – in order to achieve it.

Social Engagers often experience stunning highs and lows as their Extraversion pushes their Turbulent need for success into overdrive and their Turbulence creates an immediate sense of regret, warranted or not. These personality types can be surprisingly competitive, measuring themselves against peers and hoping others notice their accomplishments, then retreat, suddenly becoming averse to conflict, leading them to apologize for or avoid confrontations – even those that ended in beneficial discussions.

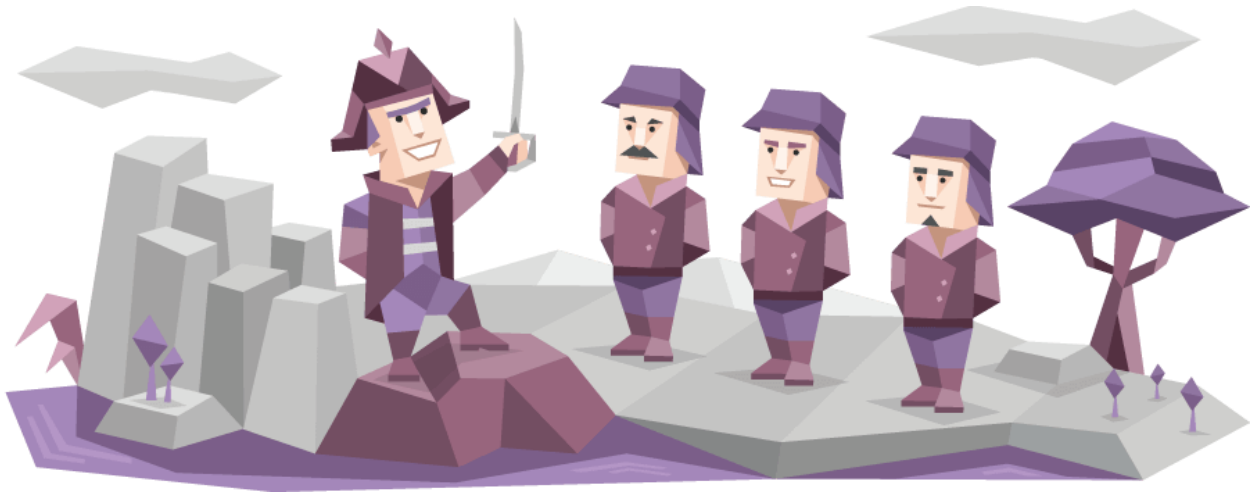
These personalities may falter occasionally in their self-confidence, but ultimately they are driven to improve and achieve. At the end of the day, they have no trouble blowing off some steam and enjoying a much-needed break, either. Social Engagers enthusiastically pursue stimulating and exciting experiences, especially with a group of friends. They much prefer to dive into an experience than to sit down for a reserved evaluation, though many will naturally regret their hot-headed lack of planning down the road.

This push and pull between ambition and alarm, impulse and caution, highs and lows can itself be quite stressful, but it's all part of this Strategy's charm. These personality types are often restless in pursuit of their goals to improve their circumstances, but show their passion by indulging their desires through some earned fun (and maybe shopping for something impressive). Social Engagers work hard at their personal and professional development, striving to meet all manner of stringent standards, but they lead dynamic lives as well, filled with companionship, sharing adventures and accomplishments with others whenever possible. Whatever direction they pull, they are sure to pull the crowd with them.

While the Strategies are important, this series of e-books simply doesn't have the space to explore them properly. For now, we'll focus on the inner core: The four Roles.

Look to future updates to the series and the Academy to see this aspect explored more fully.

Who Is “The Commander?”



Throughout this book, we'll discuss how Commanders' traits manifest themselves into this complete personality type. The interactions between these traits result in a unique set of behaviors that are examined concerning their effects on personal growth, friendship, parenthood, romantic relationships, and academic and professional development. The following paragraphs are a brief overview of the Commander personality type – each section is explored in much greater detail in subsequent chapters.

Personal Growth

As Analysts, Commanders have a strong affinity for logic and creativity, but they also display unique qualities of their Judging and Extraversion traits – they like to act decisively. Commanders don't stop at hypothetical scenarios and thought experiments, using their imaginations to create the groundwork for purposeful, immediate applications as well as elaborate projects down the line. These types are less prone to imaginative distraction than other Analysts, making them energetic,

visionary, and, in a word, *intense*. They strongly express their ideas, but aren't as easily flexible when encountering alternate or conflicting ways of thinking.

These types truly revel in shaping their environment, but they also benefit from practicing openness: sharing their ideas and, in turn, learning from others. Bold – and often blunt – in word and deed, Commanders who balance their expressions of will with concern for the needs of others invite mutual respect that promotes achievement and intellectual growth instead of authoritarianism. These types' appreciation of discipline helps them temper their sometimes-fierce natures with inquisitiveness, kindness, and objectivity about their limits, and such personal growth is a worthy lifelong challenge for all Commanders.

Friends, Family, and Romantic Relationships

Few types can match the strength that Commanders offer those they love, as their intellect, imagination, and determination can be used to support the people they're close to – and they often enjoy being such a hub in their social world. Of course, developing bonds with people can depend on how they present their energy, and these types often put minimal emphasis on emotional understanding. While they might offer solid and sincere virtues, Commanders aren't always very delicate or sensitive in the way they relate to friends, family, and romantic partners.

As energetic idealists, they can be deeply caring, but often unconsciously forego empathy in favor of what feels like a more rational solution. Despite their best intentions, this can create disconnection – or even disaffection – at times. Concerned with social standing, though, Commanders have good reason to value others' feedback. Consciously developing and utilizing emotional intelligence skills helps these types create extremely rewarding social bonds by letting them both give and

receive forms of energy from love, tenderness, and joy to exuberant, witty humor and constructive criticism. When it comes to those they love, Commanders' firm principles can lead them to prioritize the well-being of others and stand as kind guardians.

Academic and Professional Development

Commanders are often driven people, excited to put their ideas to work and seek out situations that test their intellects and limits. In school or at work, these types achieve as much as they let themselves. Demonstrating their capabilities gives them a magnetism that often invites others to follow their lead, and as elements in a group, these types can be inspiring and charismatic, helping everyone achieve more than they thought was possible. Few types can match them when it comes to determined persistence in pursuit of a goal; Commanders quickly assess what they want and how to get it, and they have the energy to make their desires a reality. It's not uncommon for these types to earn leadership positions.

These types excel at seeing how moving pieces can align most efficiently, even when those moving pieces consist of unique minds and seemingly irrational behaviors. Although Commanders can be hard on people – including themselves – rational objectivity compels them to be fair. Although they rarely think twice about criticizing others they believe have fallen short, they tend to clearly communicate their expectations. Consciously building mutually rewarding social and intellectual cooperation in class or on the job gives Commanders the best chance of success in life.

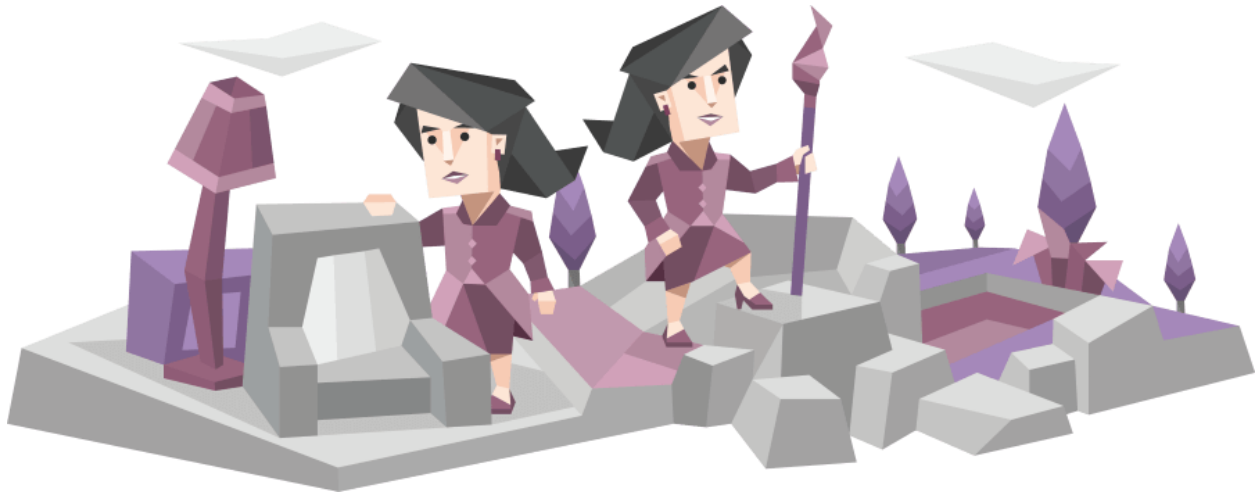
To these types, the world often seems cut and dried, a place of losers and winners, and they strive to be in the latter camp. No other personality type is better suited to

forging a positive future for themselves – and others. Firm and creative, they aren't content with complacency or ignoring areas of themselves where they can improve, always wanting to better themselves and improve the world around them through lofty vision and vigorous action.

On That Note...

This e-book is designed to help Commanders in their mission, combining in-depth insights and advice tailored to these powerful and compelling types. This introduction provides only a brief outline of their potential strengths and weaknesses, and in the following chapters, we'll present much greater detail and provide further information as well as suggestions for improvement in each of these areas. Understanding one's personality type is incredibly valuable, and we hope that the following information proves useful.

Personal Growth



Commanders' Decision to Grow

Personal growth isn't some theoretical veneer of self-satisfaction – that would seem useless to Commanders, who revere functional action. Personal growth is about judiciously assessing life and deliberately making useful changes by developing abilities that enable progress. It's about striving to become the best possible version of oneself, including finding a personal determination of what that means. No set of ideals or goals fits all people, even of the same type, so it's important that personal growth reflects the true needs of the individual.

For Commanders, growth is often about expanding beyond rigid structure to explore alternative possibilities. It's not about changing their essential personalities, but rather learning to optimize their abilities with interdisciplinary broadness – truly optimal approaches often require significant flexibility and continual evolution to stay at their peak. A carefully objective sense of self helps people with this personality type expand personal limits and act on their potential. It all starts with being willing

to look inward to recognize what's balanced, respected, and achieved – and what could be improved.

Sharp assessments come easily to Commanders, but their views often lack suppleness, as they strive to build unassailable positions and stable practices through authoritative engagement. There's a certain strength in this way of living, but it also makes it difficult for Commanders to change themselves – or even admit when change is needed. Certainty may feel like an asset, but balancing their consistent decisiveness with a truly open mind – and heart – is one of the most important areas of personal growth for these types.

Developing Healthy Perspectives

Often, a major source of unhappiness in Commanders' lives is the contrast between the intellectual ideals they push for and the realities of the external world that don't align with their vision. People with this personality type try to mold things as they see fit, and they may become frustrated at anything they perceive as getting in their way. Acceptance and allowance aren't easy for Commanders to muster, especially when they think that something is right, wrong, or could be better – which they often do.

Trying to force things into conformity with their own conclusions can become a lifelong battle for Commanders. But personal growth isn't only about exercising their own potential to the fullest – it's also about evolving expectations beyond unproductive extremity. Nothing, and no one, is perfect all the time, and even the most perfectionist and powerful Commanders can lighten the pressure on themselves and others by recognizing that fact.

These types rarely give up, and when they learn to evaluate – and value – themselves based on the merit of their efforts instead of static benchmarks, they may find that

progress, success, and happiness can be ongoing. Personal growth isn't defined by measuring oneself against external standards; it's created by acting wisely on the potential of any given moment to forge life as masterfully as possible.

Fulfillment and Development

Commanders can build a more fulfilling life by focusing on five related, but distinct, motivational aspects of personal growth. Because they're Judging types, much of what defines their happiness is based on control and structure. However, their Intuitive trait also makes them hungry for understanding, creative expression, and future progress. For Commanders, mastering a balance between exerting their highly specific visions and reshaping themselves when needed is critical to their personal growth – and happiness.

Real growth starts with an objective evaluation of whether their behavior is satisfying and effective or not. Then they can create options for improvement by reformulating their attitudes and actions. Not all personal growth is the product of deliberate effort, though; sometimes it emerges naturally from ongoing maturity, is prompted by challenges and crises, or is learned from wise people. Commanders benefit from keeping their minds open to unexpected sources of knowledge. As the saying goes, "You're either getting better, or you're getting worse. There is no staying the same."

Let's define the five motivational aspects in brief.

Personal Fulfillment

- **Self-esteem** is how well Commanders like themselves. Everyone is affected by their feelings, so accepting both their flaws and strengths builds a secure foundation from which they can proceed happily.

- **Self-respect** speaks to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value rational action, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows accordingly.
- **Self-confidence** is the energy that helps Commanders maintain momentum in life. When belief in their own abilities is affirmed through positive action, Commanders have boundless vigor.

Active Development

- **Self-evolution** is the process of deliberate growth that Commanders undertake to activate their potential. Knowing when to assess and rebuild themselves, and then practicing that development outwardly, advances them in life.
- **Self-responsibility** is taking charge of their lives by accepting accountability for what they can do to improve things. Being conscious of their behavior gives them the power to create the future they want.

Commanders' personal growth is aided greatly by their capacity for innovative thought and talent for seeing grand future potential. Although examining their own inherent biases and prejudices can prove to be a great challenge, people with this personality type don't allow such complexity to dissuade them. Commanders can be remarkably perceptive, and choosing to analyze their own strong and weak aspects is an exercise of one of their greatest strengths: objectivity.

In each of the following sections, we'll first examine how Commanders use the five motivational aspects in balanced ways to lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives. Then we'll look at how they may depart from beneficial behavior, as well as adverse

effects they may experience because of imbalance. Finally, we'll discuss ideas to rebalance each of the aspects to get things back on track.

Self-Esteem

Self-esteem is the quality of liking oneself, independent of things like societal measures, personal struggles, or self-perceived flaws. No one is perfect, but a positive self-image is a critical foundation from which growth can occur. Without it, happiness becomes tremulously dependent on circumstance. Self-esteem isn't a response to external factors, but rather a stable and internal state of self-love. It's essential to strive for, if not always easy to maintain.

Balanced Self-Esteem

Bold Creativity

Commanders are known for their ability to build complex ideas into ambitious projects and clever solutions. Although they often think in terms of technical mechanics, their visions can also be fantastic, and these types draw self-esteem from learning to appreciate their own inspiration. They thrive on their excitement when engaging grand ideas; therein lies a capacity for self-fulfillment, when they let their imagination inspire their efforts.

Creativity, especially when it takes an active form, can be a source of joy for Commanders. Their own creative cores are a source of affirmation that drives their happiness – a great way to build self-esteem. Inspiration is precious to any type that values creative output, and they can see their own value reflected when they innovate. When they tap into what's inside them to continually feed their actions in

life, Commanders feel a sense self-love based on their own merits that can endure the occasional stumble.

Broadcasting Positivity

When their self-esteem is balanced, Commanders can be magnetic, constantly sharing their enthusiastic creativity and firm optimism. When their inner emotional state is one of happiness with themselves, it flows outward to impress others, easily making them the center of attention. These types love give-and-take, and their self-esteem grows when they fairly exchange lively conversations, ideas, and actions with others. Commanders elevate everyone around them when they generously share their upbeat energy.

Frequently acting with such positive effects gives people with this personality type satisfying feedback for their efforts, creating a healthy cycle that allows them to counterbalance any negative self-perceptions and maintain their own self-esteem. It's easier for them to accept their imperfections when cheerful engagement is their default mode because it improves the way they view themselves – a positive change loop, with shame replaced by the happy ways they exchange energy with the world.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Unforgiving Self-Appraisal

One of the ways Commanders commonly undermine their own self-esteem is by placing too much emphasis on the divide between what is and what could be. If they turn this scrutiny on themselves too sharply, it can create a sense of inadequacy. They may judge themselves against the grandest potential they can conceive, failing to temper possibility with realism. Self-esteem cannot stand up to the infinity of

things that could be better – a fact that escapes these energetic perfectionists when their expectations are out of balance.

This is especially problematic when Commanders compare themselves to other people. Feeling bad about themselves when someone else is ahead of them in some area can lead to self-criticism with an unbalanced expectation of supremacy at its core. Faced with such contradictions, they may be very hard on themselves. Commanders are proud of their abilities, and anything that contravenes that pride can unnecessarily swing their self-esteem in the wrong direction.

Ignoring Their Humanity

Negative feelings that harm self-esteem can be hard for people with the Commander personality type to process in healthy ways. Consequently, they often try to gain control over their lives by repressing their emotions, acting against their own humanity under the false assumption that it somehow makes them seem weak. Such a perspective simply isn't true, and their self-esteem is damaged when they struggle against perfectly natural feelings they think they should be stronger than.

Such denial can be outwardly apparent, even becoming a social barrier. Love, joy, passion, compassion, curiosity, and surprise can be as messy as they are beneficial, but Commanders don't always find them easy to integrate with their desire for emotional control. They may unwittingly clamp down on such wonderful feelings, along with darker ones. When they define their self-esteem by restricting their emotions instead of uplifting them, they're not mastering their nature – they're running from it.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Loving What They're Doing

Commanders can use their sharp perception to boost their self-esteem by evaluating how far they've come, rather than how far they've yet to go. Everyone is on a highly personal journey that has unique pitfalls and triumphs. Supporting the journey means focusing on progress, not position. Commanders can affirm a wellspring of self-esteem and recognize their own wonderful qualities simply by recognizing how they're using them.

Comparisons to others are inherently flawed. It's easy to find someone who's better at something; expecting otherwise is the height of arrogance, from which an unnecessary fall can occur. Everyone is different, so perfectly accurate comparisons are logically impossible – and therefore a waste of time. Happiness needn't be relative, and Commanders can create balanced self-esteem by developing themselves rather than comparing themselves to others. For Commanders looking to recognize their own personal abilities in action, the following exercise can help:

- Pick a personal ability that brings you happiness (a latent skill, perhaps expressed as a hobby or burgeoning interest.)
- If it's not already being actively improved, plan to do so. Join a club, enroll in a class, or simply procure the materials and work on it personally.
- Schedule the activity or engagement on whatever regular basis is fulfilling but doesn't interfere with other goals.
- Set a goal for the next stage of improvement, rather than targeting a specific level of skill or accomplishment. In other words, don't place an end on the road of enjoyment, just enjoy each step along it.

- Proudly note any perceptible progress (a whiteboard can be useful.) For this exercise, the benchmark is appreciating each moment of progress in its own time, no matter how long it takes.
- Feel free to take on pursuits simultaneously. There's no reason Commanders can't brave open mic nights with their guitars one day and then head off to golf practice the next.
- Change it up if desired, but always work toward developing an ability that feeds personal joy and a sense of reward.

Commanders can develop a base state of self-esteem by making a conscious choice to view themselves positively. The evidence they require to truly believe it's working can be found in the recorded results of their efforts, and happiness can be found in the practice itself.

Exploring Emotion

If these types sidestep honesty about their emotions, they can diminish their ability to manage them. It's natural to be challenged by feelings, but acknowledging them fully enables the balanced self-control that Commanders so prize, as well as the self-esteem they need to thrive. Consciously exploring emotions builds self-esteem because it empowers controlled, healthy expression, rather than letting emotions rupture in chaotic ways that harm their view of themselves. Commanders take pride in proficiency, and conscious emotional intelligence is certainly something of which to be proud.

When those with this personality type practice accepting their feelings, they create an ability to progress and prosper. Repressed feelings can have caustic effects that not only erode self-esteem but also breed coldness, which can interfere with social

relations. When Commanders begin to understand feelings they've ignored, it frees the internal warmth of self-esteem and creates an appealing outward genuineness. Balancing emotions is a lifelong process, but Commanders' rational, willful approach can serve them well – here's one great way to start:

- When a feeling arises, observe it without judgement. A feeling is a natural response of the brain, not a defining factor of your being.
- Accept that the emotion is an inevitable by-product of events that's expected and not innately harmful if viewed appropriately.
- Try to understand the source. What happened? Map it out to trace and analyze its origins.
- If the feeling is negative, don't hide it or let it fester. Instead, try to find any root cause that can be addressed. This can help with processing the feeling, or even releasing it.
- If the feeling is positive, let it flow outwardly. Any excuse for a laugh or a smile should be vigorously embraced, whether alone or with others. Never let intellectuality, propriety, or ego dampen healthy joy.
- Communicate! Discuss feelings with trusted friends or family. There's nothing better than verbalizing emotions to bring them into focus, and getting things out in the open can provide a clearer view.

Commanders need not ignore their emotionality, nor try to change who they are, to build internal harmony. If anything, liking themselves comes from truly understanding and appreciating themselves as they are. For this ambitious personality type, taking deliberate steps to get in touch with their emotional aspects is a great way to restore balance to their self-esteem.

Self-Respect

Self-respect differs from self-esteem in that it's less about emotional harmony with oneself, and more about objective appreciation for one's own qualities and actions. Commanders build this motivational facet by being honest with themselves, taking pride in what they do, and respecting the talents that make them special.

Balanced Self-Respect

Guiding Principles

Commanders deeply value organized, consistent systems. They work hard to figure out their preferences in doing things, creating their canon of principles through both a search for function and ideas. Their principles are highly personal, but as energetic idealists, they cannot help but actively apply their conclusions to their environment. Establishing and living their principles is one of the core ways that Commanders build balanced self-respect.

People with this personality type are rarely content to shape only their own lives; Commanders naturally think that if something works for them, it can benefit others as well. Of course, not everyone has the same needs, so these types balance their approach by consciously using their cleverness to conceive plans that respect others' uniqueness. Nothing boosts Commanders' sense of self-respect like living out their ideals, then sharing such principles in balanced ways that garner them acceptance and positive feedback from the world as well.

Pride in Accomplishment

As rewarding as they can be, principles remain only theories unless they're put into action. A common way Commanders build and maintain balanced self-respect is by

engaging both effort and achievement as independently worthy actions. A mighty leap is mighty wherever one lands. These types seek to modify circumstances more than adapt to them; putting their ideas to work is a critical step in that process. Instead of just thinking that something “should” be a certain way, Commanders love to put innovative thought into practice.

Not always quick to seek radical changes, they nonetheless embrace bold action, including challenging the person in the mirror to walk their talk. When Commander individuals pursue goals (especially around something new), they affirm the strength of their abilities, which is something they can respect deeply in themselves, independent of specific achievements. Whether they’re redesigning a bathroom or running a marathon to raise money for charity, these types appreciate themselves through action and incorporate that value into a balanced sense of self-respect.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Superiority Complex

Self-respect grows from internal strength, but when dealing with the world, Commanders face a challenge. For people who pride themselves on mental ability, a sense of superiority is all too easy to assume. When they build their self-respect without respecting other people’s views, they miss opportunities to improve what they know. Arrogantly lording their wisdom over others is hardly as admirable as improving the world around them – or learning something new.

Commanders may express such behavior by belittling the contributions and ideas of others, devaluing others’ efforts as “flawed” as a demonstration of their own intellectual prowess. When they lack balanced self-respect, they may overtly or subconsciously seek domination instead of addressing the root cause of any

insecurity. However, arrogant Commanders likely won't be able to fully respect themselves, and those they deprecate will never offer them the genuine peer appreciation they truly desire.

Too Heavy a Load

Commanders are known for being driven, and they tend to affirm their self-respect through their output. However, their broad, bold visions can lead them astray if they bite off more than they can chew. When they struggle under the weight of too many grand goals at once, their self-respect can suffer. Unfortunately, they're unlikely to back off, often refusing to pare down their efforts.

Such imbalance may start as strain in such practical matters as logistics and resources, but it can easily become stressful or even emotionally damaging. For a personality type that often builds self-respect based on accomplishments, overreaching can be risky, as it puts their sense of self on the line. If they can't do all they think they should be able to do, Commanders may feel there's something wrong with themselves, instead of simply acknowledging their perfectly human limits.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Equitable Brilliance

Commanders can respect others without diminishing their sense of self-respect. One of the most crucial elements in any rational endeavor is the notion of peer review: the idea that, where an individual might err due to inherent bias or simple accident, a group of well-informed individuals can compensate for such errors. Commanders can apply this concept to their own thoughts and opinions, maintaining their own

proud intellectuality while seeking ways to refine and prove their ideas among others, not against them.

Evaluating worthy input can reinforce the strength of their position and, likewise, their sense of self. In fact, Commanders' self-respect demands that their notions are correct; testing themselves against alternative views can accomplish this. By remaining open-minded and allowing for the possibility of both their own shortcomings and others' admirable abilities, these types demonstrate their capacity to improve and excel, and that objectivity strengthens them. When Commanders feel like diminishing someone else's conclusions, they can try this exercise:

- Find the facts. Research both sides of the matter objectively, enough to answer the question of who's more correct.
- Note and retain the information needed to demonstrate the point.
- If others' research contradicts, alters, or expands personal conclusions in any way, find and thank them for prompting the learning, and share what was learned.
- If the research confirms your conclusions over others', don't force the issue. If something must be said, try: "Hey, I know you value knowledge, so I just wanted to share what I learned."
- Either way, move on. Knowledge is valuable because of what it can be used to accomplish, and Commanders can always find something more purposeful to do with what they know than merely feeling superior.

Fighting to be "right" is a noble cause when it's about improving the self. Others, however, may need to find their own wisdom without being forced. Commanders build balanced self-respect by finding, embracing, and sharing their truth, not by using it as a weapon.

Bite, Chew, Repeat

These types can maintain their self-respect by embracing the joy of pursuing goals without spreading themselves too thin. When they balance realism and vigorous engagement, Commanders can deepen their self-respect as they express themselves through effort – staying on top but not necessarily trying to serve the full scope of their imagination all at once. Being a super human is possible without trying to be superhuman, and even Commanders have their limits.

Sometimes the satisfaction of accomplishment is intensified through focus, and Commander individuals certainly bring intensity to their goals. Using this virtue to focus their energy on a reasonable number of pursuits can help them avoid stumbling under too heavy a load. A lifetime of amazing achievement is created in steps, and they can build balanced self-respect by understanding that it may not be possible to stride forward in too many directions at once. Their own sharp analytical skills can help Commanders manage their priorities. Before adding another iron to the fire, they can consider the following:

- What's the benefit? It's important to balance personal interest with broader gains.
- What will it cost? Cost can take many forms, including money, time, stress, impact on relationships, and the effects on other commitments.
- How long will it take? Research can help formulate an estimate.
- How likely is success? Belief is an asset, but a dose of realism is useful.
- Is the pursuit itself rewarding, or only the final achievement? Some of the most beneficial things are those that generate value along the way, such as learning or joy, regardless of their ultimate outcome.

- Is there consumption overlap? For example, a goal that requires money might not drain other resources such as time, but two goals that both require a lot of time might cause conflict.
- Is there a compensatory effect? Some things that consume the same resource might yield different benefits that balance out. For example, replacing a septic tank and taking a vacation can both be expensive, but one can provide relief from the other.
- Can it wait? Just because something is interesting doesn't mean it needs to be done right away.
- With the insight you gain by answering the above questions, evaluate and prioritize goals to create a reasonably sustainable level of engagement.

Commanders rarely fear (or even acknowledge) exhaustion, but realistic limits on resources can nonetheless interfere with achieving inspired goals. It's important for these types to get results that feed their self-respect, and their decisive objectivity can help them manage their efforts in a balanced way.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence is the energy that propels Commanders to explore and accomplish their goals in life. It starts from within, building on the foundation of self-esteem and self-respect by relating those inner strengths to the exterior world. Everyone wants to feel capable, and self-confidence is important because it opens the door to action.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Visions of Progress

Commanders aren't so named because they like to sit and watch life happen. They may have diverse interests and beliefs, but one thing they have in common is a desire to craft concepts into reality. For these types, balanced self-confidence is often a marriage of their intellectual ideals with their firm vigor, leading to the pursuit of their vision. When Commanders put time and energy into developing balanced self-esteem and self-respect, those qualities almost automatically erupt outward as positive, progressive action.

People with this personality type aren't satisfied by mere exuberance, though; they feel compelled to implement logical systems that reflect their conclusions about the world and their place in it. No other personality type is more concerned with advancement than Commanders, and they demonstrate balance by not only improving their own lives, but also trying to better the planet as they progress through it. Finding inspired ways to do so keeps their self-confident energy strong and invites beneficial returns.

"I've Got This!"

Self-confidence isn't just about advancement for Commanders; it's also about how they handle unexpected challenges and learn from mistakes and misfortune. Building on the blocks of self-esteem and self-respect helps them remain durable and energetic whatever may come. Those qualities help them maintain balanced self-confident energy with open-mindedness so that life's harder feedback seems constructive rather than destructive, leading to inspired action. Despite the

knowledge that they can't predict everything, Commanders can always pick themselves up and move forward.

The wisest of these types don't necessarily regard setbacks with excessive frustration, either, but rather as potentially valuable, exciting learning opportunities. Broken things can be rebuilt, and examining failure with curiosity rather than frustration is a great step toward achieving a better result next time. Commanders are great at creating solutions to problems, which increases self-confidence as they feel able to make just about anything better, including their own futures.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Running Roughshod

Often gripped by powerful inspiration, Commanders' otherwise healthy sense of self-interest can get way out of balance. They tend to get so caught up in pursuing their desires that they ignore any detrimental effects their actions may have on others. Achieving their visions can be so exciting that they may unconsciously discount the values, needs, or concerns of others in the process, even pushing those close to them in unwanted directions. Their energy can cause harm if it's used without empathy, or even regard, for anything other than what they want.

What makes such behavior so troubling is that Commanders may recognize it, yet not see anything wrong with it. Unbalanced self-confidence can gain frightening momentum, and when they think they're right, they can seem to trample others, not seeing any reason to compromise their perspective for something they see as inferior. They may simply wave away responsibility for collateral damage – either under the flag of serving a higher cause or simply because the rest of the world isn't "strong" or "smart" enough to handle them.

The Frustration of Failure

To put it simply, Commanders have demanding expectations that are hard to meet. Self-confidence includes chasing ambitious hopes, but when failure dashes their hopes, their cutting nature turns inward, and their energy suffers. This is especially common when externally recognized benchmarks such as academic accomplishments or professional or social status are at stake. When these types put too much pressure on themselves to “win,” any failures can drain the enjoyment from what should be happy pursuits.

Of course, in life, failures are inevitable and common, which poses a challenge for a personality type whose ethos is striving to be the best. When Commanders tie their energy to mistaken assumptions of complete success, anything less can damage their self-confidence, even if such stumbles aren’t their fault. Frustration and blame are common traps these types fall into when they feel they’ve failed, and they may even act out in anger as a result.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Sharing Momentum

There’s no reason Commanders need to trample others. Firm direction and vigorous momentum can be used to another effect – moving people forward together. They can rebalance their tendency to dominate by creating *appealing* opportunities for others to willingly join with them. They needn’t dilute their visions to share them, but by respecting others, Commanders can make others more likely to appreciate what they’re trying to do. And, if people don’t choose to join, these types can extend respect further by not dragging others into something they don’t want.

What does this look like in the real world? Commanders can magnanimously welcome others into their plans in the hopes that they'll become a helpful part of the action. They can describe their ideas and mission with bright vigor, and those who see the virtues of their views may offer their own contributions. Commanders certainly have the mental agility to incorporate others' ideas into their own vision, and they often find unexpected inspiration through such brainstorming. They can rebalance their runaway-train mentality by inviting some passengers aboard, using the following exercise:

- When engaging a goal, whether personal or professional, watch how it seems to affect other people. How are they reacting?
- Share personal excitement and inspiration with them. They may be more supportive when they see an idea illuminated by the optimistic enthusiasm of its creator, so talk about the wonderful potentials.
- If people aren't behind an idea, ask them for suggestions on ways to make it better.
- Benefit and responsibility often go together, so inviting people to participate constructively can help them feel like more than bystanders.
- Whenever possible, use others' input to create broadly appealing gains – a great way to gain others' support and assistance.
- If others still don't like the goal despite the previous steps, and if you still plan to act, try to be respectful in dissent.
 - Make it clear that your intention to move forward anyway isn't personal.
 - Reiterate that you are seeking cooperation.
 - Consider asking to revisit the issue later. Demonstrating ongoing willingness to make things work is a far more productive approach than conflict.

When Commanders put their best foot forward while striding powerfully – and maybe even offering their hand – others may feel motivated rather than downtrodden. When this forceful personality type demonstrates openness and a desire to work with others, their energetic self-confidence seems a lot less like a trampling and a lot more like leadership.

Willingness to Fail

Failure is hard for Commanders. But perfection is a logical impossibility, so accepting the inevitability of occasional failure can release them from frustration with themselves. Instead of pinning their self-confidence purely on success (and suffering the attendant stress of such a limited view), these types can focus on their ongoing improvement.

To create balanced self-confidence, they can examine disappointing experiences with all their intellectual might to extract useful insights, turning such events into opportunities. Asking, “What can I learn from this?” is a critical step to becoming better. Those who define themselves only by their successes can have many opportunities to feel terrible, but forging setbacks into something useful is a command move that affirms an ability to progress – and balanced self-confidence blossoms from such ability. One bold way to practice handling failure is to deliberately engage it with low stakes:

- Pick a skilled activity with which you are completely unfamiliar – a painting night, tennis lesson, dance class, or public karaoke, for example. Choose something so outside your existing skillsets that proficiency will be *very* unlikely.

- Consider inviting trusted friends into the experience – people who share laughter, not judgement.
- Participate in the activity.
- Relax your mind and stay in the moment.
- While doing it, deliberately set the following mental bars for success:
 - Sincere effort
 - Lightheartedness
 - Expanded physical or emotional limits
- During the activity, observe your stress levels. Are ego or unrealistic expectations of success interfering with learning, progress, and enjoyment? Don't let them.
- Laugh away any embarrassment – literally and out loud.
- Learn from the experience, even if it brings up insecurity. Accept that improvement is an ongoing thing.

When Commanders learn to handle failure and try again, they create the self-confident sense of being successful that overcomes any inevitable missteps. Letting go of frustration and putting energy into wiser attempts are skills that get better the more these types practice them.

Self-Evolution

Change can be hard, and the need for it isn't always apparent to Commanders who have carefully built themselves to a certain point. However, anything thus built doesn't preclude further progress, and these types can always choose to advance. Self-evolution is the idea that they can turn their love of understanding and optimization onto themselves, constantly looking for ways to improve.

It's very important to realize that self-evolution isn't necessarily about specific measures, but instead about creating personal fulfillment and extracting whatever is desired from life. This may include academic or financial aspirations or something as simply soul-satisfying as mastering a skill. It may also mean developing their emotional intelligence to better understand themselves and others. The point of self-evolution isn't to be on an austere march of obligation toward their goals, but rather to continuously develop personal potential into reality.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Kindness Creates Connections

In the pursuit of reasoned, rational action, no type is more vigorous than Commanders. However, how others perceive them is also very important to them – even if they're convinced of their own abilities, they want others to acknowledge them for who they are, and they seek such acknowledgment by connecting with people. For them, empathy and emotional intelligence aren't always easy, so while they're developing these skills, they rely on other strengths when engaging with others: smart ideas, rational logic, and a willingness to boldly engage.

Commanders turn those qualities toward balanced connections with others by making people the beneficiaries. Demonstrating their intellect is a common way they seek to build their standing. When their efforts are inquisitive and kind, and when they aim to learn about others, they find people to be receptive – and often appreciative – of their energy. Nothing feels better to Commanders than being applauded for what they do and who they are, and firm, unerring, bold kindness is a balanced path to such acclaim.

Determining Transformation

Commanders love mechanisms that improve life. As much as they deeply value consistency and dedication, they also want to advance their methods and views. This ongoing process often leads to moments of critical decision-making – letting go of habits or established practices can almost feel like admitting to making mistakes because the structures they've worked so hard to build must be modified. However, they understand it's a necessary step to creating something better, and once they make these decisions, they commit to them with forward-looking willpower.

For stability-minded Judging types, too-frequent change can frankly be annoying, but Commanders maintain balance by keeping their doors propped open for new thinking – they don't want to miss good opportunities. Even more importantly, their esteem for rational logic leads them to recognize their own mistaken perceptions, and then they work to correct them. The only thing they dislike more than being wrong is ongoing wrongness. Commanders embrace change because improvement makes solid sense.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

Unintentionally Harsh Logic

Even the most progressive ideals can turn cold when they discount less tangible aspects of humanity. Commanders' rational mentality can make them capable achievers, but when they rely only on sterile, efficiency-themed rationales to guide their evolution, their logic can become frighteningly severe. They may even come to see emotionality as a weakness that people should evolve past. Crafting ideals from dispassionate logic can easily result in damage – to others as well as themselves –

but individuals with the Commander personality type may not see feelings as important compared to the progress for which they strive.

Behavior that can come off as high-handed callousness is rarely intended – or even realized – as such by these types, who may simply be carried away by trying to improve themselves and the world. Surgery without anesthetic is a good analogy for this unnecessarily rough path to self-evolution; their energy and sense of logic may focus unforgivingly on efficient results more than feelings. It can be hard for them to think any other way, but such an unbalanced lack of consideration for themselves and others can slow their progress by ignoring critical emotional development.

The Density of Structure

Their reliance on structure can make it hard for Commanders to embrace change, especially within. Even keenly analytical minds can be tested by objective reviews of their own conclusions and behavior. But, like any other personality type, they're far from immune to ego's blinding effect. Often, the more vigorously they try to optimize their views and actions, the more stone-like their thinking becomes. If Commanders become convinced they've achieved some personal pinnacle, their lack of openness to evolving an ideal may hold them back.

Resistance to change can breed combativeness in these types, as they may confuse inflexible thinking with the righteous assertion of truth, working energetically to defend even outmoded convictions. Commanders can be passionate, but if they fight too hard for established concepts (something they rail against in others), they almost certainly limit their knowledge – and their personal growth. Change is inevitable, and fighting it is a poor use of their abundant energy, especially when they value advancement so much.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Feelings Are a Fact

Commanders can rebalance overly harsh logic by consciously choosing to do so – it's halfway accomplished merely by their determination. They need not feel others' emotions in their own hearts to accept the value of being kind, although that valuable potential increases through practice. Logical reasons to prioritize kindness include its benefits to self, the effects on others they're close to, and future social potential. In other words, Commanders can offer kindness as both a simultaneously genuine and transactional gesture.

Feelings have tremendous influence over people's thinking, so Commanders can recognize the value of kindness as a powerful aid to lofty goals. Unkind behavior, no matter how it may be supported by facts, makes people feel threatened; they become reactionary, as stress shuts their ears to the voice of reason and rationality. This is antithetical to Commanders' desire to improve the world through that very voice. Kindness, especially from strong individuals, strengthens others and elevates their thinking. Commanders can tap into the power of kindness through simple, direct, conscious actions to help others:

- Seek opportunities to use personal power or ability to help others in major or minor ways – for example, assisting an infirm stranger down some stairs, volunteering locally, pitching in a few hours on a neighbor or coworker's personal project.
- If such opportunities seem to present itself, ask to help – don't just butt in.
- Ask others for explanations of the outcomes they hope for, as well as how they're trying to achieve them.

- Offer only positive approval: Agree with what works and offer constructive solutions. Don't point out flaws.
- Offer direct assistance: Offer to take an aspect of the task off someone's plate, then finish it.
- Do only what's asked and agreed to. Kindness means helping others, not taking over.
- Feel free to set upfront limits on your involvement to avoid becoming overwhelmed and so there's energy to spread kindness to other people and goals as well.
- Ensure consistency and follow through on all offers – a natural, essential thing for Commanders.

Commanders love being problem-solvers, and helping others is a kind and sensible form of problem-solving that tends to be remembered. The return on investment only begins with gratitude. Commanders often find their energy returning to them in the form of compassion, ideas, or simply others' willingness to help them when they need it.

Advancing Through Change

These types can take a lesson from the material world: Absolute rigidity equates a lack of movement, including toward progress. Those who don't wish to be stuck in place (or cracked) must develop some ductility. With Commanders' ability to examine and explore reality, progressive change is certainly within reach. Their ability to assess things and act decisively helps them ensure that changes are good ones, and they can remain open to making the best possible decisions as new opportunities present themselves.

Being willing to evolve their conclusions is a huge asset to Commanders, and it relieves a lot of stress. Sticking to proven practices may seem like a source of stability, but it also causes them to miss opportunities. Instead of insisting only on what they've decided, Commanders can view their established understanding as a sturdy foundation to build on – using any resources available. A measure of openness combined with their sense of energetic action allows these types to evolve. Commanders can start by practicing positive change voluntarily:

- Pick one aspect of yourself, your mind, or your life in general that could change for the better. Focus on changing a habit (eating a healthier diet, setting the alarm 15 minutes earlier to enjoy a little personal time in the morning, or reading instead of watching TV, for example.)
- Consciously practice acting on the change at least once per day.
- Feel free to include anyone who can help things proceed – involving others is a great way to practice personal change.
- While practicing the new habit, note the benefits gained, and use that satisfaction to inspire the next change.
- Mix it up: After a week or two, pick another thing to change and start the process over again. Keep building or advancing at least one personal quality.

Commanders are adept at following through once they decide to make changes – it's the initial decision to change that can require some serious effort. However, their desire for advancement helps these types embrace self-evolution as they focus on building something new and wonderful rather than polishing monuments they've already finished.

Self-Responsibility

This facet of personal growth is about Commanders' decisions and what they value. Consciously accepting ownership of all aspects of their actions is key to personal growth, and self-responsibility represents both accountability and capability in Commanders' lives, including recognizing the limits on their responsibility.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Authority Over Life

These types have a gift for dissecting concepts and events, and they see causes and probabilities surrounding almost anything. Combining this with self-responsibility gives them influence over their lives because they can choose actions that create joy, personal progress, and harmony with their environment. Commanders crave control, but because their will isn't the only factor in life, that's not always possible. They create balance when they use their abilities to gracefully and constructively deal with whatever happens, instead of pushing too hard against an unwelcome fate.

That can mean different things depending on the situation – more an *attitude* of positive action than a specific course of action. Self-responsible Commanders use their knowledge and power to consciously engineer the best possible outcomes, including knowing when to relax and back off. True greatness – and personal growth – isn't really a measure of ability, but rather how adroitly that ability is used. When they claim accountability for their lives, they also gain authority, and every adversity becomes an opportunity for them to learn, refocus, and create a better future.

Accepting the Challenge

As they take responsibility for their lives, Commanders may come up against upsetting things or people. Tolerance isn't easy for a type that so actively envisions their ideal world, yet these types often find it to be the only functional solution available. In the face of the disagreeable, they can firmly balance their reactions by recognizing that it's not their responsibility to "fix" everything – sometimes it's not even an option. Knowing when to accept that which they cannot or need not change frees up a lot of useful energy.

They must work harder than most to overcome frustration and release themselves from judgement, but Commanders are up for the challenge of balancing their exacting vision with wise acceptance. They appreciate the value of living in progressive motion – they'd rather hurdle a wall than keep smashing into it. When they practice acceptance, they step off the narrow path of perfectionism into an expanded mode that enables them to stride forward despite upsetting obstacles.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Dangerous Blame Game

Commanders tend to see everything as a system, and are often able to understand things in complex detail. This can be a virtue when they're creatively constructive, but when they experience misfortune, their vigorously analytical tendencies may lead them to hunt down and attack any perceived sources. It's dangerously easy for such an expressive personality type to erupt when others' incompetence or deficiency seems to be at fault – so easy that they may not see any personal accountability, or feel the need to take the self-responsible step of turning their ire into restorative action.

In fact, Commanders' tendency to blame any perceived inadequacy – be it a mechanism, method, or person – often feeds a cycle of negative, sometimes aggressive judgment, even around legitimate complaints. The energy they focus on finding fault could be better used to move forward, but when Commanders think they're right and don't see any culpability in themselves, they may convince themselves they don't have any responsibility to remedy the situation. This attitude can take them from productive action into unbalanced, angry cynicism, hardly a state in which these types achieve growth or joy.

Bossing the World

Commanders' keen perceptions detect the myriad problems that are a part of everyday reality. However, harshly criticizing everything they see as "broken" and trying to force unwanted changes in the world are unbalanced behaviors that rob others of their own right to self-responsibility. It's simply unrealistic for Commanders to attempt to make everything the way they think it should be, and when such overreaching efforts inevitably fail, they can become angry. When they insist on trying to command everything, they may end up being at war.

Such an unbalanced attitude not only threatens Commanders' own happiness and health, but it can also be hurtful to others, harming relationships in their personal and professional lives. Self-responsibility certainly includes taking progressive or curative actions, but Commanders can do a lot of damage when they assume the obligation – or right – to judge and control everything. When they think they see the "best" way, they struggle to be permissive, often putting themselves at odds with people around them.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Command Response-Ability

Life presents many opportunities to find fault – after all, the world is full of flaws. However, self-responsible Commanders can choose paths forward of firm optimism and creativity instead. It's good to understand the root of a problem, but identifying a cause is different than blaming it; blame is a destructive attitude, whereas understanding a problem with a constructive mindset is a gesture of power because it affirms an ability to effect change. Accepting their restorative abilities also frees Commanders to recognize any part they may have played in their problems without shame – a wise use of rational objectivity.

To take that wisdom even further, they can learn from such realizations with a mind to prevent problems in the future. When they embrace both self-responsibility and their abilities, they often find that participating in solutions – even overseeing those they previously criticized – is a far more satisfying and productive use of energy than blame. These types are easily capable of envisioning and enacting grander plans than finger-pointing. Commanders can use the following steps to help turn their minds toward progress instead of blame:

- Ask, “What happened?” Before assigning blame, seek answers with a cool, analytical mindset. The truth may come to light and provide a useful perspective.
 - Go over the chain of events to uncover the details of what happened.
 - Ask others for their take on events. Limiting the analysis to only one perspective would be to ignore additional data.

- Map things out on paper, if needed, including others' description of events.
- If the root problem can be identified, see whether the situation can be improved constructively. This is a great time to seek the counsel of trusted, respected friends, family, or coworkers.
- Be forgiving. Inanimate objects can't apologize, and people can't undo history. Forgiveness benefits those who give it. After all, stress and anger can do real physical and mental harm. Calm tolerance is a rational investment in personal health.
- Elevate others. Instead of pointing out how people are wrong, respectfully offer them mentorship, helpful energy, and the benefit of personal experience – and be graceful if they decline.
- Move forward. Feelings of blame don't always go away quickly, but staying focused on progressive action is helpful, so tap into personal energy and creativity to seek a solution that can make things better.

The above are rational and helpful steps, but frankly, sometimes frustration and the desire to blame can be irrationally raw. Consider this classic tool that any type can use to release negative feelings:

- Let it out. Write an unrestrained rant about the problem and then read it aloud in private, letting out emotional energy along with the spoken words.
- Afterward, destroy the paper so that it can't be read again.
- If desired, repeat the exercise whenever the need arises. The act of composing and then tangibly expressing and releasing negativity opens a window of relief that Commanders can step through to get back on track.

Blame implies victimization, but Commanders prefer to see themselves as capable agents of their own destiny instead of as victims. These types create useful and balanced self-responsibility by examining how they can improve things instead of blaming themselves, others, or circumstances for their problems.

The Strength to Accept

Tolerance and acceptance can seem like useless concepts when Commanders want to mold the world to suit their views. However, as they mature and accept that they can't control everything – or everyone – those skills become extremely valuable to rebalance unbeneficial frustration. When these types accept responsibility for their actions and reactions, rational objectivity reveals that frustration isn't only unnecessary but also within their power to change.

Self-responsibility is a logical path to calm acceptance that leads Commanders away from futile anger and toward progressive action. It's OK to call out things that seem wrong – Commanders have wonderful insights to offer – but fighting to control what they cannot does little to bring happiness or progress. It's more rewarding to embrace opportunities to act on their visions without getting stuck when they can't, and tolerance can help avoid such pitfalls. Here's a daring exercise they can use to practice such a skill. (It may require a little planning in advance.)

- Enter a social situation antithetical to your personal opinions, and decide to withhold judgement or thought. (For example, a progressive atheist could sit in the back of an orthodox religious service.)
- Quietly listen and absorb for 10–15 minutes (or longer if the subject proves interesting).

- Don't discuss the experience with other participants. This is an internal practice, not a social one of argument or agreement. If you are asked to discuss the experience, perhaps offer a friendly, "Just curious, but I'd prefer not to discuss it."
- Allow internal judgement (intolerance), but simply observe it instead of delving into it – collect the facts, not the feelings.
- If emotions like anger or frustration come up, feel them for five seconds, then refocus. It's important to respect and allow emotions, even while rebalancing them.
- Try to understand exclusively the upsides to the thing being examined, even if it's not personally agreeable: What are its positive points? How does it benefit people? Why do people like it, and how is that legitimately lived? Commanders have the mental strength to walk in others' shoes.
- Tally up the positives and see whether they collectively make the thing more acceptable. Something needn't be enjoyed or even engaged to be tolerated.
- If possible, meet up with a friend afterward and discuss these observations.
- Realize that the objectionable thing will always be there – but choosing to focus on it or not is a matter of self-responsibility.
- Take this idea into everyday life: Where it's beneficial to place attention and energy is a personal choice.

There's no magic bullet with which Commanders can fight their own discomfort when they perceive genuinely odious things. However, trying to force change isn't always enough to make life happy. Sometimes personal growth comes from recognizing the advantages of acceptance, and then finding the strength to progress despite the world's offenses.

Conclusion

Masters and Commanders of Their Lives

Commanders are aptly named, but “command” can have different meanings, one of which is domination. Those who look down on others and the world achieve only a relative position of dominance that’s built on conflict, by claiming superiority rather than demonstrating worthiness. This is the path of a dictator, not a Commander. Balanced self-esteem and self-respect give these types the self-confident energy to unabashedly show the world their virtues. Commanders don’t need to hide their imperfections, either, because acknowledging flaws is a declaration of intent to grow beyond them.

This brings us to another meaning of “command”: mastery. Continually pursuing ascendant growth, Commanders lift themselves with personal energy, cheerful willingness to apply their abilities, and a determination to improve themselves through objective self-evolution. These qualities create personal greatness regardless of comparisons to others, and just as certainly, they attract admiration and respect. Luminous, positive actions earn genuine regard and may even create opportunities for learning and leadership.

Leadership doesn’t necessarily mean directing other people. Commanders can also practice brave self-leadership, forging rewarding, self-responsible paths. They can feel good about living daringly when their perceptions lead to actions that benefit others as well as themselves. At their best, Commanders are emcees for rational progress and lofty principles – loud, proud voices for the positive potential in all things, sources of ideas conceived with bold imagination, plans wrought with focused

insight, and grand deeds achieved through energetic commitment. For these types, when all things are balanced, all things are possible.

Romantic Relationships



Even in love, Commanders are likely to have a set of goals – and a plan to achieve them. The task of trusting others in love is a bold adventure that takes them into uncomfortable, unknown territories. However, when they find the courage to loosen their grip in deference to others they love, they'll experience and enjoy more balance in their lives.

Although they may face many challenges (like every other personality type), Commanders who are looking for love still see the value of solid romantic partnerships. Their attempts may not look like the conventional images of romance, but these types ultimately desire love and connectedness like anyone else. As Extraverts, they draw energy from others, and loving, attentive partners can be quality power sources. This alone makes the challenge worth it.

Passion That Runs Deep

Connection is an essential human need. Romance and love are among the strongest expressions of connectedness, but not everyone experiences these expressions in the same way. Commanders may not fit easily into the conventions that surround

dating, love, and marriage. However, when they make a partnership commitment, Commanders can be incredibly stable, loving partners. Relationships with them may not be filled with fireworks, but less flamboyant romances can still be powerful ones.

Romance, especially of the passionate variety, is more likely when Commanders feel that their partners are also interested in increasing their knowledge and pursuing goals with gusto. A shared passion for achievements – even if the goals they hope to achieve are nothing alike – is more stimulating to Commanders than candlelit dinners (unless they're discussing their goals at said dinners). Their passion is likely to take the form of arousing conversation, and their idea of a romantic gesture may be letting their partners decide where to go for dinner without criticizing their choices. (Internal dialogue: "That restaurant only has a three-star review? Are you sure you want to risk it?" External dialogue: "Sure, honey, that sounds fantastic. It could be a fun experiment.")

Struggling with Emotional Connection

Although their feelings are as strong as anybody's, Commanders may not be emotionally demonstrative. Their Extraversion makes them adept in social situations, but the awareness needed to navigate through more emotionally fraught environments may be somewhat superficial, and learned rather than heartfelt. This may extend to dating and other romantic scenarios. Hopefully, as their relationships mature, Commanders tend to access their honest feelings more and use them to strengthen romance. When trusting only their rational instincts and dismissing any alternative thoughts from their partners, however, they don't always supply the requisite empathy required of lasting relationships.

Additionally, Commanders in less-evolved relationships may struggle with their desire to analyze and solve every perceived problem. They often don't realize that people experiencing emotions aren't always looking for solutions – sometimes they just need an empathetic ear. Commanders see pain and try to fix it, and they're the type most likely to agree with the statement, "You believe there's a right or wrong answer to every question in life." For them, there's a definitive solution for every problem. Everything is a part of a system that, if broken, just needs rethinking or readjusting to be repaired.

Unrealistic Relationship Expectations

Since Commanders spend much of their lives strategizing and analyzing situations, they may find it challenging to match their imaginative expectations with hard reality. They're among the personality types most likely to say that their attitudes about relationships change frequently. (Shifting attitudes about relationships are shared by those with the Intuitive trait, who spend much of their time in their imagination-fueled mental playgrounds.) The troubling question for Commanders may be, "Is there a perfect, rational formula for this thing called love?" Even if they believe they've found one, next month, with more "data," their formula might transform completely. Their wishes can be a moving target.

Another area where Commanders may find themselves struggling to be realistic is the romantic expectations of their partners. Commander lovers don't always appreciate the layers of rituals involved; in fact, they often feel they're superficial and unnecessary. For example, buying their sweethearts bouquets of flowers that are just going to wither and die ("Really, you know they're already dead, right?") seems impractical and an inefficient use of funds at best. They may fail to see that such rituals often have a purpose that has more to do with emotional intelligence than

logic. Commanders who reject such rituals may find themselves struggling to find significant others who are willing to overlook their disregard for anything that isn't "entirely logical."

Embracing Emotional Expression

Learning to understand the role their emotions play within their romantic relationships, and having the ability to communicate them effectively, are both particularly important for Commanders. Effective communication in romance must include feelings, whether they appear to have a rational purpose or not. The best way for individuals of this type to sort through both their own and their partners' emotions is to take the time to intentionally and regularly talk about their feelings.

Commanders can avoid over-intellectualizing their emotions by sharing them and allowing for their partners to provide additional unique perspectives. Doing so improves their relationships as well by encouraging them to engage their lovers in conversation and to truly listen to what they have to say. They will get more accurate information about how their partners feel if they ask rather than assume. Intentional communication about feelings is a win-win situation for Commanders and their love interests alike.

Establishing Reasonable Expectations

Commanders are by no means the only personality type with unrealistically idealistic expectations of future partners and relationships. Although it's certainly helpful to have a set of traits to look for in lovers, no one should become married (pun intended) to an idea of the "ideal mate." All relationships are built on compromise, and everyone is unique and complex. It's impossible to find sweethearts who fit exact molds Commanders may create in their minds.

For these types specifically, it's unrealistic to think that their partners can share all their interests and view things through the same logical lens. Having "enough" in common is often more enriching, as their beloveds can introduce them to new ideas as well. It's also not necessarily wise to judge potential partners based on their perceived intelligence. Knowledge manifests in a variety of ways. Although someone may not be well-versed in philosophy or physics, Commanders shouldn't discount the importance of other forms of intelligence.

For example, lovers gifted in psychology can help to balance out some of Commanders' weaknesses by helping them to improve their emotional intelligence. Likewise, potential mates who are incredibly skilled in mechanical or technical projects can provide the skills and know-how to implement ideas that these types can only ponder. The best life partners aren't clones of their mates but, rather, provide balance to their traits and bring out the best in them.

Potential Role Pairings

Exploring the four Role groups and their possible interactions with Commanders in romantic relationships can provide a helpful framework for navigating relationships. However, some caution is warranted. Life is messy and full of hard decisions. People aren't like puzzle pieces that fit other pieces in perfect, predictable ways. Too many variables affect all relationships. Although the information in this chapter can help Commanders understand their relationships better, nobody can offer exact solutions or predict perfect romantic partners by personality type alone.

Also, traits may live on the surface in obvious ways – but may run as undercurrents. Traits often become subdued over time as the people who possess them adapt and grow. The idea isn't to cram certain romantic partners into a mold, or to define

anything strictly. Rather, the reasonable goal is to discover how traits might influence each unique person within a couple. When it comes to building loving relationships, ongoing personal conversations outdo even the most reliable personality studies.

Commander–Analyst Romantic Relationships



It's often said that "opposites attract," as if human hearts were emotional magnets. If that's true, it's fortunate that no two people are exactly alike, even if they share the same basic personality traits. Relationships between Commanders and other Analysts are hardly like peering into a mirror.

Balanced Commander–Analyst Romantic Relationships

Kindred Minds

When Commanders fall in love with other Analysts, they often feel as though they've finally found someone with whom they can relate. Analysts are about ideas, and Commanders entertain the ideas of their Analyst partners – even if a spirited debate about the quality of those ideas may ensue. In fact, both types often appreciate their partners' shared ability to objectively discuss the merits of ideas, current events, or even the most recent episode of a favorite television show. Such dialogues are

immensely important in romantic relationships for these particularly cerebral types, and having partners who share the ability to engage in such conversations (both inside and outside the bedroom) is both valuable and exciting.

Their shared Intuitive and Thinking traits make communication between Commanders and their Analyst sweethearts a simple, erudite affair, while still allowing for plenty of differing opinions. Specific traits, including Introversion, Extraversion, Prospecting, and Judging, influence all Analyst partners' personalities – not to mention the impact of personal experiences and life lessons. Even with their similarities, there remain plenty of nuances and differences to keep these relationships interesting. Commanders might find much in common with Analysts with the Judging or Extraverted traits, and they might find balance with Analysts who possess the Prospecting trait or are Introverted.

Creatively Intellectual

Commanders (and Analysts in general) often put a great deal of emphasis on their intellectual abilities; however, their exceptional ability to engage in imaginative endeavors may be what truly makes them shine. Their ability to combine the creative with the cerebral is impressive. Lovers who share and admire this quality can be hard to come by outside the Analyst Role group. Both Commanders and their Analyst partners are likely to thrive on innovative problem solving, allowing them to settle differences of opinion in particularly interesting and impressive ways.

For example, conflict over who should be responsible for taking out the garbage could result in an exceptionally creative solution for trash removal in general. (Self-emptying, mobile garbage cans, anyone?) Spreadsheets and computer programs that track finances can be sexy when they establish a budget and automatically track

spending, earnings, and investments – preventing pesky arguments over financial issues that plague the peons who ignore the beauty of organization. Simply put, being on the same wavelength can allow Commanders and their significant others to focus on what they love best, such as improving their knowledge and brainstorming solutions, without having to worry about the communication issues that may plague romances with other types.

Unbalanced Commander–Analyst Romantic Relationships

Superiority Complex

There's no inherent problem with romantic relationships being more intellectually-based than emotionally-oriented. However, in romances, emotions can surface despite these lovers' discomfort with showing them. Even Commander–Analyst partners, in all their rationality, can still hurt each other emotionally, perhaps by shooting down each other's opinions in front of friends in less-than-sensitive ways.

Commanders have so much confidence in their own ideas that they may slight the Analysts they love by viewing any alternatives their partners present as inferior. Because neither type is likely to approach such situations with regard for each other's feelings or sense of esteem, this can cause chronic feelings of opposition and frustration. A constant sense of opposition doesn't bode well for romantic bonds. In other words, each partner can walk away from such discussions feeling unloved.

Improvement Above All Else

Commanders' and other Analysts' rigorous minds also continually seek areas for improvement, always asking, "How can this be better?" When Commander–Analyst couples believe that everything is subject to debate, they're at risk of continuously

over-analyzing their relationships in a misguided attempt to improve them. When they assume their romances are never good enough, or at least never as good as they could be, they can experience perpetual feelings of discontent.

For Commanders, potential improvements may also provide grist for their argument mills. Without some awareness and balance, they tend to spend more time deconstructing, arguing about, and rebuilding their connections to each other than they do simply experiencing them. Constantly discussing and debating both real and perceived relationship issues prevents Commanders and their Analyst partners from living in the moment and appreciating the love they have for one another. Such consistently hard work can be exhausting and corrosive to romance, and it may erode any sense of stability these couples seek.

Rebalancing Commander-Analyst Romantic Relationships

Engaging in Respectful Dialogue

“Give and take” may be a cliché solution to romantic problems, but in a genuine way, Commanders should work on taking their lovers’ feelings seriously and providing insight into their own emotions. People with this personality type need to let their well-ordered intellectual universe become penetrable enough to let their partners’ (and their own) feelings in and out. Although they may not be fluent in the language of the heart, Commanders and their Analyst partners should still attempt to talk about their emotions.

Perhaps the most important component of such conversations should be an intentional focus on mutual respect and non-judgment. For types who are particularly prone to assigning value to people’s words and the emotions they express, it can be difficult to withhold judgment and criticism. Commander lovers

who hope to improve communication with their partners and cultivate more loving relationships need to engage in sincere self-reflection to develop the skills for more respectful, considerate dialogue. Understanding the impact that their words and behaviors have on their sweethearts can help Commanders avoid unnecessary conflicts and misunderstandings, as well as provide them with deeper levels of intimacy.

The following exercise can help Commanders become aware of how they communicate with their partners, and then take steps to correct any tendencies toward superiority:

- Take stock: The first step for determining if one has a superiority complex is asking their life partner. Commanders can ask their lovers, in non-defensive and non-judgmental ways, if they've ever felt inferior based on how they treat them.
- Learn the signs of superior behaviors, such as bragging, interrupting, criticizing, and engaging in self-righteous dialogue.
- Consider some trigger words that may accompany superior behavior, such as, "Well, I think/happen to know..." or, "That's dumb/unrealistic/ridiculous" (or any other tag word that indicates a higher level of intelligence than the individual they're talking to.)
- Create a "response protocol" they can engage in after a trigger word has been used. For example, if the words, "That's ridiculous," have been uttered, Commanders can plan on adding the phrase, "I apologize, what I meant is that concept doesn't address/answer _____. I don't mean it's less intelligent."

Just being aware of a tendency to engage in less-than-respectful dialogue can be an opportunity for enlightenment for Commanders and their Analyst partners. Learning

how to identify such interactions and then deal with the consequent behaviors can reduce conflict and bring these partners closer as well.

Appreciating Instead of Over-Analyzing

Even the most logical couples have their flaws, and Commander–Analyst couples can often benefit greatly by getting out of their heads occasionally and living more in the here and now. Simply appreciating their partners instead of analyzing them can strengthen these loving relationships.

People are tremendously complex, and even the most astute couples may never fully understand everything about each other. But that doesn't matter. Although an intellectual understanding of the situation may give Commanders the sense they have a grasp on things, it's likely insufficient by itself if they don't take emotions (both their own and their partners') into consideration.

The strength of romances is that partners enjoy their sweethearts for who they are – not who they could or should be. These rational couples may find it helpful to give themselves permission to live in the moment with their partners rather than analyze their love affairs to death, no matter how uncomfortable or unnatural it might seem initially. For this to happen, Commanders must let go and trust their significant others and their relationships. They may even decide to do something lighthearted instead of pondering heavy things. Experimenting with spontaneity can be the most direct way to confront the tendency to over-analyze relationships. The following exercises can help Commanders practice building emotional connections through spontaneity:

- Plan a surprise date each month with only the day and time agreed to beforehand. Rather than ruminating and discussing endless details, one

partner plans an evening or day with only two requirements: the event should bring enjoyment to their significant other, and should hold an element of surprise.

- Just for fun, bring home their partners' favorite takeout, flowers, or board games to play – something they weren't expecting but that they'll certainly appreciate.
- Have a “no screens” rule for at least an hour each day. Taking time to intentionally remove distractions opens opportunities for spontaneous conversations and, ahem, other activities.

When partners take time to just “be” occasionally – and accept one another exactly as they are – they can keep romances healthy and exciting. For types who are prone to living inside their heads, opening up to new adventures and experiencing the “right here, right now” with their significant others can be just the intellectual *and* physical stimulation they need.

Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships



Diplomats' core traits are Intuitive and Feeling. Thanks to the Intuitive part of that combination, Diplomats and Commanders tend to share a visionary view of the

world. Unlike most other types, they live a world of ideas and abstractions. The one trait Commanders have that's not shared by any Diplomats is the Thinking trait. While Commanders value decisions and motivations that spring from rationality, Diplomats tend to be driven by more empathetic considerations. When Commanders and Diplomats fall in love, there's a good chance that both the gifts they bring to each other and the potential conflicts in their relationships originate from this difference.

Balanced Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships

A Visionary Pair

As fellow Intuitive types, Commanders and Diplomats share a creative, visionary view of the world. Unlike most other types who focus on what's been done or what is currently happening, these two types have their sights set firmly on a future full of possibilities, as well as opportunities to dream up (and maybe even implement) some of their many ideas.

Conversations between Commanders and their Diplomat partners are likely to be deep discussions focusing on their passions, ideas, and life philosophies. Small talk never stays small for long; even chats about daily activities tie into their hopes, dreams, and plans. In fact, much of the passion between these types can come from communicating their unique visions and exciting ideas. When Commanders find Diplomat sweethearts with enough shared interests and a mutual understanding of what each brings to the table, sparks can fly, and big dreams may just become a reality.

Bringing Out the Best

Both Commanders and Diplomats, with their penchant for living in their heads instead of focusing on the here and now, often find themselves misunderstood by more pragmatic personality types. Their shared Intuitive trait allows for a deep level of connection and understanding that goes beyond social niceties and shared interests. Commanders appreciate their Diplomat darlings' abilities to imagine romance that operates outside of the "expected" social constructs. And Diplomats, with their passion for all things unique and creative, find Commanders to be some of the most ingenious and inventive lovers.

These types can bring out the best in each other, especially when it comes to communication, if they're mature and comfortable with their own identities. Both can be endlessly idealistic and look for partners who will support their off-the-wall (and sometimes spontaneous – hello, Prospecting Diplomats!) ideas. Brainstorming about the future can be both exciting and erotic, if Commanders can reign in their tendency to over-analyze ideas and just let themselves dream for a bit. Similarly, Diplomats can benefit from Commanders' voice of reason that encourages their daydreams while still providing a much-needed reality check.

Unbalanced Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships*Logic Versus Passion*

These loving twosomes can face frustrating obstacles if they allow their differing points of view on emotional expressions or romantic gestures to prevent them from appreciating one another. Stoic behavior may be their default mode, but Commanders who refuse to let down the barriers they may have placed around their hearts can struggle to connect with Diplomats who need to *feel* their connections in

a more visceral way. Diplomats may not need something as cliché as breakfast in bed or a bouquet of flowers, but they do need to experience tangible expressions of affection to feel loved and appreciated. Even the most adoring and grateful Commanders can struggle to communicate such feelings effectively if they allow their pride to dictate their reactions and behaviors.

Not only can Commanders alienate their Diplomat lovers if they refuse to express their emotions in healthy ways, but they can also do a great disservice to themselves as well. One of the great joys of being human is the ability to experience an emotion as deep and profound as unconditional love. Barriers that they refuse to break down, or even examine, can prevent them from engaging with their partners in ways that create true and lasting intimacy.

Seeking Solutions Over Empathy

People with the Commander personality type are straightforward and often choose hard facts over softer diplomacy, which can be difficult in budding romances. This can cause issues when Diplomats want to vent about problems. Commanders are especially prone to jumping in and offering solutions rather than expressing empathy or compassion. It's part of their *modus operandi* to fix systems that aren't working. Sometimes those systems may be the people they love.

When Diplomats bring problems to their Commander partners, they aren't always looking for action plans. They may simply want someone to listen to them and acknowledge their pain. Diplomats may misinterpret Commanders' sincere wish to help as a cold lack of empathy and perhaps even an absence of caring.

Of course, this works both ways. Diplomats may offer empathy to Commanders who are looking for rational solutions and not "touchy-feely" sentiments. To

Commanders, this appears to be frivolous emoting with a lack of real substance. A cycle can begin when Diplomats feel dejected because they don't sense that their Commander sweethearts understand what they're going through, while Commanders remain frustrated by what they see as a foreign injection of emotions into their problems.

Rebalancing Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships

Finding Common Ground

Communication and positive perspectives can bring any relationship back to something that's strong and vibrant if given the chance. Maturity plays a role, but to fully succeed, couples need the rudder of intention to steer to a better place. Because of their shared Intuitive trait, these significant others can learn to be open-minded enough to put value in the personality traits of their beloveds. When mature, loving Commanders partner with mature, loving Diplomats, both types learn to appreciate the positives in their partners' ways.

The differences between Commanders and Diplomats regarding emotional expression and romantic gestures can often be worked out in honest, straightforward conversations. Insightful Diplomats grow to understand that Commanders' affections run deep, even if they never fully master outward expressions of love. With maturity, they come to appreciate the love behind any efforts Commanders make. Despite their standards for authenticity, they realize that, although Commanders may not always connect deeply with explicit expressions of love, they're sincere in their desire to please. In turn, Commanders come to appreciate how important these gestures are to their Diplomat darlings. The

following steps can help Commanders to find meaningful ways to engage with their Diplomat partners:

- Learn which romantic sentiments their Diplomat lovers may appreciate, such as Valentine's Day and anniversaries, and then respond accordingly.
- Set an "affection quota" – without, of course, telling their partners. For example, Commanders could hold a hug for 30 seconds at least twice a day. Or, in a similar vein, say, "I love you," at least three times a day.
- Commanders should consider how making symbolic gestures can be incredibly rational in a utilitarian way. As the old saying goes, "Happy spouse, happy house." Make a list of the things such loving gestures might add to their relationships. For example, a kiss when leaving in the morning sets the mood for the day and reassures their sweethearts before a period of absence.

Diplomats likely appreciate the love behind any efforts Commanders make. Despite their standards for authenticity, they realize that, although Commanders may not express love in the same way that they do, they're sincere in their desire to please. And for Commanders, it's likely worth the effort.

Focusing on Empathy Over Answers

Commanders don't readily buy into the idea, but it's true that one can be too honest. Diplomats put significant emphasis on sparing the feelings of others because they believe in the importance of emotional awareness and compassion. Commanders may want to consider the implications of the quote, "Do you want to be right, or do you want to be loved?" Far from being an invitation to behave in phony ways, the quote is more an invitation to frame reality in gentler terms.

Intentional listening is the most valuable tool in the empathy toolbox, as it enables Commanders to understand situations completely before reacting. When their Diplomat partners vent about frustrating situations, Commanders should first listen to get all the information. Then, instead of trying to solve issues, they can simply follow up with reflections that sum up what they've heard. Some specific steps that Commanders can take to practice intentional listening are as follows:

- Repeat back what Diplomat partners say so they know they're being heard. For example, "So, it sounds like you were really upset when your coworkers didn't invite you out for drinks after work." Emphasizing that they truly heard what their partners said is often much more important than judging what they're saying, or trying to fix the problem.
- Adding an empathic statement, such as, "That's really disappointing," is more comforting (and does more to calm the situation) than offering a revengeful solution, like, "You should just ignore them the next time they ask you for help." Though it may not always be obvious why, empathy provides its own solutions to problems, which are often more effective for Diplomats than forced fixes.
- Being aware of their partners' body language is essential. Commanders can get lost in thought, searching for the right solution, and forget the basics of physical connection during communication.
- At some point, once their Diplomats partners have had the opportunity to talk about their feelings, it may then be appropriate for Commanders to ask if their partners would like any suggestions. However, they want to actively resist offering any until they receive the go-ahead.

Everyone likes to be heard. However, it may be important when connecting with others to try to “speak their language.” Knowing what others want and need, and then finding ways to give it to them when appropriate, is an important part of building a romance. Not all problems need an immediate solution.

Commander–Sentinel Romantic Relationships



Sentinels, with their Observant trait, aren’t nearly as enamored with ideas and visions as their Commander partners might be. Such abstract considerations seem impractical to them. They prefer to pay attention to the present moment and the world around them. Despite their differences, the potential for complementary relationships between the two types is immense. Commanders can bring visionary, creative energy to love affairs with their Sentinel partners. Meanwhile, Sentinels can bring some much-needed practicality and social sensibility to Commanders’ otherwise lofty, sometimes self-centered worlds.

Balanced Commander-Sentinel Romantic Relationships

A Deliberate Partnership

Both Commanders and Sentinels respect order and predictability, albeit in different ways. Commanders are interested in more abstract systems as expressions of order, whereas Sentinels find that organizing the tangible is more to their liking. Dating is an excellent example of how their approaches differ. Once Commanders decide to find romantic partners, they view dating as a pressing task – difficult but necessary. They consider what they want in a systematic fashion and use a logical system to develop a list of qualities they expect in potential significant others.

Sentinels also rely on fixed qualities when seeking partners. However, their requirements are unlikely to be determined by a checklist they've developed from pure logic. They rely on experience, gleaning the characteristics they're seeking from traditions they've known, concrete life lessons they've learned, and societal expectations.

Because of their personality traits, both can find a solid foundation by pairing with each other. Although some types prefer a serendipitous approach to love – eyes meeting across the room and that sort of thing – such relations can feel flimsy. In contrast, Commanders and Sentinels who fall in love are likely to have a sense that their romance is very deliberate. Their checklists ensure that all the essential elements are in place, fostering a sense of confidence.

Serious and Stable

Reliability appeals greatly to Sentinels, and Commanders tend to impress them with their serious nature, intelligent demeanor, and intense work ethic. These traits align

with Sentinels' desire for stable lives with compatible spouses. Sentinels' organizational abilities, rigorous attention to daily matters, and regard for social conventions and family can help Commanders compensate for any lack in these areas. Commanders solve problems in the lofty reaches of conceptual thought, whereas Sentinels anchor their lives by attending to everyday concerns.

Commander–Sentinel romantic partnerships can be influenced by whether Sentinel partners have the Thinking or Feeling trait. Those with the Thinking trait can be more at home with Commanders' analytical nature. Feeling Sentinels want more emotional support and communication than their Thinking counterparts. Although Feeling Sentinels are distinct from Diplomats, they do share some similarities in their romances with Commanders. However, unlike Diplomats, they're likely to respond to their emotions in more concrete ways, and they often welcome their Commanders partners' compulsion to offer practical fixes to their problems.

Unbalanced Commander–Sentinel Romantic Relationships

Lacking Appreciation

When Intuitive and Observant types meet, clashing over practical matters can be a regular occurrence. The everyday accomplishments that Sentinels handle deftly, and with some pride, can easily fly below the radar of their Commander lovers. Sentinels rarely ask for praise, but they still enjoy it. When appreciation isn't forthcoming, they may become frustrated, questioning their role in relationships where they feel their lovers take their contributions for granted. Sentinels and Commanders prize loyalty, so this disconnect may not derail their relationships entirely, but lack of recognition creates significant pain for Sentinels.

Nonetheless, Commanders might tolerate dirty dishes in the sink a little longer than their Sentinel sweethearts, especially if they have something else on their minds. It's not overt neglect: Domestic order might be on their radar, but it isn't as high on their list of priorities as it is for Sentinels. Yet, because such everyday matters are so essential to the stability Sentinels value, they can easily become ongoing conflicts in otherwise loving relationships.

Visionary Versus Traditional

Commanders are always looking to deconstruct ideas and reassemble them into an improved state. Sentinels prefer the familiar and accept change reluctantly. Commanders can harm their relationships if they treat them as systems to tweak – Sentinels, even those with the Thinking trait, aren't likely to understand or fully appreciate this mindset. They may even view their Commander lovers' penchant for improvement as a threat to the stability they worked so hard to build. Further, if they interpret such endeavors as criticisms of their efforts, Sentinels easily become hurt and defensive. Commanders rebuilding the world into an enhanced place may appear to be no less than destructive to their Sentinel partners.

Finally, Commanders sometimes enjoy considering ideas that might seem controversial to more mainstream Sentinels. If they take their Commander partners too seriously, they might become alarmed or even offended. An assault on conventional thinking, even if it's solely in the realm of the theoretical, tends to jolt tradition-loving Sentinels. In response, Commanders can see Sentinels as unrefined thinkers, and that attitude can come across to Sentinels as condescension. Without mutual respect, diverse approaches and new ideas can cause rifts in Commander–Sentinel love affairs.

Rebalancing Commander–Sentinel Romantic Relationships

Practicing Intentional Appreciation

Commanders can make a special point to express gratitude to the Sentinels they love. It's easy to discover the many ways Sentinels contribute to relationships, beyond utilitarian things like organizing their households or remembering important dates. Sentinels truly want to safeguard the people they love and do what they can to meet as many of their needs as possible.

Although Commanders are independent, stand boldly in their own paradigms, and don't need to hear applause as much as other types, they shouldn't assume this is the same for their Sentinel significant others. Appreciation can be the most cherished gift Commanders can give them. It's reassuring to Sentinels that their partners endorse and value the stability they create and cherish.

The following are some ideas that Commanders can use for showing their Sentinel partners appreciation on a regular basis:

- Leave a thoughtful thank you note in an equally thoughtful place. (Perhaps a "Thank you for washing my underwear!" note on the washing machine, or, "This mirror sure is clean, all the better to see your face" on, well, the mirror.)
- Make it a habit to thank partners for things like making meals, holding open doors, or washing the car.
- Make breakfast in bed, perhaps adding a nice statement about how much they do and how they deserve something nice as a thank you.
- Say, "I love you" regularly.

Even if it feels forced or insincere to acknowledge their partners' contributions in the beginning, Commanders are apt to realize just how much their Sentinel partners do – and just how appreciative they actually are.

Respecting and Embracing Differences

A common mistake among romantic partners is to see their own traits as superior. Commanders and Sentinels are distinct personalities, and both can be insistent that their way is better. But attempting to remake a significant other into one's own image is rarely successful. Commanders should understand that Sentinels aren't always comfortable with their big ideas and constant attempts to improve things. Without such awareness, trying to force them to "get it" can become a futile obsession.

Likewise, Sentinels may never quite domesticate their Commander lovers as much as they would like. In fact, Commanders are one of the types least likely to be persuaded by others, and the most liable to see compromise as a form of failure. Family traditions may never capture their hearts, and they're often distracted from the conventional aspects of life that are so important to Sentinels. Here are some ways they can embrace and respect their Sentinel darlings for who they are:

- Avoid partner "makeovers." It's a fool's errand to commit to another with the intention of changing them. An appropriate balance would involve each lover *voluntarily* dedicating themselves to their own growth, with an openness to learn from each other.
- Invest time in finding out what each type values. Commanders should avoid assuming they know what their Sentinel lovers hold dear. There may be more depth and substance there than what Commanders may suspect.

- Avoid over-analyzing motives. Sometimes the most obvious reason for something is the only relevant reason. Someone who insists on a meticulous house may not be a control freak, just someone who likes a clean house.
- Remember the original reasons for falling in love – those characteristics probably haven't changed. The disconnect is more likely about shifting expectations.

It's helpful to remember that relationships are often complementary, even between similar types. Thinking of significant others as gifts that enhance, rather than obstacles to overcome, goes a long way in romance, especially when partners have diverse characteristics.

Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships



Commander-Explorer couples are Intuitive-Observant pairs with a typical divide between visionaries and hands-on “doers.” Explorers live almost entirely in the present and seek out the new and the exciting. They’re curious about everything – except long-winded discussions revolving around abstractions and ideas (some of Commanders’ favorite things.) But despite their differences, Commanders and Explorers in love can bring much to each other’s lives.

Balanced Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Vision and Pragmatism

Both Commanders and Explorers enjoy solving things, but the former tend to ponder theoretical puzzles, whereas the latter think on their feet, unraveling real-time problems. Commanders often admire Explorers' love for specific challenges, such as mastering a musical instrument or craft. Explorers are undoubtedly impressed by the ease with which many Commanders can unravel even the most complex puzzles or problems. Despite their different styles, both types share some measure of commonality in their desire to find solutions that might easily overlap or complement each other.

On a first date, if Commanders can connect the ideas they love to play with to something practical and immediately useful, they'll impress their Explorer dates. Commanders who talk about the benefits of learning computer code and how it can be used to develop software to run a 3D printing program, for example, might appeal to Explorers' appreciation of practical, useful skills. If Commanders veer off and begin talking about something like hypothetical social effects of artificial intelligence, however, Explorers tend to be quick to bring them back to the present and more down-to-earth topics.

Open-Minded Meets Spontaneous

Explorers' spontaneity and practicality may actually attract Commanders. Although they have adventurous imaginations, they aren't nearly as comfortable in novel real-time situations as Explorers are. As a counterbalance to their own serious nature, they can indulge in their Explorer partners' freer, fun-loving attitudes. Both Commanders and Explorers think on their feet in different ways. If they can tap into

this in service of their love for each other, they can find rich, satisfying romances together. At the same time, both types value their independence a great deal and won't hesitate to allow their partners the same freedom and flexibility they so desire. Nobody would accuse Commander-Explorer couples of smothering each other.

In committed relationships, these types both appreciate each other's disregard for social conventions. They welcome the space they grant each other when Commanders dive deep into their latest interests and Explorers become so obsessed with their projects they seem almost entirely detached from their home lives. Explorers virtually disappearing on occasion could work out well for independent Commanders, giving them ample time to discover their worlds in their own very distinct ways.

Unbalanced Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Mind Over Matter – For Better or Worse

Their often-blant bias for intellectual competence over physical abilities (or any other skills for that matter) can cause significant friction in Commander-Explorer love affairs. Explorers are likely to be offended by the suggestion that their Commander beloveds' mental abilities are superior to either their own or the myriad other skills and talents they may have. Additionally, Commanders are apt to miss out on some of the truly unique, inspiring aspects of their partners' personalities if they discount their plethora of artistic, technical, and social skills.

Explorers, on the other hand, may find themselves impatient with Commanders' obsession with presenting theories while, at times, neglecting reality. Although Commanders may seem immune to criticism, the truth is they often feel it deeply. Explorers who dismiss their significant others as stodgy, intellectually elitist,

impractical, or boring are committing a sort of reverse snobbery that can be just as hurtful. None of this is fertile soil for growing romantic relationships.

Out of Sync

Commanders and Explorers have characteristics in common – their love of solving real-life riddles, for example. But they differ in how they focus their attention on such puzzles and other matters. When Commanders face a problem, they prefer to spend a lengthy amount of time methodically deconstructing and then rebuilding it, looking for as many viable solutions as possible so they can commit to the best one. Explorers are as persistent as the adrenaline charge they get from working on a specific challenge. Once it becomes too repetitive or feels routine – and once a reasonable amount of excitement evaporates – Explorers are off looking for the next fascination. Novelty is the draw for them, and changing focus is typical.

Commanders' need for meticulous deliberation can annoy impatient Explorers, who prefer to act first and think later. Romance can be tricky to navigate when one type is more focused on acting intentionally and the other is more interested in being spontaneous. Such differences can put these lovers on differing natural rhythms for decision making, and the features they loved so much in each other at first can become a tiresome load when they progress into something relentless.

Rebalancing Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Up to the Challenge

Future-focused Commanders have a strong inclination toward self-improvement. If they remember that romances are about human needs and desires, this quality can hold power in relationships. If they remember that love involves accepting each other

and cherishing each other's gifts, talents, and skills as much as it does growth, this can be their greatest tool. Contentment and emotional fulfillment with their Explorer partners can co-exist with Commanders' preference for rationality and systemic improvement, but only if they strive to create a marriage between their cerebral preferences and matters of the heart.

Love isn't about the right skills, nor the right words. It's about extending one's self to merge on some level with another while holding tight to one's unique identity. Commanders have what it takes to meet challenges and develop wonderful romances based on a combination of their unique styles. Blending their shared desire to improve themselves with their courage to take on challenging tasks can serve them well when they seek to improve their relationships with their Explorer partners. Here are some specific steps that Commanders can take to develop a greater appreciation for what their Explorer sweethearts bring to the table:

- Meet partners in the present. It's easy to dream about what romances could be, but it's more satisfying to live in the moment and appreciate what relationships truly *are*. Taking regular walks together, chatting about the day, or texting them a daily expression of gratitude ("I'm grateful you took out the trash this morning," or, "I'm grateful for the nice evening we had last night!") are just a few ways to acknowledge what lovers bring to their relationships.
- Stop trying to change partners. He may never be into reading about Stephen Hawking, and she may have no desire to discuss the pros and cons of cryptocurrency, but that doesn't make them less intelligent or informed. Instead of trying to get Explorers to embrace their passions, Commanders should spend time engaging with them about some of theirs.

- Make a gratitude list. List at least five things that Explorer partners are good at, that they're admired for, or that just makes people smile. This is something that can be done together, perhaps over supper each evening, or in a more private platform like a journal.

Commanders who have spent much of their relationships focusing on what their partners lack and what their relationships need to be better can learn to see what's truly great about what they have. Self-improvement should focus not just on what Commanders can do to improve themselves in the future, but how they can appreciate their lives, and their loving relationships, right *now*.

Adopting Alternative Rhythms

Adaptation is a requirement in life and, no matter the personality type, it's required for success. This doesn't mean people shouldn't be true to themselves and play to their strengths. For Commander and Explorer couples, adaptation often involves accepting their beloveds' different foci and life rhythms. It doesn't necessarily mean keeping pace with each other – although Commanders sharing their deliberative natures and Explorers their spontaneous styles can be beneficial. It more often means tolerating and even appreciating each other's differences.

Commanders who want to understand the style of Explorers who have stolen their hearts might try joining in on their adventures occasionally. Doing so provides many advantages; the most relevant to romance involves understanding and connecting more intimately with their Explorer lovers. But there are other bonuses to embracing a different style occasionally.

Henry Miller wrote, "All growth is a leap in the dark, a spontaneous, unpremeditated act without the benefit of experience." Whether it is or not, sometimes Commanders

must allow life to unfold more on its own and in a less controlled fashion if they're to experience it more fully. Sharing in their significant others' hunger for the fresh and novel can stimulate that appetite in themselves. A role-reversal that has Commanders initiating what Explorers might normally suggest can pump more enthusiasm into romantic relationships stuck on their differences. Consider the following:

- Look for events Explorer partners might like. Finding out what that is might take some time and objective observation. When choosing, keep the focus on Explorers' preferences.
- Set up a "surprise" date based on one of those events.
- Keep an open mind and a willing attitude – it can make almost anything pleasant and even enjoyable.

Commanders, perhaps a little more than most, cling tightly to their own styles. When these pairs can exchange some of their preferences, both types are treated to a bigger world. But even more importantly, such sharing can pull Commander-Explorer couples with such different approaches to life closer together.

Conclusion

When Commanders are in love, it isn't likely to be the stuff of poets and sonnets. Compared with what's portrayed in popular media, their love lives might appear tepid at the surface. This proves the adage about looks being deceiving. Just because romances don't exude showy emotions doesn't mean intense bonds aren't forming. All relationships take work and attention. With a little focus and prioritization, Commanders can offer profound devotion and meaningful love.

Being comfortable with what it means to be “Commanders in love” is likely to be a significant hurdle for these types. But once they jump it, their confidence gets stronger. They need not look like anyone else or follow the scripts of conventional love stories to have wonderful romances, custom-made for them and their lovers. The rarest version of any collectible is the most valuable – an idea worth embracing when Commanders pursue romance.

Friendships



Driven and intense, Commanders seek friendships that offer mental engagement, big ideas, and a sturdy match for their strong personalities. In friendship, Commanders want intellectual counterparts who understand their goals and keep up with their ambitions. They especially enjoy friends with whom they can be direct and unfiltered, as hand-holding and tact aren't their specialties.

Commanders' propensity for sarcasm, humor, and stark opinions aren't for those who struggle to read between the lines, nor for the faint of heart. But for those who can handle it, they offer exciting friendships full of energy and purpose, creating space for everyone to grow and evolve.

Commander chums can expect vivid conversations, bold ideas, and spirited debates, as well as true respect. Beneath their unvarnished candor, these types hold their friends in high esteem – after all, they hold rigorous standards for the people in their lives, so the very existence of their friendships are declarations of respect. Provided they practice balanced ways of treating others, Commanders can build a circle of friends who enjoy their company and accept them just as they are.

The Leading Edge

To advance on their path of personal growth, Commanders must deepen their social relationships and their understanding of others. Perhaps the most important skill for people with this personality type is emotional awareness, which improves trust and communication in their relationships and ultimately leads to social advancement. Yes, Commanders can accomplish much with their strong minds, ironclad will, and powerful ideas – but good friends can help carry them even further.

Beyond external accomplishments, friendships enrich Commanders' lives on an internal level. Beneath their bravado and independence, they can still suffer from feelings of disconnection or loneliness, and like anyone, they benefit from emotional support. If they learn to relax and accept the joy of camaraderie, their lives can take on new dimensions.

Exacting Requirements

Commanders aren't easy to impress. Although they ignore many traditional rules of social conduct, they have their own high expectations of others. Therefore, their friendship isn't to be taken lightly. When they do meet others who match their requirements, they feel respect and appreciation they can't always express in words.

Sadly, their friends might not be able to feel their esteem. Commanders expect to stay on good terms with their pals without a great deal of maintenance. Common gestures of friendship – such as sending birthday cards, offering a shoulder to cry on, or simply checking in with someone – aren't their forte. This doesn't reflect a lack of affection or an unwillingness to expend effort on their relationships, however. These types pride themselves on being available to their friends whenever they're needed,

particularly if they can offer concrete support or advice. If friends are needed to help bail others out of trouble, Commanders are a good bet.

Pointed Honesty

Some friends build each other up with ego-stroking, but Commanders unabashedly share their opinions – without necessarily considering the resulting emotional impact. Such blunt behavior is rarely intended to be mean. These types challenge their friends to improve just as they challenge themselves, offering what they see as constructive observations. In an age of gossip, false social veneers, and the worship of appearances, their sharp, insightful honesty can be refreshing, if abrasive.

Their forthrightness means that Commanders have little taste for emotional games. They prefer to fight their battles with facts, not emotional manipulation. Although they aren't the gentlest of communicators, their sincerity means that their friends can trust what they say – whether it's positive or negative. If they learn to respect their chums' emotional needs as much as they respect their own opinions, Commanders can foster friendships of mutual trust and support.

Commanders and Friends from Other Roles

At certain stages of their lives, Commanders might be tempted to prioritize personal achievement over their relationships. Once they recognize the value of human connection, however, they're motivated to enhance their social abilities and deepen their connections – which are both tall orders. Fortunately, Commanders have the tools to meet the challenge. When they decide to master something, little can stop them.

Let's look at some patterns that emerge in Commanders' friendships with people from all four Role groups, focusing on strategies they can use to create and sustain beneficial, fair, and fulfilling friendships.

Commander-Analyst Friendships



At times, Commanders can feel misaligned with the world. Everywhere they turn, they spot people making irrational decisions, settling for the status quo, and being fake to be likable or impressive. Fortunately, making friends with other Analysts can help them feel less alone in their values of rationality, progress, and authenticity. When they befriend other Analysts, Commanders often feel energized yet comfortable, delighting in the company of those who understand and accept them.

Balanced Commander-Analyst Friendships

Compatible Creativity

Other Analysts are usually a quick fit for Commanders, as they share a passion for new ideas, knowledge, and unconventional thought. Such camaraderie tends to be based more on intellectual engagement rather than social or emotional support,

which is often how Commanders like it. They may have grown accustomed to feeling frustrated or bored with the world's common and limited ways, and friendships with other Analysts can be invigorating breaths of fresh air.

That air comes in handy because these friends never run out of things to talk – or argue – about. Commanders are full of analyses, questions, and ideas, and other Analysts are likely to keep pace and properly challenge them. These friends love bouncing ideas back and forth, dissecting each other's ideas piece by piece, an oddly enjoyable process. There's pleasant competition in these alliances, with each challenging the other to establish a stronger foundation for their thoughts.

Free to Be

Even independent-minded Commanders can feel the pressure to conform. Every day, advertisements and social media carpet-bomb audiences with artfully curated images of what it means to be successful, happy, or desirable. Spending time with Analyst friends – who share a healthy disrespect for societal expectations – reassures Commanders that they're free to be themselves.

Other Analyst types may challenge them with hard-hitting questions, but at their core, they deeply respect and appreciate their friends for who they are. As a result, time spent with Analysts can help Commanders feel empowered to be authentic and pursue their interests and curiosity with little or no inhibition – whether they're fascinated by sound engineering, avian migration, or New York history. In turn, Commanders who unabashedly pursue their interests, embrace their quirks, and prioritize their values can inspire their Analyst pals to do the same.

Unbalanced Commander–Analyst Friendships

Impatience

Commanders have little tolerance for ineffectiveness, procrastination, or indecision, and their tendency to see broken systems everywhere creates a strong pull to fix things. As a result, they can lose patience with friends who put off taking positive action in their lives. If friends complain about their jobs without applying for new ones, ever-candid Commanders won't hesitate to call them out on it.

This can spark tension with other Analyst types – Debaters and Logicians in particular – who might discuss ideas or solutions without readily acting on them. Although Commanders may hope they're inspiring their friends to finally do something by pointing out their inaction, the approach backfires if they come on too strong. At first, their friends may feel defensive, annoyed, or even stifled. Over time, they might pull away from Commanders altogether, not wanting to deal with their judgment or their impatience.

Problems also arise when Commanders' Extraversion clashes with the socially reserved style of Architects and Logicians. Commanders may have a hard time drawing their Introverted friends out in public; in response, they might push harder, urging their friends toward bolder action. If Commanders can't muster tolerance for their friends' limits, they can become critical, potentially causing offense and leading Introverts to withdraw even further. Overall, their forceful manner runs the risk of steamrolling or provoking their Analyst friends, who can themselves be quite reactive. In the absence of respectful communication, Commander–Analyst friendships won't thrive.

Butting Heads

Even like minds don't always see eye to eye, and when Commanders and their Analyst friends disagree on core views, spectacular sparks can fly. Commanders' Judging trait makes them stubborn, and they may find themselves at odds with other Analysts. Commanders, always ready for a mental duel, may not mind the tension, but when a good friend's personal views are the topic, arguing with every ounce of wit and energy can be a mistake.

For Commander-Analyst friends, battling each other's ideas can easily turn from stimulating to frustrating, testing established friendships or causing new attachments to falter. Commanders often can't temper their compulsion to *win*, which can be a problem with Analyst friends, who tend to have their own strong opinions. If they choose personal power over friendly compromise, Commanders may conclude that some friends simply can't handle the "truth."

Rebalancing Commander-Analyst Friendships

Don't Push – Inspire

Here's a rational argument against pushing friends to act: It rarely works. No one wants to feel criticized or nagged, and even rational-minded Analysts may dig in their heels when Commanders point out how they're failing to live out their ideas. This often befuddles Commanders, whose "pestering" is generally motivated by a sincere desire to help.

So, how can Commanders manage friendships with people who aren't as decisive as they are? The first step is to observe and note their current behavior. Commanders may be surprised to realize how often they bring up their friends' areas of inaction,

such as looking for new jobs or ending relationships that aren't working. The second step is to remember that nobody puts off action without a reason. Either they're encountering resistance – perhaps due to insecurity, uncertainty, or other obligations – or they aren't that interested in making a change – it's idle musing. There's nothing inherently wrong with either state. In fact, even most Commanders have experienced inaction at one point or another in their lives. The third step is to recognize that, if someone is truly struggling to act, showing support usually works better than badgering or shaming them.

To support their friends who are putting off an important change, Commanders can try the following exercise:

- For these types, it's often easier to spot inconsistencies in other people's behavior than in their own. Before commenting on Analyst friends' choices (or lack thereof), pausing to consider whether they're projecting any of their own issues might be revealing. For example, perhaps they're fixating on their friend's job dissatisfaction rather than facing up to their own.
- Listen carefully, and ask questions before offering advice: "What do you think is holding you back?" "What would be a realistic first step for you to take?"
- Commanders want to help in concrete ways, which is a gift – provided their friends are ready for it. Make a specific offer to help only after listening to the answers in the previous step, and ensure that the offer aligns with the friend's vision for next steps. In other words, if someone thinks a realistic first step is to update their resume, don't offer to get them an interview with the CEO of a company.
- Don't impose a deadline on the offer of assistance. Saying, "I'm here to help when you're ready," can go a long way.

- When in doubt, Commanders can inspire their friends simply by making needed changes in their own lives – whether asking for a promotion, learning a new skill, or signing up for a 5K run. That way, friends will know where to turn when they need inspiration, guidance, or support in taking charge.

Commanders might want to provide their friends with hard-nosed “reality checks,” but even with other Analysts, the approach usually backfires. By supporting rather than pushing friends who aren’t acting, Commanders can honor their own desire to help without diminishing their pals’ self-esteem or unduly straining their relationships.

Prove It Together

One excellent way for Commanders and their Analyst friends to relieve mental friction with each other is to step outside the intellectual realm. Debating what’s “right” is tiring. These friends can take a break from seeking complex truths by instead sharing the simple joys of fun-finding rather than fact-finding. Planning hands-on activities together is a great alternative to talkative mind-fests, as real-world experiences can wash tension away. Bike rides, basketball games, and barbecues are just a few examples of how these friends might escape whirling mental potentials and have refreshing fun in the moment.

When disagreements do arise, Commanders and their Analyst friends can break out of circular or hypothetical arguments by embarking on hands-on experiments together. After all, if they collaborate on attempts to find the truth and bring ideas into reality, both gain wisdom and perspective. Commanders love to learn, and chasing data with friends can be doubly enjoyable, by not only providing useful

knowledge but also building stronger friendships through cooperation. Here's how they can get started:

- First, build the skill of recognizing when a debate leaves friendly terrain and becomes unproductive or tedious. Some indicators of such a shift are muscular tension, raised voices, rolled eyes, criticism, contempt, or repeated statements.
- When a red flag arises, steer the discussion toward experiments that could test the idea in question.
- Rather than testing competing hypotheses, choose an approach that's cooperative. Look for ways to make the project concrete, and foster hands-on creation, perhaps by building something or creating a simulation.
- Afterward, review and discuss the results with the goal of discovering the truth, not proving each other wrong.

If such measures prove ineffective, a cordial "agree to disagree" approach may be the only fair solution. It's important for Commanders and other Analysts to recognize that pluralistic objectivity is a mark of an evolved intellect. Basic tolerance may be required between strong-minded, intelligent friends, and it's often the only thing that allows intellectually nourishing friendships to flourish despite differences.

Commander-Diplomat Friendships



Commanders and Diplomats often share a rapid connection because they recognize in each other the ability to see beyond the superficial into deep, mysterious dimensions. Their main difference is that Diplomats tend to view the world in terms of harmonious cooperation and hopeful ideals, whereas Commanders are more likely to coolly consider possibility tempered with probability. The difference is unlikely to derail their connection, however, and can even inspire new understanding for both.

Balanced Commander-Diplomat Friendships

Keeping It Fresh

Commanders and Diplomats often enjoy an immediate sense of kinship, given their insightfulness and their shared passion for fresh ideas. In fact, Diplomats often tick all the boxes on Commanders' checklist for the "ideal friend." Yet they can also help break down Commanders' tendency to reduce people into checklists and categories, showing them the joy in diversity and inspiring them to appreciate people as they are.

Commanders can learn from their Diplomat friends that even the most unassuming people can be exciting, profound, and intelligent. This mindset expands their worldview and reveals what everyone around them has to offer, from strangers sitting next to them on the train to the people they encounter every day. Spotting such potential is Diplomats' specialty; for Commanders, spending time with them can be eye-opening.

Although Commanders excel at dispassionate efficiency, they often marvel at Diplomats' ability to bring people together for the greatest possible outcome. If these chums use their strengths in tandem, applying rational ideas to high ideals, they become a mighty force for the common good – and for mutual growth. Overall, Commanders' relationships with Diplomats run deep, allowing both to explore new terrain.

Balancing Each Other

On a more personal level, Commanders can exchange some truly significant qualities back and forth with their Diplomat friends. Commanders may offer reasoned thinking that accommodates Diplomats' idealism and creativity, helping their friends focus their passionate energy. From Diplomats, Commanders can gain revelatory dimensions of emotional insight, helping them explore the complex mysteries of human interactions – and themselves. These comrades have the potential to lead each other to tremendous personal growth.

Efficiency without compassion is difficult and lonely. Compassion without rational discipline meanders from one unbridled feeling to another. Friends who balance each other in those areas are valuable companions, so there's much potential in friendships that emerge between Commanders and Diplomats.

Unbalanced Commander–Diplomat Friendships

“Excuse Me?”

Generally staunch in their views, Commanders might see Diplomats as relatively persuadable or acquiescent. However, that isn’t necessarily true. Diplomats may shy away from disagreements, but this doesn’t mean they’ll yield to the opinions of others. In fact, they can have strongly held ideals and principles – especially Judging Diplomats.

If Commanders alienate their Diplomat friends by harshly disagreeing with or criticizing something important to them, the resulting rift may be deep and difficult to repair. Some Diplomats may react strongly even to constructive criticism or well-intended feedback. In response, Commanders might push harder, trying to prove the rationality or “rightness” of their perspective. The result is often resentment and disappointment on both sides.

All the Feels

Commanders often think of strong emotional expression as incompatible with truth, logic, or accomplishment – in other words, something to be “dealt with” rather than honored and integrated into their day-to-day lives. For their Diplomat friends, who consider emotional transparency a critical way of connecting with others, such an attitude can come across as hostile and distant. When Diplomats try to unburden themselves emotionally, Commanders may react awkwardly, change the subject, or offer advice rather than sympathy. Even when they truly want to help their upset friends, Commanders can struggle to find words of support.

Such differences can profoundly affect Commander–Diplomat friendships. Sensitive Diplomats might feel judged or dismissed, which may lead them to pull away. On the other hand, Commanders might feel exhausted after spending time with their emotionally expressive friends, eventually retreating from what they perceive as uncontrolled chaos.

Rebalancing Commander–Diplomat Friendships

Preventing “Foot-in-Mouth Disease”

Commanders may be surprised to discover just how much their unflinching honesty can wound sensitive Diplomats, who easily take criticism and disagreement personally. Fortunately, if they take a few simple precautions when voicing their opinions, their incisiveness can be an asset to their friendships.

Instead of indulging in the ego-stroking that some people use to form bonds, Commanders offer directness as an expression of respect. Because it comes from a place of integrity and authenticity, their directness can become endearing to their friends – yes, even Diplomats. By speaking their minds carefully and respectfully, Commanders can ensure that their ideas and feedback help their Diplomat pals, rather than trigger defensiveness or hurt feelings.

So, how can Commanders bring the benefits of their directness to their friendships without alienating Diplomats? It’s easier not to say something in the first place than to take it back, so Commanders do well to put themselves through the following mental hurdles before speaking.

- Consider whether there’s any real benefit to correcting or criticizing friends at this point. Are they in a position to be receptive to feedback right now, or are

they emotionally distressed or upset? If it's the latter, speaking up at this time would likely backfire.

- Resist the temptation to interrupt friends to offer an opinion. Interrupting someone might seem like a time-saving measure – especially if they're just going on and on – but it puts them on the defensive, making the conversation less productive overall.
- Know when to back off giving advice and feedback. For example, never offer criticism or hard-to-swallow opinions to those in emotional distress. Signs of emotional distress include an especially fast or slow pace of speaking, crossed arms or a hunched posture, and – of course – crying.
- When in doubt, before stepping in, ask, “Do you mind if I offer my perspective?” Remember that Diplomats might find it difficult to say no outright, so if they show reluctance, hold off until a few hours – or days – later.

Commanders' directness can be a gift, but in some instances, discretion is the better part of valor. Fortunately, people with this personality type are willing to think before they speak, which prevents “foot-in-mouth disease.” By running through the points above before sharing criticism or feedback with their Diplomat friends, Commanders can save their insights for times when their contributions can truly be beneficial.

Validation + Support + Encouragement

Commanders don't love talking about feelings – and in many situations, that's perfectly fine. That said, they can short-change their friendships, particularly with Diplomats, if they shut down every conversation involving emotions. Diplomats look to such discussions as opportunities to express their true, authentic selves, so relationships feel shallow to them if they can't emotionally unburden themselves when necessary.

As they mature and become more attuned to others' needs, Commanders recognize that some people struggle in relationships that are the emotional equivalent of brick walls. At times, friendships with Diplomats require validation, support, and encouragement. Fortunately, Commanders are perfectly capable of learning effective ways to comfort their Diplomat friends who are going through tough times – even if it doesn't always feel easy or comfortable.

Here's how Commanders can meet Diplomats' emotional needs while staying true to themselves:

- Use the formula: emotional engagement = validation + support + encouragement.
- Start with *validation*, which means demonstrating awareness and understanding of what others are experiencing. Listen carefully. Take care not to speak more than those who are upset, not to interrupt them, and not to unnecessarily discredit what they're saying.
 - Remember: Everyone is entitled to their experiences, and feelings are valid, even if they don't seem helpful or rational. To express validation, simply reiterate the emotions others are expressing, without judgment or minimization. For example: "It sounds like you've had a really tough time of it," or, "It sounds like you're really hurt."

Progress to *support*, which can be as simple as saying, "I'm here for you." Even if it feels awkward to say it (or less effective than offering advice), Diplomats benefit immensely from such outward expressions.

End with *encouragement*, which is an unconditional offering of future support – in other words, "When you want to make a change, I will help you – if you want my help."

Even if Commanders feel uncomfortable or overwhelmed in such conversations, Diplomats sense their good intentions. By following the formula of validation + support + encouragement, Commanders can be there for their friends in the way Diplomats crave.

Commander–Sentinel Friendships



Commanders may find that Sentinels complement them very well as friends. Sentinels can help ground Commanders, offering the tenacity, consistency, and pragmatism that they tend to crave in their relationships. In return, Commanders may enjoy the opportunity to expand Sentinels' awareness beyond the mastery of pragmatic, tangible concerns, helping them develop their own creativity and imagination.

Balanced Commander–Sentinel Friendships

A Solid Foundation

Commanders and Sentinels might seem like an odd match, given Commanders' thirst for innovation and Sentinels' respect for tradition and protocol. But beneath the

surface, the two types share similar desires for their friendships. Both value loyalty and consistency, and although Commanders may not be quite as grounded as most Sentinels, well-rounded Sentinels appreciate the other traits that Commanders offer – for example, their willingness to help friends in concrete ways.

Their similarities create a solid foundation for friendship, with each trusting the other to have their back. Commanders know that Sentinels will show up for them, whether by helping them with a move to a new apartment or encouraging them to focus on what they can do in the moment when they feel overwhelmed. In return, Sentinels appreciate that Commanders take the time to understand things and act with forethought, often serving as stabilizing, foundational influences for the people who matter to them. These chums can stand the test of time, holding strong through the life changes and time pressures that allow so many other friends to drift apart.

Follow-Through

In a world that can seem like all talk and no follow-through, Commanders and Sentinels recognize each other as take-charge kindred spirits. This creates an important baseline of respect in their alliance, which is important, as both Commanders and Sentinels chafe at spending time around people who fall short of their standards. For Commanders, close Sentinel friendships can be a refuge from all the people in their lives who seem flaky or inconsistent.

Thanks to their shared, results-driven mindset, Commanders and Sentinels follow through on their plans to spend time together. They don't swap the idle line, "We should hang out sometime," which characterizes many anemic friendships. As a result, they share experiences and bond in ways that make sense to them, actively

sustaining and developing their relationships instead of simply paying them lip service.

Unbalanced Commander–Sentinel Friendships

Different Perspectives and Priorities

Connections between Commanders and Sentinels often emerge due to circumstance – for example, if they’re coworkers or roommates. In such environments, Commanders are likely to witness Sentinels’ pragmatic effectiveness, which garners their respect.

That said, Commanders may not always understand what seem like obvious limits in others’ approach to life. For one thing, Commanders love to disrupt the status quo and aim for risky, ambitious goals, but Sentinels can be alarmed by the prospect of jetting off on seemingly less secure paths – particularly when current issues need hands-on work. Commanders don’t always understand Sentinels’ respect for conventional expectations, nor their lack of enthusiasm for theorizing. These disconnects can be significant initial challenges to friendships between the two types.

Clashing Values

Commanders tend to be more irreverent and skeptical than tradition-minded Sentinels, which can create tension between them, particularly because these friends may both have mild (or not-so-mild) disdain for those who don’t see things their way. In general, Commanders love to question the institutions that many Sentinels hold dear, from religion to government to social norms and conventions. Alas, many Sentinels are (understandably) resistant when others try to upend their worldview or negate their values.

The dynamic plays out in an obvious way when Commanders point out logical inconsistencies that underpin Sentinels' values and beliefs. Although they're just trying to be accurate, they can damage their relationships if their Sentinel friends feel attacked, talked down to, or belittled.

The dynamic can also harm friendships in less obvious ways. For example, Commanders might try to push their Sentinel friends to have less "conventional" dreams: "Why settle for 2.2 kids, a 9-to-5 job, and a white picket fence when you could be an astronaut/entrepreneur/CEO?" However well intended, such comments unfairly imply that Sentinels' aspirations aren't good enough, which can leave them feeling defensive or unsupported. Commanders can indeed broaden Sentinels' horizons, but they can do so with respect for Sentinels' existing values and priorities. Otherwise, they risk pushing away their Sentinel friends.

Rebalancing Commander-Sentinel Friendships

Befriending Sentinels

In the early stages of their acquaintanceship, Commanders might conclude that Sentinels won't fit the bill, particularly if Sentinels don't seem receptive to Commanders' theoretical or disruptive style of thinking and conversing. Unfortunately, that mindset closes Commanders off from rewarding social interactions – including friendships – with a significant portion of the population. It also keeps them in an echo chamber, where they aren't challenged by alternative points of view or different personalities, even when those alternate perspectives reflect societal norms.

Fortunately, Commanders don't need to be coddled, and they don't expect constant validation. In addition, they see the utility of diverse friendships. They know that, like

everyone, they have weaknesses, and they're rational enough to recognize that they can benefit from friends whose strengths lie in other areas. As a result, Commanders who want to feel more grounded in their home lives or their communities may wish to seek out friendships with Sentinels, who excel in those areas.

Commanders can enhance their open-mindedness – and get to know Sentinels on a deeper level – by doing the following:

- When talking with Sentinel acquaintances, take the position of an interviewer, steering the conversation from small talk to things that truly matter to Sentinels. Seek out ways their interests and perspectives might harmonize (rather than conflict) with Commanders' interest in innovation. For example, it may come to light that Sentinel friends have addressed pressing needs by spearheading initiatives to bring a community together, ensure efficiency, or automate processes.
- Look for common ground – for example, a focus on optimal outcomes. Ask Sentinels what they hope to achieve through their work or other activities. Chances are that they'll have gratifyingly specific answers.
- Even though they're a significant portion of the population, Sentinels can be outsiders or underdogs – and many Commanders can relate. If the Sentinels in question seem relatively comfortable and self-assured, turn the conversation toward times they've upheld their values despite opposition or persevered despite difficulties. Sentinels don't often call attention to their determination, but they enjoy speaking about it when given the opportunity, and it's a trait that Commanders generally find admirable.

Of course, not every Sentinel can be a match for every Commander – and that's perfectly all right. That's the case with people from any other Role group. However,

by using the suggested conversational techniques, Commanders can break through superficial differences, find common ground, and identify Sentinels who can become great friends.

R-E-S-P-E-C-T

Diverse friendships are a gift, in part because they make Commanders question themselves. Do their choices make them feel fulfilled and happy, or would they be better off if they tried a different way of living? Is their definition of a “good life” really the best? Commanders generally recognize the utility of confronting and re-assessing their assumptions, and they may appreciate how interactions with Sentinel friends force them to do so.

Even if they don’t directly address their differences, the two types can enjoy surprisingly pleasurable friendships based on respect and mutuality. It’s important to remember that each friendship serves different needs in our lives, and not every friend must fulfill every need. Sentinels might not “get” Commanders’ unconventional manners and aspirations, and they might not like breaking with convention in ways that make Commanders’ hearts beat faster. However, that doesn’t diminish the fact that these friends can have fun going to the movies together or grabbing a cup of coffee. Whatever their differences, they can still enjoy each other’s company and offer practical, well-intended support when it’s needed.

Expecting all rewarding relationships to be founded on perfect compatibility is an impossible ideal. Recognizing that can lighten Commanders’ loads and brighten their friendships. To reframe their attitude accordingly, Commanders can try the following steps:

- Pay attention to what types of activities are especially enjoyable with Sentinel friends.
- Express appreciation for those moments out loud. It can be as simple as, “I’m glad we were able to see that movie together,” or, “Thanks for following up about getting dinner together. I’m glad we made it happen.”
- Note feelings before and after spending time with Sentinel friends, and express gratitude for any positive shifts: “My mind was all over the place earlier today, and now I’m feeling a lot less stressed. Thanks for that.”

Sentinels are touched by moments of appreciation, and voicing such thoughts aloud reminds Commanders of the strengths of their particular brand of friendship.

Commander-Explorer Friendships



Commander-Explorer friendships have lots of potential, especially if they share common interests. Commanders may struggle to let go of compulsive analyses and simply have fun, but they can look to Explorer chums to help them approach the world with enthusiasm and unworried curiosity. On the other hand, Commanders can help Explorers see their deeper potential and consider the consequences of their

actions. Setting sail is a grand adventure, but they need someone beside them who knows how to navigate; these two can be excellent partners in discovery.

Balanced Commander-Explorer Friendships

Appreciating Diverse Strengths

In truly fulfilling friendships, Commanders appreciate that their friends' strengths differ from their own, admiring their unique and impressive qualities on an individual basis. This is especially apparent in friendships with Explorers, whose strengths include spontaneity and the ability to take deep pleasure from the present moment – two traits that may not come naturally to Commanders. In particular, Commanders – who are at risk of over-thinking things – may be fascinated by Explorers' unencumbered embrace of their individual interests. Commanders are likely to be quite inspired by Explorers' remarkable tenacity, particularly given that it comes from a place of joy and engagement rather than obligation.

When they take an open-minded approach, Commanders recognize the value of such gifts, allowing their Explorer friends to be their true selves, even if those “true selves” aren't quite as rational or consistent as Commanders might prefer. Appreciation of diverse merits helps them grow. By spending time with Explorer friends, they can expand their awareness of the world, engaging with fresh ideas and possibilities.

A Pleasant Surprise

To put it simply, Explorers can be great fun. Spontaneous and action-oriented, they take Commanders on unexpected, memorable adventures – which many Commanders crave. It can be tempting to think that rationality is incompatible with lighthearted fun, but that's hardly the case. Beneath their rational exteriors,

Commanders thrum with wit and irreverent humor, and they enjoy a good time as much as anyone. By helping them relax and enjoy themselves, Explorers remind Commanders of an essential element of their true natures.

Such friendships can have wonderful energy and excitement. Commanders have so many ideas about what's possible, and Explorers prompt them to unbind their minds and take charge with even greater creativity. Commanders often have a strict way of thinking, but Explorers teach them to break their own rules and approach things from unexpected angles. If they happen to share a specific interest or hobby, it gets even better, and they can collaborate with their unique perspectives, sharing many days of fun and discovery.

Unbalanced Commander–Explorer Friendships

Differing Ideas About Engagement

Commanders may see Explorers' tendency to live in the present and follow their whims as shortsighted, and they may even disapprove of Explorers' tendency to move on from unfinished projects. On the other hand, Commanders' stubbornness and reluctance to let go can be very frustrating to Explorers, who may tire of hearing a steady stream of judgment about the importance of following through. When they fail to respect each other's approaches, frustration and resentment brew.

Tension may come to a boil during any type of activity, whether it's shared or not. It can be concerning for Commanders when Explorer friends get caught up in the drama or pleasure of the moment without taking time for logical examination. However, they won't get a rational explanation from Explorers, who simply move on to the next thing before the dust settles. If Commanders spend too much time

analyzing and criticizing, Explorers may simply leave. A lack of foundation for communication can lead these friends to become out of sync with each other.

The Rigid and the Reckless

Commanders might wonder whether their Explorer friends think of them as stodgy or boring. Explorers live in the moment, and they love to act on their desires. For some, that might mean checking out an expensive new restaurant they can't really afford. For more reckless Explorers, "adventures" might entail bridge jumping, rock climbing without proper precautions, or quitting a job without a backup plan. Regardless of the scenario, Commanders may see Explorers' spontaneity and risk-taking as dangerously shortsighted and stressfully unpredictable.

This isn't the foundation for a good friendship. Commanders can too easily fall into the role of the "stooge," acting almost like parents as they criticize their Explorer friends for not being more responsible. This, in turn, can spur Explorers to be more reckless to prove their independence. When friends react rather than respond to each other, neither is the best version of themselves. Inevitably, Commanders tire of caretaking and Explorers tire of Commanders' judgments, and one or both friends pull away.

Rebalancing Commander-Explorer Friendships

Why Bother?

Chances are that Commanders won't want to join all their exuberant Explorer friends' adventures. Their opinionated nature can make it difficult for them to feel excited about the concerts, art openings, or other events their Explorer friends suggest attending. They might also become frustrated if they get involved in undertakings

that Explorer friends subsequently abandon, whether it's building a model airplane or taking a weekend road trip.

That said, if Commanders don't make any effort to share experiences with their Explorer friends, then friendship is likely to fade eventually. As mature Commanders know, lasting relationships require effort and compromise, as well as quality time together. Although they can encourage their Explorer friends to stick with their undertakings, they can't force Explorers to follow through on activities that have lost their interest.

As such, Commanders need to relax their need for control at times, saying yes to their friends' ideas even if they might not work out. As a first step, Commanders might set a goal for how many times they'll say yes to Explorers' invitations. For example, they may aim to join close friends for an adventure at least once a week, or they might decide to say yes to at least one out of three invitations. Without that type of benchmark, it's easy to put off spending quality time together. Fortunately, Commanders are goal-oriented, and when they commit to maintaining their friendships, they follow through.

To find more enjoyment in the things they do with Explorer friends, Commanders can try the following:

- Re-label adventures as experiments. Choose a "lab notebook" in which to record observations.
- Identify a question that the experience can answer – for example, "Will trail running raise my heart rate higher than road running?"

- If time permits, consider doing research about the activity. Learning about trail running strategies and records, for example, might make the experience more interesting.
- Create a hypothesis for the above question. Decide how to measure the results.
- Note the results.
- Revisit the hypothesis and revise accordingly.
- If possible, conduct a follow-up experiment to verify results.

By focusing on an experiment, Commanders can enjoy their time with Explorers just as it is, rather than focusing on whether the activity comes to a successful or (in their minds) satisfactory conclusion. In their own way, Commanders care about being there for their friends. By sharing new experiences with Explorers, they can broaden their horizons – and deepen their friendships.

How About This?

Commanders can take charge in their outings with Explorers by regularly proposing activities that suit their interests, meet their standards, and don't seem needlessly risky or fickle. This way, they won't end up criticizing their friends for failing to take them on well-planned activities. Just as importantly, they won't suffer through outings they don't enjoy, which can cause them to feel resentful or frustrated.

If their Explorer friends want to wander into the backwoods to camp and forage wild edibles, for example, Commanders can say “no thanks” this time – but another time offer to reserve an actual campsite with access to legendary trails and arrange to bring food. Or, if Explorer friends keep inviting Commanders to concerts they don't enjoy, they can turn the tables and suggest performances by artists they admire.

Here's how Commanders can propose more activities that they and their Explorer friends can enjoy together:

- Every time an Explorer's invitation is turned down, make a note of the type of event or outing offered (for example, an outdoor adventure, a music performance, an overnight trip.)
- Research an alternative that sounds more enjoyable (for example, a concert by a performer you respect or an overnight trip to a place you'd like to visit.)
- Finally, suggest these events or activities to Explorers in ways that convey excitement.

The above approach allows Commanders to temper their desire for control with spontaneity, particularly because they can depend on their Explorer friends to liven up their experiences. That said, please note that this strategy is designed to be used in tandem with the previous one above. ("Why Bother?") At times, Commanders benefit from saying yes to their Explorer friends' ideas – especially if the ideas draw them beyond their comfort zones.

Conclusion

Open Horizons

Commanders may be known for their independence, but this doesn't mean they don't benefit from fun, supportive friendships. When they open themselves to understanding and appreciating people with whom they may not share easy or immediate compatibility, they can discover a world of people who can offer good company, fresh perspectives, and consistent support. Friendships can be a much-needed source of happiness and personal fulfillment for Commanders, allowing

them to develop open-mindedness, emotional awareness, and a sense of true belonging – all of which are important steps in their personal growth.

In return, Commanders bring many gifts to their friendships. Although emotional demonstrations don't come easily to them, they communicate their care through respect and loyalty toward their chums, as well as a willingness to step in and offer insightful yet practical help whenever it's needed. Offers of friendship from those with this personality type indicate deep appreciation and commitment; they aren't to be taken lightly.

Branching Out

Although Commanders might assume that they should look for friends who share their values, interests, and approaches to life, that isn't necessarily the case. Their unique combination of traits makes them rational and curious but not always open-minded, and they have deep values as well as a tendency to want to change the world to suit their own rational preferences.

Friendships with people who don't completely share their perspective might not provide obvious reassurance, but ultimately, such relationships create even greater gains. Although Commanders are known for their crisp, unconventional ideas, their creativity stalls if they surround themselves only with like-minded individuals. As they grow, people with this personality type come to respect capability and accomplishment in many forms, which allows for connections with people whose strengths differ from their own. By consciously engaging with others who challenge their worldview, Commanders can expand their minds, achieve new perspectives, and increase their abilities.

For these types, however, friendship isn't just about intellectual expansion. They also crave trustworthy friends who listen to them, stick with them through thick and thin, allow them to be their authentic selves, and bring fun and enjoyment to their lives. Thanks to the open-mindedness and emotional intelligence that they gain from their relationships, Commanders can learn how to establish deep, meaningful friendships – and maintain them over their lifetimes.

Parenthood



Commanders are typically up for a challenge. As a result, they're serious about the role they play when they become parents. They approach parenting with the utmost sense of personal responsibility. People with this personality type hold themselves to a high standard, and they view their children's success as reflecting those standards. They want to see their kids grow into smart, independent people who strive to achieve their goals.

Commanders are unlikely to hover over their children although they're likely to be present and involved to the degree their children need them. They may encourage their kids to extend themselves in the same outgoing way they do, which may not work for all children – especially those developing into more Introverted individuals.

Their high standards motivate Commander parents to focus on helping their children build their own values. They help their daughters and sons create a “code of conduct” that guides their thoughts and actions and helps them achieve their goals, and they hope their children interpret their encouragement as permission to be free to be

themselves. They likely feel they parent best when their children end up finding and following their unique interests.

Commanders' aims are for their children to think for themselves and have a willingness to challenge the conventional. Commanders are prone to steer their kids toward embracing hard work as a value. They're most proud when they can label their kids "self-sufficient" and "proactive" in as many ways as possible.

Unfailingly Supportive

Commanders are consistent individuals who pride themselves on being responsible and organized, and such reliability is a valuable part of the parenting toolbox. Some parents may regard raising children as a responsibility or even a chore. Commanders typically embrace the challenge of bringing up children. They consider teaching their kids to succeed in the world to be a valuable effort filled with meaning and potential fulfillment that's worth their enthusiastic support.

Commanders are by and large carefully consider doling out praise and disciplinary consequences. Although not excessively warm, Commanders still bond with their children in their unique and caring way. They take pleasure in the progress their children make and the successes they achieve. These parents view each benchmark as noteworthy whether it's the first time they tie their shoes, their first spelling test they pass, or, as adolescents, when they first go out with friends on their own. While they may withhold gushing praise, they quietly and proudly make another checkmark on their mental list of their children's progress.

Expecting Too Much

As children develop, their sometimes-quirky behaviors can puzzle parents of any personality type, and Commanders are no exception. People with this personality type thrive on logic, intellectual arguments, and rational behavior, so the nonsensical antics of young children or adolescents can be baffling. No child has the mental or psychological capacity necessary to always behave rationally. Trial and error are essential parts of learning. It would be a mistake to consider even the most precocious children as “small adults”– complete packages in a compact form who respond properly to everything life throws at them.

Commanders’ sometimes-stern opinions can come across as uncaring, even if they don’t reflect their underlying feelings. Sometimes children need a shoulder to cry on, along with more rational life lessons. Learning to integrate rational instruction while providing emotional support may be one of the challenges Commanders must continuously address throughout their lifelong tenure as parents.

Determining Developmental Needs

It’s important to remember that developmental milestones are rule-of-thumb measurements that aren’t set in stone. Like all Analysts, Commanders love and trust systems and may feel more confident if their children stick close to fixed schedules as they progress through their youth. Kids who reach certain milestones earlier aren’t necessarily “advanced.” Likewise, those who achieve them later aren’t always “delayed.” Labeling children in such ways, especially very early in life, can be harmful to their development and their self-esteem throughout their lives.

Pediatricians and family physicians are parents’ best resources for determining whether they should be concerned about their children’s development. They can

provide resources that cover what to expect at different stages regarding physical, intellectual, psychological, and behavioral development. Regular appointments with physicians can ensure that any issues are addressed in a timely manner, putting Commander parents' minds at ease.

Overly Critical

Criticism is another area where Commanders can miss the mark if they don't pay enough attention to this tendency. Their expectations may be excessive, so they may want to guard against becoming impatient when their children don't quickly pick up on what adults see as obvious. Commanders may overestimate their children's abilities and understanding, and perhaps become frustrated when their children don't meet their (sometimes unrealistic) expectations.

Commanders usually prize self-determination and intelligent action above most everything else. They value – and often expect – clarity and emotional stability in others. Parents who rely on rationality alone can alienate emotionally sensitive children by discounting their feelings. These types prefer to believe that the correct solution is the most efficient one, and they can have trouble softening their often-blunt opinions when dealing with their children.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of a child's growth presents unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate the stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachments and create meaningful memories makes the struggle worthwhile.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development comprised of eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. (The stages aren't set in stone, and the ages listed for each stage are approximate.) Children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time, sometimes skipping stages, achieving them in an unexpected order, or trying one milestone and falling back to an old one, which is especially common with babies who are learning to walk. It's worth developing healthy relationships with pediatric physicians to check in with any questions and concerns, as they can distinguish normal developmental delays from more serious concerns.

The following sections discuss some expectations for each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Commander personality type affect their parenting at each stage.

Commanders are hard-wired for helping their children through the developmental process. This doesn't mean they don't have blind spots to overcome. Parents of every personality type have a unique set of challenges to deal with, putting Commanders in the company of every other parent on the planet. A model like Erikson's offers Commanders, with their love of systems, a paradigm for better understanding their challenges and meeting them.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. In these stages, children are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when parents create bonds of attachment by meeting their babies' needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

Trust Versus Mistrust

Infancy, in Eriksonian terms, starts at birth and lasts about 18 months. The main developmental task of infancy involves deciding whether the world is a trustworthy place. If their caregivers nurture them adequately and they achieve trust, children emerge from this stage with an overarching impression of the world as being reliable enough. They viscerally assign a reasonable amount of trust to other people, the environment, and the broader future. Not gaining trust leaves infants with a sense of the world being a frustrating or hostile environment that can't or won't satisfy their needs fully enough. They can come to interpret their environment as fundamentally undependable – and, in the extreme, even a dangerous place.

This stage has implications for future relationships, and it also affects feelings of overall confidence. If someone doesn't expect the world to meet their needs in a reasonable fashion regardless of what they do, they'll approach life tentatively and perhaps even defensively. They'll be likely to assume disappointment rather than success when they try to muster motivation.

Balanced Parenting During Infancy

Built-In Reliability and Experience

Consistency is essential to building trust in infants, and Commander parents attend to their infants' needs by feeding, changing, and comforting them diligently. Most Commanders already have formed precise systems for guaranteeing their lives run smoothly even before their children arrive. Adapting babies to their systems and having them enjoy the benefits of consistent, nurturing environments are almost effortless for most of these types. The sheer regularity of their care goes a long way to building such trust.

Chaotic environments create a sense of general distrust in impressionable infants, but Commander parents likely bring order instead. Infancy is an age of dependence, and these dependable parents help babies feel secure in their worlds. Commander parents are well-suited to welcome their newcomers into reliable environments worthy of their newborns' trust.

Plenty of Energy

Infancy is a trying time for parents because children at this age depend on their parents to provide for all their needs, regardless of the hour. New parents to suffer from sleepless nights, so exhaustion comes with this stage. Commander parents have an advantage as they typically have high energy levels and aren't likely to tire quickly. Their Extravert energy carries them through these exhausting times.

Besides having the momentum to power through their sleep deprivation, Commanders' energy, when used effectively, helps insulate them from some issues caused by exhaustion. While by no means immune, they're less likely to feel anxious, sad, or overwhelmed. Commanders might even thrive on their infants' constant demands, as how to respond to such demands is yet another challenge for Commanders to conquer.

Unbalanced Parenting During Infancy

Not Always Affectionate

Although they're extraordinarily attentive and reliable, Commander parents may need to focus on regularly providing intentional affection. They may not always appreciate their babies' emotional needs. During the infant stage, babies who don't receive enough physical contact with caregivers may later struggle with bonding and

trust. Commander parents aren't likely to deprive their children of touch, but they may see interactions with their infants as necessary rather than organic bonding opportunities. They may also look for more efficient ways of dealing with their children that don't involve something as unpredictable as emotions.

For example, Commanders may be tempted to let their children "cry it out" when it's time for them to sleep. Isn't coddling them reinforcing the crying, and wouldn't withholding the reinforcement extinguish the behavior? Both professionals and parents hotly debate this all the time. But most agree that children need regular reassuring contact. Infants need to be held, to be rocked, or to hear a soothing lullaby sung by their parents until they learn to self-soothe at night.

Adapting to their infants' unique needs can be especially frustrating for Commanders. They may hope for more efficient solutions to what are often lengthy and stubborn parenting problems. They may seek ways to streamline processes and force them to work faster. But anyone who has properly raised children knows there are no shortcuts. It's an exhausting, hands-on process that often defies an organized path and sometimes calls for nothing more elaborate than physical contact and a warm presence. At this stage, touch may be the most valuable strategy available.

Rebalancing Parenting During Infancy

Interacting with Affection

Commanders are extraordinarily motivated and excel at parenting children through the infancy stage when they take the proper steps for overcoming their potential weaknesses. They're not always comfortable with their emotions. But cuddly infants, especially those who return their feelings through smiles, giggles, and other positive reactions, can bring out Commander parents' sensitive, silly, loving side.

It's important for Commanders to remember the value of touch and other ways of connecting with their babies. They may need to set up intentional ways of ensuring enough warm contact.

The following techniques can be useful for promoting both affection and bonding between Commander parents and their infants:

- Reciprocate children's laughter, facial expressions, and even hand motions. Infants bond by instinctively mimicking facial expressions, a phenomenon called "mirroring."
- Cuddle infants frequently and keep them close with wearable child carriers.
- Speak in a soothing voice, sing, and encourage eye contact. These actions help attachment and trust grow.

Physical affection is one of the most critical ways to both build attachment and promote infant growth and development. There's an added benefit of focusing on these types of interaction for Commanders who may devalue emotional displays. They're also tapping into their innate need to love and be loved, and hormones released during physical contact create lasting bonds between parents and children.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Autonomy Versus Shame and Doubt

As Erikson noted, when young children become mobile, they become interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Emerging from the dependence of infancy, toddlers try on independence to see how well it fits. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting everything they find in their mouths, and attempting halting verbal communication are just a few ways that toddlers learn. Because of children's

energy, curiosity, and constant engagement with their environments, exhausted parents have dubbed this period “the terrible twos.” But by trying things out and exploring, children are setting the groundwork for their own independence, and patient Commander parents may find it to be an exciting time of discovery.

During this stage, parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Toddlers who can test boundaries yet receive parental support and encouragement develop a sense of autonomy. When adults excessively restrict, criticize, or make them feel guilty for their need to test boundaries, children experience a sense of shame, and they may also suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. By not developing a proper amount of independence, they may rely too much on external structures and directions from others. Such tendencies can last throughout their lives and can hinder their ability to achieve goals.

Balanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Eagerly Encouraging Learning

Increasing knowledge is a high priority for Commanders, and these Extraverted parents typically encourage their children to engage in activities where they can learn something. The exploration stage can be an exhilarating one, as it contains many milestones: talking, walking, learning how to use and manipulate toys and tools (such as forks and spoons), to name a few. Commander parents tend to provide their toddlers with plenty of stimulation and opportunities for exploration. As part of their exploration, children begin to express personal preferences, which are tiny steps toward solidifying a unique identity.

From reading books that spur the imagination to talking about their kids' life experiences as they occur, Commanders are likely to incorporate learning into everything, increasing their toddlers' knowledge and creating secure bonds between them. The more positive experiences that children have learning with their parents, the more likely they are to seek educational experiences in the future. Commanders who invest themselves by taking a supporting role and encouraging their toddlers' growth and learning lay the foundation for their sons and daughters to succeed.

Open-Minded and Curious

Commanders are open-minded and easily intrigued, making them just as interested in exploration as their children. This shared need to explore the world around them can be an incredible opportunity for both intellectual and emotional bonding. Commander parents have no problem understanding their children's impulse to explore, even when that means testing boundaries. They typically assist by providing the safe yet encouraging "home base" that their children need during their hands-on investigations of the world.

Many parents feel frustrated when their toddlers start to question everything (seriously, *everything*) and make their opinions known. Not so for Commanders. They may experience some of the same frustration, but they counter the feeling with a tinge of pride when their children ask questions that show they want to learn more. Constant questions that begin with "why" may try the patience of some parents, but Commanders are likely to try to provide satisfying, age-appropriate explanations. These parents are more than willing to entertain questions or challenges from children. They expect their kids to respect their authority – they won't deal with their questioning mid-tantrum – but little ones who ask thoughtful questions, or raise

objections for good reasons, often receive thoughtful responses from their Commander parents.

Unbalanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Authority Issues

For Commanders who are insecure in their parenting abilities, this stage can be especially challenging. They may have trouble when children are disrespectful, which is sometimes part of their misguided attempts to grasp more independence. However, it can feel like a direct assault on Commander parents' authority – or, worse yet, a rejection of their love and direction. With their emotions so deeply hidden beneath the surface, parents with the Commander personality type may not even realize they want their children to return love and acceptance. These types show their love by providing guidance and knowledge – often authoritatively. If they don't receive the proper respect, they may become concerned about the depth of their children's love for them.

Commanders aren't offended by their toddlers' wishes to challenge the rules; however, this doesn't mean they'll accept disrespectful behavior if they believe it undermines their authority. This personality type can be rigid, and they may discover that their children's constant challenging of rules and boundaries causes tension. It also may hurt when their toddlers use their new favorite word – “No!” – forcefully and often. Commanders who view challenges to their authority as a rejection of love or respect may find this stage of child development to be the most difficult to endure. If they respond personally, their children may perceive that their explorations hurt others, which may cause a sense of shame and inhibit their attempts at autonomy.

Rebalancing Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Promoting Autonomy Through Positive Discipline

It's easy to become frustrated when children resist complying with those in charge, but it's important to understand their need to test boundaries at this stage. Toddlers must learn how to act independently and become self-reliant, and this sometimes means testing their parents' authority. At this stage, they seek both security and increased autonomy. Commanders must walk a fine line between supporting their children's need to explore and upholding important rules to ensure safety. Toddlers who disregard their parents' requests to stop throwing their toys aren't doing so out of a lack of love or respect for their parents. It isn't personal. Rather, they're challenging the boundaries that their parents have put in place to learn how much independence their adult caretakers might allow in specific circumstances.

A strong, confident voice is essential for parenting, but parents should distinguish between that and a tyrannical, authoritarian voice. Commander parents promote their children's healthy autonomy through encouraging, understanding communication and positive discipline. It helps to look at the use of authority, specifically disciplinary actions, as learning opportunities for children rather than forms of punishment.

Redirection is one of the most effective tools parents can use when dealing with toddlers. This should be distinguished from distraction, where parents try to find something else to occupy their children's attention. Redirection, instead, focuses on addressing the underlying issues of the present circumstance and then finding workable alternative solutions. Consider the following example:

- Imagine a toddler is upset because they can't have a cookie before dinner, and they yell in response.
- Resist the urge to yell back or place them in time-out.
- Make eye contact and speak in a calm voice, saying, "I hear you saying that you would like a cookie. It's not okay to yell, so let's both talk about this using our quiet voices."
- Consider the underlying cause of the child's anger. If the child is asking for a cookie, odds are they're hungry – and hungry children are notoriously grumpy.
- Find a workable solution for all parties. Is there a healthier snack they can have? Could they taste a spoonful of the dinner that's being prepared? Would a glass of water help?
- Once the child calms down, talk to them about how yelling isn't likely to get them what they want.

Discipline should focus on teaching a lesson that helps toddlers develop a sense of autonomy. Taking the time at this stage to make sure that children understand why specific behaviors are unacceptable helps them to realize what's expected of them, and it helps to improve their self-control. Commander parents also benefit from strengthening their relationships with their children by becoming sources of thoughtful wisdom rather than fuming mounds of anger and frustration.

Preschool to School Age (3–5 Years)

Initiative Versus Guilt

Erikson highlighted the preschool years, ages three to five, as a prime time for brain development, and youngsters during this stage gather knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Children absorb information like sponges through constant

activity and a broad range of questions. The Swiss psychologist, Jean Piaget, said, “Play is the work of childhood.” Erikson reinforces this by stating that much of the learning that takes place at this stage comes through play – especially the unstructured kind. Using imaginary play and make-believe games and stories, creativity blossoms as children toy with the power of their own ideas. In addition, interaction with parents, teachers, and peers helps preschoolers grow socially.

When children can’t practice launching activities, when their constant questions and childish make-believe play are dismissed as annoying, they may experience guilt, frustration, and a lack of confidence. They may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative. To help their children navigate this stage successfully, Commander parents can aid them by providing opportunities for them to make their own decisions. Parents must suppress any tendency to be excessively controlling and allow their kids to begin activities, ask questions, receive answers, and lead others in exploratory play.

Balanced Parenting During Preschool

Competent Mentors

Commanders are imaginative, determined, quick-witted, and decisive individuals who excel at making plans and solving problems. They model these behaviors for their children and are likely to encourage their preschoolers to play imaginatively and to practice creative problem-solving through activities like board games and puzzles. As a rule, Commander parents relish explaining various ideas, especially complicated ones, and enjoy their roles as intellectual guides who mold young minds.

Instilling a sense of curiosity, independent thinking, and high personal standards into their children from a young age is just as important to Commander parents as

teaching their children any set of more concrete skills. They embolden their preschoolers to view everything as a learning opportunity. Something as simple as a walk around the neighborhood can be a spontaneous lesson on nature and geography, and a routine trip to the grocery store can develop rudimentary math skills.

Commander parents prompt their children to question everything. They try to instill curiosity and a love of learning from an early age, aligning their involvement closely with the stage's developmental tasks. However, they also need to provide enough freedom for their children to initiate their own activities. They should maintain an adequate balance between guiding their children and leaving them to their own devices.

Promoting Confidence

Besides providing endless information and learning opportunities for their preschoolers, Commander parents model independent thinking skills that also promote confidence. If kids at this stage lack confidence in themselves, they can become excessively dependent on others to lead, inform, or motivate them. Commander parents don't support passivity. Instead, they focus on helping their children feel confident and make choices on their own.

Commanders have well-developed decision-making skills and incredible initiative; both are qualities they can model for their children and encourage them to use. Self-assured parents with this personality type actively aid their kids in developing their own critical thinking skills. At this stage, for example, they might expect their children to use their problem-solving skills to smooth out conflicts with other kids. They're unlikely to pander to their preschoolers' wishes for them to solve their problems for

them. Commanders see more value in helping their children figure out age-appropriate solutions for themselves.

Unbalanced Parenting During Preschool

Insensitive and Critical

Some Commander parents may put more emphasis on their children succeeding in academics and athletics by meeting benchmarks or scoring points rather than gaining more age-appropriate “wins.” For example, they may cheer on their preschoolers when they score a soccer goal while ignoring the fact that they didn’t pass the ball to the other players or display good sportsmanship.

Results-oriented Commanders may overlook the value of softer skills such as teamwork and fair play – important lessons in preschool soccer programs. Instead, they may measure their sons’ and daughters’ success only by the number of goals scored. Should their children not meet the more quantifiable results represented by goals, the message to the preschoolers might be they’re “less than” in the eyes of their parents. In reality, their children may have succeeded wonderfully in the age-appropriate lessons intended. But those results may be less measurable in objective ways.

Their tendency toward insensitivity influences Commanders’ interactions with their children. Even the most loving Commander parents may send harsh messages to their children – whether directly or indirectly. Preschoolers respond easily to criticism, and frequent confrontational communication or indirect messages of disapproval may provoke feelings of guilt that are difficult for young children to overcome. Telling them that their questions are “annoying” or “dumb” can be crushing during this phase. Measuring their achievements against standards that are

too competitive or difficult at their age can be discouraging. With discouragement comes a sense of helplessness that can squelch any initiative they might have. Rather than experiencing their own potency as a growing human being, they instead wonder why they don't measure up when it comes to the most important people in their lives – their parents.

Excessively Logical

Some Commander parents fall flat when it comes to embracing unstructured or creative play. Those who fixate on their children's intellectual development may fall prey to the idea that free play isn't as valuable as "educational" play or guided learning activities. They may focus their energy on providing learning experiences instead of allowing their little ones to find their own way and spontaneously explore their worlds.

Commanders love systems and may crave organized play, but sometimes it's better to leave their children's play unfettered. When taken too far, their organized approach may leave too little room for their children to make the discoveries – and the important mistakes – necessary for developing competence and initiative. Guidance is always a part of parenting, but preschoolers can't be programmed in some exact manner. Their learning experience is likely to be hindered if they don't have room to discover life on their own. Free play is better than a structured program at this age.

Rebalancing Parenting During Preschool

Increasing Compassion and Understanding

For Commander parents to support their children's self-confidence and teach them healthy social skills, they must practice compassion and understanding themselves. Excessive or unnecessary criticism is especially damaging to preschoolers. At this stage, children are just developing confidence in their abilities and the initiative to continue learning of their own accord. Too much negativity can easily stymie these efforts.

To prevent the guilt and withdrawal that may evolve when kids feel as though they're continuously wrong, Commander parents should reassess how they communicate with their preschoolers. Are they modeling compassionate communication? Are they patient when engaging in stressful conversations, or do they become critical? Do they promote empathetic behaviors such as concern when someone is sad, angry, or hurt? Or do they avoid other people who are expressing emotions? If they find they aren't communicating in ways that model compassion or understanding, Commanders can try the following activity:

- First, consider a situation that triggers an angry or critical response, such as preschoolers frequently ignoring their parents when they're asked to pick up their toys.
- Next, think about the "default" response that occurs.
 - Is there yelling?
 - Are threats made to take away (or throw away) toys that aren't picked up?
 - Are threats made about possibly sending the children to time-out?

- Are the kids told that they're lazy, disrespectful, or naughty?
- Now, write down what about that behavior elicits an angry or critical response.
 - Are there feelings of disrespect on the parents' part?
 - Do the parents feel that their children don't like them?
 - Is there an underlying concern that the children are just plain "bad?"
- Instead of taking their kids' behavior personally, Commanders should consider ways to respond with understanding. In our example, they may not want to pick up their toys because they're having too much fun, or they may be very tired.
- Respond so it addresses the behavior with compassion rather than frustration.
 - "I know you're tired, but we need to pick up the toys before you lay down. Here, let me help you."
 - "I know you're having fun, but we have to go to the grocery store, so we need to pick the toys up now. Don't worry; you can play with them again when we get home!"

Understanding is the root of compassion. Taking the time to decipher their preschoolers' real intentions and needs allows Commander parents to connect with their children in valuable ways. Walking a mile in their little sneakers can go a long way toward positive parenting.

Promoting Creative Play

Learning to gauge their children's developmental readiness can be difficult for Commanders focused on achievement. Rather than constantly worrying about where their kids fall on the bell curve, they can focus on allowing them to develop more organically. Children don't need a constant itinerary of structured learning

periods with just “educational” toys and games. Simple toys available “on demand” allow them to engage their imaginations – the first building block for growth.

Being flexible doesn’t mean all play and no work. One way that Commander parents can promote both learning and autonomy without being too controlling is to allow their preschoolers to engage in imaginative, unstructured play. Consider playing house, pretending to be dinosaurs – with improvised costumes, perhaps – making up silly stories, or even playing a game of “hide-and-seek” to model the benefits of play and strengthen the parent-child bond. Unstructured playtime is important for children at this stage to gain competence, confidence, and initiative. Here are ideas for unstructured, child-led play that Commander parents can include in their plans for the day. They promote creativity and imagination in ways that structured play and video games cannot.

- A game of “Simon Says,” where the children take the lead telling their parents what to do.
- Play that involves building or creating something from scratch, with materials such as blocks, clay, paper, crayons, or paint. (Consider setting these up in a place where messes can be contained.)
- Outdoor play, with natural items such as sticks, stones, dirt, and water, promotes creativity and imagination in ways that structured play and video games cannot.

Encouraging free, unstructured play doesn’t mean that Commander parents must totally abandon educational play or learning activities. The key is finding a balance between structured activities and the freedom that children at this stage need to develop initiative and self-confidence.

School Age (5-12 Years)

According to Erikson, the elementary school years are an important period of skill development for young children. They aren't only absorbing new information. These children are refining their knowledge and using it to develop skills in increasingly complex ways – from relationships to school subjects to athletics. They develop even more autonomy as they head off to school to spend a large part of the day apart from their parents and families. Parents who challenge and support their kids in such pursuits help them flourish in both their abilities and their self-confidence.

This stage is somewhat of a Goldilocks scenario: Children don't benefit from either “too hot” or “too cold” parenting. If they don't receive enough consistent support and achieve enough success at this stage, they can feel inferior to their peers and become so demoralized that they're less likely to work toward achieving long-term goals on their own. But if adults make everything too easy for them and they aren't sufficiently challenged, kids may assume undeserved confidence in themselves and their abilities. This can lead to a sense of entitlement that leaves them unmotivated to try harder. Parents must allow their children to hit a few of life's potholes on their own. Experiencing the valuable lessons that come from trial and error helps them deal with life and all its imperfections – theirs and everyone else's.

Balanced Parenting During the School-Age Years

Encouraging Expertise

As parents, Commanders have no trouble challenging their children to improve themselves and to set and achieve increasingly ambitious goals, though children's goals may not always take forms expected or appreciated by their parents. However, becoming expert in any field is important to Commanders, so they take every

opportunity to promote their children's drive to increase their knowledge and skills. Are their kids passionate about dinosaurs? Parents with this personality type are likely to provide them with books, educational videos, and museum trips galore.

Not ones to settle for merely "learning about something," Commander parents place much emphasis on developing competence. They work to inspire their sons and daughters to build skills and abilities, especially in their intellectual development. Although Commanders prize intelligence, they're no strangers to the value of basic hard work and a passionate approach, and they encourage their children, regardless of levels and abilities, to achieve their personal best.

Supporting, Setting, and Achieving Goals

Setting and achieving goals are integral to children's learning at this stage, and Commander parents are happy to model the focus and determination necessary to succeed. School-aged children face steadily increasing expectations at school and elsewhere. They gain much from those who can teach them how to meet expectations strategically. Parents with this personality type take pleasure in sitting down with their kids to help them map out the steps to achieve academic, social, and personal objectives.

Developing long-term goals is challenging for children who lack the maturity to plan effectively. This skill becomes increasingly necessary during the school-age years, and Commander parents can draw on their own experience with planning and setting goals to help their daughters and sons prepare for projects. ("Ok, you want to make a solar-powered toilet for the science fair? Let's figure out what you need, and the time needed, so that you can make the best potty possible.") They can also

provide their kids with the resources to achieve specific goals. (“You want to make the swim team this year? Great! I’ll take you to the pool, so you can practice.”)

Unbalanced Parenting During the School-Age Years

Pervasively Critical

Commanders can become so focused on succeeding and doing things perfectly that they may erode their children’s confidence with unrelenting streams of criticism. Sometimes the criticisms are blatant: “There’s no excuse for less-than-perfect grades. Anything less than an ‘A’ is unacceptable.” Other times, they may engage in criticism less obviously through body language or by highlighting the achievements of more “successful” peers or siblings too often.

When Commanders carry over their own perfectionist tendencies into their parenting, they may subconsciously expect negative results when they interact with their children. When assuming the worst becomes their default, Commander parents may cause their kids to feel the constant presence of disapproval, which can negatively affect the confidence they need to develop skills and to acquire a sense of competency.

Overwhelming Expectations

It’s possible for Commanders to push an achievement-oriented view on unwilling children – those more interested in building relationships than becoming stars of the basketball team or valedictorian of their class, for example. Sometimes ambitious parents may see their children’s performance as being more about their success as parents than their kids’ reasonable progression through a developmental stage. Constant pressure to perform in pursuit of higher levels of success can overwhelm

sensitive children, making them feel inadequate and unworthy of their parents' love. Sometimes, Commander parents who take a tough-love approach may do much more harm than good to children's self-esteem.

School-aged kids who feel constant pressure and little support may become withdrawn – pulling away from the people and circumstances causing the pressure. Or, they may act out, expressing their frustration in unhealthy ways. While the pressure they place on their sons and daughters may be the product of good intentions, Commanders who don't consider their children's emotional needs may unintentionally damage their relationships with them.

Rebalancing Parenting During the School-Age Years

Becoming an Active Listener

It's important for Commander parents to balance their need for perfection with compassion and support. Peers and teachers exert an increasing influence on school-aged children, but parents still take the lead in developing kids' skills, goals, and self-esteem. Commanders who struggle with excessively perfectionist tendencies or competitive natures must try to decrease their criticism and focus on empathizing with their children. As ambitious as they are, and as successful as they hope their children can be, they must learn to temper their motivation with compassion.

Active listening is one of the most effective ways to practice compassion. The following suggestions can help Commander parents to develop active listening skills to communicate with their children more compassionately and effectively:

- Take time to listen to kids' concerns, questions, and frustrations. Listen first, before focusing on how to solve their problems.
- Don't interrupt.
- Pay attention to body language. Consider sitting or kneeling on the same level. Use postures and expressions that confirm listening.
- Once time has been taken to improve understanding of their situations, focus on working with them to help them find solutions (if necessary).
- Remember, it's also important for parents to practice non-judgment when actively listening to children. Listening is usually more important than offering an opinion – an important skill to learn when communicating with children and adults alike.

Compassion, effective communication, and thoughtful perspectives are all products of active listening. But active listening has the added benefit of allowing children to define their own problems and explain their circumstances. Commander parents who practice patience and a light touch can help kids develop critical thinking skills during the process. Active listening allows Commanders to empower their children further.

Focusing on Comprehensive Development

Challenging their children to improve is a worthy goal for all parents. That said, constantly pushing them to exceed their limits is likely to cause more harm than good. Kids' confidence decreases when they believe they aren't meeting their parents' expectations, causing them to either withdraw or act out in frustration. Commanders who believe they're doing their children a favor by pushing them to succeed may be in for a rude awakening when they discover they're pushing them away.

These parents can learn to balance their expectations with a more comprehensive approach to their children's growth. Gaining competence is important during this stage, but it means much more than doing well in school, clubs, or sports. School-aged children spend more time interacting with others outside their families and developing their own identities, so learning healthy emotional and social intelligence is essential. Commanders who can recognize (and help with) their daughters' and sons' growth in areas other than intellectual development are more likely to strike a sensible balance. Here are some concepts that may help Commander parents:

- Promoting (and practicing) healthy emotional awareness and expression: Understanding what emotions are being experienced, and then expressing them properly and effectively, are among the most challenging – but most rewarding – skills parents can learn alongside their children. Charts are available online that can help youngsters of all ages label what they're feeling.
- Engaging with empathy: To communicate in an efficient and considerate way, it's essential to look at the situation from others' point of view. After actively listening to kids, paraphrase their experiences and try to apply both logic and feelings to the events in their lives.
- Practicing impulse control: Parents who control their behavior and desires promote self-discipline, one of the most necessary skills for achieving success and building healthy relationships. Although this isn't generally hard for Commanders, children can try their patience. It's helpful if these parents remember to keep their responses measured and aligned with their children's developmental needs.
- Forgoing criticism and focusing on the positive: If criticism is necessary, try to balance it out with praise and/or hope, either in the moment or later. For example, "I know you're disappointed about not making the team. I'm really

proud of you for trying out. I bet if you practice regularly for the next few months, you'll have an even better shot next season. I'll help you make a practice schedule." Always make any criticism about specific behaviors, not overall worth. Let kids know that all competent and good people make mistakes and fail sometimes.

Kids thrive when they have the confidence to be themselves. When their lives are in balance, they're happier in the moment, and more successful in their future efforts. Building the above skills pays big dividends for children later in life, and it also promotes healthy relationships – including their relationships with their Commander parents.

Adolescence (12–18 Years)

Identity Versus Role Confusion

This transitional period centers on kids' sense of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To resolve their roles, adolescents in this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. During this pivotal stage, they make educational and pre-career decisions, and develop relationships based on how all those things align with their values and beliefs.

Erikson described adolescence as a time for children to refine their true selves and distance themselves to a degree from their identification with their parents and family members. Life takes some of the focus off their external behaviors, like in the earlier stages, by adding the impactful internal questions, "Who am I? What part do I play in the world from here on out?" These questions add new depth during this time

of growth, and a sense of unique identity emerges when this stage is successfully executed.

Typically, society allows leniency (sometimes reluctantly) for adolescents to experiment to “find themselves” during this period as they test various roles. Take, for instance, teenage fads and trends that baffle adults. Sometimes, it’s as routine as the adolescents trying out different clubs, school electives, or various social groups. Some parents may be pleasantly surprised to see a wholesome value arise independently because of something their teens experienced.

Whatever the result (and however jarring it may occasionally be to the adults in their lives), some amount of experimentation is necessary before teenagers can successfully form their own adult identities. Should adolescents not “find themselves” during this period, they may face a confusing lifetime quest that keeps them always searching and never fully deciding their purpose or direction.

Balanced Parenting During Adolescence

Encouraging Exploration

As in their toddler years, adolescents find themselves in a transitional stage focused on exploration. This time, however, they focus their exploration on their identities, rather than exploring their external environments. The work of adolescence is largely internal as they seek to reconcile who they are with the world around them. Commander parents who embrace their thirst for knowledge as a tool for personal improvement can be exceptional models for this growth.

Parents who embrace their own sense of confidence in fulfilling their personal visions can also model their passion for learning for their teens. Learning new skills or

mastering new topics take curiosity and dedication, and Commanders have ample amounts of both. Their natural need to learn and excel is obvious, and their kids witness such behavior regularly. These types encourage their sons and daughters to explore their interests, regardless of whether those interests are “useful” or “practical,” and this support can be the confidence boost that adolescents need to chase their passions.

Promoting a Code of Conduct

During this stage of identity development, teens need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. One of the essential facets of personal growth for Commanders is their development of a “code of conduct” they can use to support their character and their actions. Those who remain open to others’ perspectives and needs can encourage their children to develop their own unique code of conduct as well; ideally, their sons and daughters can find one that resonates with them and isn’t reliant solely on external and social pressures. If their code of conduct encourages hard work and ambitious goals, Commander parents tend to let their children fill in the blanks to meet their personal needs and wishes.

These parents encourage their children to develop this code of conduct by promoting and modeling such positive values as efficiency, confidence, and lifelong learning, while providing an encouraging environment for their teens. They may struggle with less control over their kids over time – especially as their adolescents claim more independence, as most do. Nonetheless, Commanders remain interested in helping their kids’ personal development – in fact, most people with this personality type strongly agree that teens need to be ready adults by the end of adolescence.

Unbalanced Parenting During Adolescence

Demanding Authoritarians

Parents who have an authoritarian bent, as Commanders sometimes do, may struggle with this tumultuous stage of development. Young adults in this phase of life are grappling with their expanding independence and the responsibilities that come with it, and they often need the benefit of an understanding conversation with their parents to negotiate new expectations and experiences. Commanders who obsess on enforcing prevailing (and perhaps outdated) rules too rigidly may butt heads with their teens, with little good to show for it.

There's a significant difference between being *authoritative* and being *authoritarian* as parents. Authoritative parents are trustworthy, reliable, and considerate caregivers who clearly know what they're talking about. Authoritarian parents focus on strict obedience to authority regardless of specific circumstances. Commander parents who don't adjust their grip on their children as they mature may push their growing teenagers away, as their basic developmental job demands they explore ways to stand on their own two feet.

Teens often feel a tinge of resentment, even with the most reasonable rules. Adolescents who feel that their parents disrespect – or resent – their newfound drive for independence may come to lack the confidence and motivation to pursue their personal development, both in the moment and later in life.

Overly Judgmental

To kids at this stage, critical comments can be devastating, especially those about their abilities or personal style. They already feel constantly judged, and the many

changes that come at this time of life often have them feeling awkward in their own skins. Teens who are coming to terms with who they want to be versus how society views them often have a fragile enough sense of self. Commander parents who constantly move the goal posts for success (“Good thing you passed that test – but next time, shoot for an ‘A.’”) can undermine their children’s self-esteem and their relationships.

Constant criticism and reminders of any previous missteps their kids may have made can breed resentment. Rather than forgiving their misdeeds and helping their teens deal with the results of their actions, judgmental Commanders may focus on holding mistakes over their children’s heads as reminders of their failures. They may believe this is the best way to ensure that their sons and daughters won’t repeat their errors. Unfortunately, more often than not, such unconstructive criticism strikes the recipients as mean and unfair. Adolescence need understanding and context to help them learn from, and eventually overcome, their struggles. Habitual parental responses that have them feeling chronically “less than” aren’t helpful during this time of life – if ever.

Rebalancing Parenting During Adolescence

Adjusting Expectations

As Commander parents learn to navigate their children’s changing needs and growing independence, they must occasionally change course. This stage requires constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations as adolescents become more capable, responsible, and mature. Parents with the Commander personality type may struggle to reduce the control they exert over their kids. This isn’t necessarily because they view their teens as incapable but, rather, because they believe

themselves to know more – and they probably do. However, leaving room for flexibility and exploration fosters adolescent children’s identity development, allowing them to feel capable by providing them the space to pursue the important task of achieving independence.

Commander parents who wish to encourage their children’s personal growth and independence while still preserving structure and boundaries can promote their children’s self-discipline. Adolescents who can engage in self-discipline – tapping into their values and knowledge to choose the right decision and delaying gratification when necessary – are much more likely to be healthy, independent, and successful adults. Authoritative parenting allows children to learn discipline for themselves.

One example of fostering self-discipline is to teach adolescents how to manage their emotions – an especially difficult task at this stage – using the “ABCDE” method. To utilize this technique effectively, however, Commander parents must remain sympathetic to their children’s needs, and avoid forcing them to apply reason in the heat of their emotions. Allowing teens a chance to vent and then cool down can lead to the more meaningful practice of the ABCDE exercise.

The ABCDE method, step by step, is as follows:

- A: Identify an activating event.
 - Example: Failing a driver’s license test.
- B: Determine the irrational beliefs that resulted from the event.
 - The test was impossible; the test-taker was not smart enough to pass.
- C: Consider the emotional consequences of those beliefs.

- Anger, frustration, and sadness that results in their yelling at their parents; they lose faith in their ability to succeed.
- D: **D**ispute or challenge the irrational beliefs.
 - Discuss the irrational belief, like an impossible test or their own stupidity, and determine whether the event was more likely caused by a lack of study and practice, leading to test anxiety or knowledge gaps.
- E: Replace irrational beliefs with new, **e**ffective beliefs that result in positive behaviors.
 - More study and practice before retaking the driver's license test can increase knowledge and improve confidence, hopefully preventing test anxiety and resulting in a passing score.

Commanders may have to help their adolescent children through the ABCDE process a few times before teens are comfortable practicing it on their own. With this technique, teens can eventually learn how to handle their emotions. These are the foundational skills behind self-discipline. Commander parents who practice with their children can help them to develop the tools they need to function most effectively on their own.

Cultivating Positive Communication

Even when they're at their most judgmental, Commander parents are caring. They want their children to be happy and successful. Hassling their kids for less-than-perfect grades, or criticizing their wish to get degrees in fields they judge to be "not worthwhile" ("Art history? That's a hobby, kid."), they may dishearten their teens when they only intended to support them. Commanders want what's best for their children, but how they communicate that sentiment can become muddled by their opinions and "know-it-all" attitude.

Commander parents' first step to solving the communication problem includes seeing a torrent of criticism, or their tendency to constantly point out their children's logical fallacies, as missing the mark. That doesn't mean there isn't room for measured correction if expressed in a way that's respectful of the adolescents' honest efforts and interests and their inherent value as people.

Counseling is a better model than critiquing. Telling adolescent children everything that's wrong with their ideas/beliefs/clothes/taste in music may seem effective. But a constant focus on the negative can erode both their teens' confidence and the parent-child relationships. Approaching communication in an encouraging, positive way, without judgment or condemnation, can improve their rapport and increase their children's confidence and self-determination.

The following tips can help Commanders communicate with their adolescent children in a much more positive, productive way:

- Suspend judgment – to prevent potential misunderstandings, don't jump to conclusions or make assumptions about motives, beliefs, or opinions.
- Don't discount feelings – to communicate in honest, open ways, adolescents must feel as though their parents are considering their feelings.
- Avoid arguing – nothing escalates a simple conversation to a full-blown fight faster than being combative.
- Speak compassionately – be intentional about not expressing things in a condescending, angry, or critical way when engaging in a conversation.

To be clear, Commander parents are hardly ogres at heart, and they often come from a place of good intentions. But they can be blunt and focused to the point they may not read their audiences well. Their audience, in this case, is their sensitive

adolescent children who are likely having a challenging enough time dealing with some major life changes without the perception of parental hostility. Expediency and order can sometimes mean addressing feelings, egos, and other sensitivities before gently guiding teens who may not be in the mood for advice.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Commanders have their own unique strengths – imagination, open-mindedness, determination, and dedication – they can use to parent successfully, as well as weaknesses they need to understand and balance to build positive relationships with their children. Parenting brings enormous potential for personal development, and Commanders can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use the opportunity to do so.

The advice provided in this chapter considers the general growth stages for children, as well as the basic strengths and weaknesses that many Commanders share. All children are different, and parents are the best judges of what their children need. Readers should use the advice above in a way that works best for their families without adding unmanageable stress, frustration, or burden. For special circumstances, such as persistent behavioral or medical issues, consult with a professional pediatrician or pediatric psychologist to develop a plan that addresses the needs of everyone involved.

Academic Path



Being a student is a large part of life, and whether studying in the classroom, in the workforce, or along the general path of life is up to the individual. Most people spend at least some of their formative years in a traditional school setting. No matter how long people remain in the academic world, the time they spend there can be valuable if they so choose. Not only can these years determine a career path, but they can also affect self-esteem and other aspects of personal psychology well into the future – in both positive and negative ways.

When civil rights activist Malcolm X said, “Education is our passport to the future, for tomorrow belongs to the people who prepare for it today,” Commanders likely took it to heart. This is a personality type who sees education as a means to an end. Commanders, being strategic long-term planners, set goals and then work furiously toward them, using all resources at their disposal, including the tool of education.

To maximize the benefits of their education, it’s useful for these types to fully explore their interests and preferences. It’s also important to remember that all personality types have weaknesses to deal with, and it’s no different for Commanders, who are

likely to dismiss their shortcomings as trivialities. It's helpful to address these challenges, and their appetite for knowledge and reason gives them a strong foundation for dealing with both their positive and negative tendencies, especially when it comes to the world of learning.

How Commanders Learn

Commanders love problems that need solving. When they look at systems or designs, they're able to see them in their entirety – including what they could be and what's currently missing that keeps them from their full potential. If these flaws and gaps bother them enough, they feel compelled to fix them. However, it's a mistake to characterize Commanders' pursuit of knowledge as a matter of application alone. These types strive to feel challenged by the path they're on. Innovation, improvement, and logical progress matter a great deal and help fuel their motivation to learn. If their learning paths need fixing, they step in and address them by way of formal education, on-the-job training, or independent skills-building.

Balanced Learning Habits

Knowing When to Rest

Academic success for these types may look like being the best at a chosen skill within their peer group – whether that skill is perfecting spreadsheets, mastering the clarinet, or being the student with the most trophies in basketball. To achieve their personal idea of success, they develop the ability to push past both physical and mental barriers to meet their goals. When taking a balanced approach to their studies, however, Commanders, more importantly, also know when to rest.

When it comes to choosing those periods of rest, Commanders may turn to their rationalist attitude and respect for systems and research, opening themselves to effective techniques proven by a respected authority. This is a type who might, for example, read about effective study methods in a psychology textbook and make the connection between the text and their own day-to-day behaviors. Research shows that rest makes things work better, and specific study methods can increase retention better than others. Commanders are likely to test these theories, then commit to them if they appear valid.

Expressing Openness

It would be inaccurate to call Commanders close-minded. Understanding reality depends on their being willing to consider new ideas, a need that's core to Commanders' values. This open-mindedness is a result of their Extraverted and Intuitive traits working together, raking through concepts and ideas from either their immediate network or more global inspiration. Commanders who take this balanced approach to exchanging ideas allow others to express their thoughts, and, in turn, these types provide insightful, constructive criticism or an eagerness to implement these new concepts.

Such open-mindedness can be crucial to Commanders' progress in academics. They understand that, while their ideas are brilliant, they can be even more so when they collaborate with their fellow students or instructors. This can look like discussing with a professor why they disagree with a lesson or method of teaching, but then being open to the professor explaining the benefits of their approach, which Commanders can then test out for themselves. In the end, Commanders are concerned with what can optimize a situation.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Burning Out

Commanders may mistake working themselves to the bone as “discipline.” Rather than allowing themselves to relish their current academic success, they instead may push full speed ahead toward long-term goals, putting off contentment and fulfillment until a vague point in the future when all their ducks are entirely lined up in a row. There’s a difference between doing well in the “Marshmallow Test” – or delaying one’s gratification to reap a greater reward later – and an outright inability to feel pleasure.

These students may feel guilty for giving themselves time to rest. They may even fear being out-worked by others, forgetting that other students’ successes don’t mean their own failure. This fear can lead them to an intense rut, and, in the worst-case scenarios, burning out completely. In the end, they may become what they fear most – counterproductive.

Closed to Other Ideas

Commanders can be very unsupportive of any ideas that distract from their primary goals, and even more so of ideas based on emotional considerations. When taken too far, they won’t hesitate to make this clear to those around them, regardless of how it makes people feel. It’s not unusual to see Commanders toss out seemingly incompetent classmates from group work, or completely disregard teachers as undeserving of their attention. Although this may work in some areas of life, it may not be the best route when it comes to learning, which is largely about accepting new perspectives. Commanders who take an unbalanced approach may burn every bridge in sight and stunt their academic growth.

In an academic setting, this could look like Commanders marshaling a group project – but before the group can even get together, they have the direction and objective set without anyone else’s input. While this by itself isn’t inherently bad, it can easily become so when they’re also unwilling to accept any other suggestions throughout the rest of the project.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Creating a Leisure Budget

Commander students may think it’s a good idea to work themselves ragged. However, one of the best things they can do for themselves is to reframe the idea of “rest” as something beneficial rather than a waste of time. Without rest, these types can find themselves burning out and reducing their productivity. By incorporating rest into their schedule, or creating blocks for leisure time, Commanders can find themselves in peak condition to take on their studies.

There have been several studies conducted that suggest working long, unbroken hours may be the *worst* thing one can do for productivity. In the medical journal *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience*, the research of Dr. Simone M. Ritter and Dr. Ap Dijksterhuis suggests that a “mental fixation” on a task can impede the generation of new and appropriate ideas, a concept that would be appalling to progress-concerned Commanders. In the following exercise, Commanders can create a “leisure budget” for themselves. Just as they manage how much time they put into external projects, they can also manage how much time they reserve for mental and physical recuperation. Here’s how:

- This “leisure budget” should begin small at first – 15 minutes a day, every day, for a month.

- Make this 15 minutes a completable “task” to ease any guilt for not being “productive.”
- Each month, increase the time by 15-minute increments until a “leisure budget” of at least 45 minutes is achieved.

OR

- Set a timer for 50 minutes.
- Work for 50 minutes.
- Once the timer goes off, close the laptop/notebook/PowerPoint.
- Set another timer for 17 minutes.
- Walk away from the work station.
- During the next 17 minutes, Commanders can take a walk, exercise, or grab a snack.
- Once the 17 minutes is up, return to the work station and set another timer for 50 minutes, and repeat the process.

One of the most important lessons these students can learn is knowing when to allow time for rest. Commanders work like well-oiled machines, but sometimes these machines begin to overheat from overuse. Although they can see the most optimal path from point A to point B, they often sacrifice their well-being for their goals. By implementing rest and relaxation into their routine, even in small doses, Commanders can increase their productivity, reduce stress, extend academic longevity, and become more efficient overall.

Catching Flies with Honey

Commanders should remember they don’t have to burn bridges or invalidate others to get their points across. This isn’t to say these students should try to change

themselves to be soft-hearted. Instead, they can use their powerful abilities to lead and cultivate relationships with others rather than bulldoze them.

A more equitable, respectful approach still allows Commanders to be bold and opinionated, expressing their views honestly. The key to not alienating others is the ability to accept dualism – to say, “That’s an interesting point of view,” instead of, “Your perspective doesn’t match with my own, and here’s why you’re likely wrong...” With some subtle changes in presentation, they’ll find they earn much more status and respect by being polite. They can do this by using this interpersonal effectiveness exercise:

- Approach others in a gentle and non-threatening manner, avoiding attacks and judgmental statements.
 - “Non-threatening” can mean allowing a half-smile or avoiding constant eye contact to avoid intimidating fellow students.
- Choose to be interested in listening to others without interrupting.
 - If time is of the utmost importance, Commanders can share a set amount of time to listen to others. For example, “Hey! While I’d love to talk to more, I have a big essay due. I’m happy to take a few minutes, however.”
- Validate and acknowledge others’ wishes, feelings, or opinions.
 - Validating doesn’t mean concession. Instead, it means giving merit to another opinion – an “I see what you mean” type of response.

In the end, it’s important for Commanders to remember that using the above exercise is meant to temper their bluntness, not replace it. Their ability to prioritize and speak frankly is why they tend to be very effective people – but some situations call for validating others and expressing openness.

Commanders in High School

In high school, teachers are likely to see Commander students as dominant figures in their peer groups. Enthusiastic Commanders relish class discussions as opportunities to not only swim in a sea of ideas but also discern which ideas are important. This is perhaps the best thing about learning for these innovative people.

Commanders embrace high standards, even when young. They dedicate vast amounts of time and effort to solving complex problems or unraveling mysteries. But even when they falter, with their raw drive, they can pull through. Their curiosity is an advantage, especially when it comes to the energy they apply to studying.

Balanced High School Learning

Allowing Room for “Not Yet”

Commanders in high school are like all other personality types – they’re young. Being young doesn’t diminish their motivation to succeed or lead, but it can make it confusing to know which direction to point their skills. Those who take a balanced approach to high school understand that while they might be young and ambitious, it’s also all right to explore and fail in different subjects. They strive for excellence, yes, but these students try not to beat themselves up for not mastering Numerical Linear Algebra at age sixteen.

For Commanders who take a balanced approach, receiving a less-than-stellar grade on an exam or receiving a less-than-elite score or ranking in a chosen extracurricular means allowing themselves to feel disappointed, but not defeated. They won’t say to themselves, “I’ll *never* be where I’d like to with X,” but instead, “I’m not where I would like to be with X **yet**.” That “yet” makes all the difference, as they’ll give themselves

time to rest before embarking on another learning journey knowing that failing is key to progress.

Fair to Themselves and Others

Along with self-compassion in the face of failure, Commander students who take a balanced approach learn to develop tolerance for their schoolmates and teachers. This isn't to say they enjoy incompetence, but they do learn to be fair by checking in with themselves and others. In this case, being fair means creating room for opposing opinions or perspectives, and gently, but sternly, redirecting their peers' off-track opinions with ample factual evidence. They also allow themselves to be wrong, as it's only fair to their own sense of progression. Instead of perceiving being wrong as a setback, they take it as an opportunity to improve their knowledge base.

In high school, Commanders who take a balanced approach to fairness, while also staying true to themselves, consider opinions or viewpoints they're otherwise not naturally drawn toward. They allow people to prove their points and take time to understand the relevance of seemingly mundane subjects. It isn't about being right, or being open to anything and everything, but giving themselves the chance to learn something new by allowing room for fallibility.

Unbalanced High School Learning

Failing an Idealized Self

Commanders tend to have an idealized vision of the world, but this vision begins with themselves – types who are well-educated, well-spoken, open-minded, efficient, and never willing to “settle for less.” This, however, is an unrealistic expectation to have for anyone, let alone themselves. Unfortunately, these innovative types can be

beyond hard on themselves for mistakes that everyone makes. Their strict personal philosophies rely on determination and discipline, and, when unbalanced, may make it difficult for Commander students to consider settling for “failure” if they see it as a flaw and not a normal, human experience.

These types can endow a failing grade with exaggerated meaning, far beyond any practical consequence. For example, failing a math class can risk Commanders’ self-identifying as trail-blazing engineers, or not meeting their own expectations in an art class can risk their self-identifying as creative, problem-solving people.

With such a high premium placed on intelligent competence, failure seems like a direct threat to Commanders’ identity, and may lead them to believe that a ‘C’ in a class directly correlates to unfulfilled ambitions. They may think terrible, but false, thoughts about themselves – deeming themselves lazy, incapable of working smart enough, or, with a fatalistic sigh, *“I’m not good enough and never will be.”* If their core identity constructs come under fire, their singular focus leaves them with few other identity markers to turn to – and can leave them feeling destroyed.

No Room for Alternatives

While approaching differing views with patience and open-mindedness works for some Commanders, others may struggle. Some of these students dismiss giving themselves time or attention to branch out. They may even justify their opposition based on unyielding principles alone. They may be visionaries when it comes to the broader strokes of their plans, but not even Commanders can anticipate exactly what the future holds. By holding too stubbornly to their beliefs, they may disregard conflicting but essential data, or entire fields of research and discussion, rather than revising their worldviews to accommodate them.

Their reluctance to accommodate alternative views is a result of Commanders' combined Intuitive and Judging traits. In their minds, they see the ideal, "perfect" ways to do things (the correct answer to questions, the appropriate experiments to conduct for unknown variables, or the most effective ways to present group projects), and they try to mold the imperfect models before them into those that match the images in their heads. However, the pursuit of these singular, perfect solutions can lead them to be dangerously closed-minded to the possibility that they could be wrong.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Creating Diversified Identities

Commanders are relentless in their pursuit when determined. No matter what it takes – blood, sweat, or tears – they'll achieve their goal once they decide what it is. The problem with this, however, is they risk a lack of awareness for anything beyond that goal.

These students may make the mistake of pigeonholing themselves into one subject with a dedication that's amazing but also limiting. They may even learn everything that's relevant to the goal in mind – being a nationally ranked teen athlete, for example – instead of learning what they want to learn.

Although joining the astronomy club, reading a book on Antarctica, or listening to informational videos online are all worthy pursuits, these types may feel they just can't afford the "bandwidth" to do so at the expense of their bigger goals.

To balance this, Commanders can make time to research their more tangential interests. They can do this by:

- Thinking back on things they once thought interesting but didn't try because they weren't relevant to their goals. Consider, for example, Commanders who thoroughly enjoyed a theater class, but couldn't take time away from their pursuit of biology.
 - In our example, they can join a "theater geek" friend in producing a single play (they always want a willing extra). This provides the opportunity to explore this interest without the pressure of taking on a full elective.
- Then, they can take the time to decipher if the new interest is enriching their lives rather than burdening them.
 - If yes, stay.
 - If no, leave.

By creating diversified identities, Commanders aren't likely to lose their *whole* sense of identity should one fall through. Even if they suddenly stop being A+ students, they can still be president of the debate team, a casual inventor, an effective mentor, and so on.

Having Fair Consideration

When it comes to having fair consideration, Commanders can practice stepping into another's argument or perspective to take a more balanced view of both the issue at hand and their own perspective. It's playing chess against themselves – if they know all the moves on both sides, then they can force themselves to consider a much more objective, multifaceted analysis of the board.

This can work especially well when it comes to drafting papers that require them to respond to issues. Rather than responding based only on their personal views,

Commander students can open themselves to other schools of thought. Learning more about contrary ideas allows them to see the weak points in their own arguments as well as the strengths, allowing them to present well-rounded papers or arguments that address both sides. The same thing can be said for group projects. When it comes to collaboration, the best ideas come from respectful conflict.

Here's how Commanders can pursue discussions in good faith:

- When they consider a topic or another person's views that directly opposes their own beliefs, they can ask:
 - "How?" and "Why?" of the person, or do research on the conflicting idea.
 - Listen or research without making any initial judgments while giving the benefit of the doubt.
 - Process the information.
 - See how it compares against their own knowledge set.

By hearing these new ideas out objectively, Commander high school students, with their strongly developed ability to make decisions, can find comfort in the fact that they're making the most informed choices.

Choosing Work or College

Though Commanders are by many measures an uncommon personality type, they face a common dilemma when leaving high school: should they immediately go into the world of work, or should they continue their studies?

Choosing College

For some, the choice is moot – academic certification is a requirement for many occupations they might be drawn to, including business, engineering, healthcare, and law. Without attending college, the doors they long to open can remain locked. These Commanders have a non-negotiable stopover on their life journey.

The experience doesn't need to be a chore, and many Commanders find their crusade to innovate humanity to be an integral part of their chosen curriculum. In college, they may likely find opportunities to make necessary connections and climb whatever ladders to reach their end goals.

Choosing Work

There are Commanders who choose work over attending a university, who cannot bear the costs of college – whether personal, financial, practical, or principled – or whose zeal for their goals is so potent that they just can't be deferred any longer. No longer guided by educational pursuits or their parents, these Commanders need time to define themselves and their goals. It's also reasonable to work in entry-level positions– like waiting tables or doing physical work – while continuing a path of self-discovery outside the regimen of school and parental oversight. Actively exploring interests and perhaps saving money for future schooling is a balanced reason to delay college in favor of the working world.

Others know full well what they want and find rewarding careers or choose to work for themselves. They might also take paths somewhere in between, like doing odd jobs to build a portfolio for a future entrepreneurial venture, or using a passion for writing to contribute freelance articles while dealing with the reality of paying the bills.

It's important for Commanders to realize that many roads can be rewarding. If they truly wish to create a brilliant and efficient world, they'll find a way to do so, even if their path toward doing so is different than they (or others) originally anticipated.

Balanced Decision-Making

Embracing Honesty

The important thing is for these types to consider their options with unwavering honesty. The difficulty of this task shouldn't be underestimated. When surveying the world through a healthy lens, Commanders know perhaps better than anyone how good people are at deceiving themselves. Those who recognize this very human tendency within themselves ask questions, consult with friends and mentors, and do other internal and external reality checks that gather a range of opinions and information to help orient and clarify their goals.

Any option can be just the challenge Commanders need to move their visions forward, or a means of escape from the weight of responsibility. It can be all too easy to convince themselves that one is the other. When honest and patient with themselves, Commanders distinguish between an obstacle and an excuse, and they progress.

Following Through

Students leaning toward college understand that it's a long commitment – which is fine, since Commanders strive to follow through on their convictions. They recognize that time spent toward self-improvement isn't selfish (it's the nature of ambition to prioritize one's own goals), especially if it provides them with the credentials necessary to enter their chosen professions – or to use their education to create

efficient intellectual frameworks for the personal or global problems they long to solve.

When taking a balanced approach, Commander students embrace the idea that attending college isn't an abdication of responsibilities but an acceptance of them – if time there is used effectively. On the opposite side, Commanders who don't seek out college can still find ways to advance their goals. Even entry-level service industry positions can be meaningful if they find satisfaction in their community of coworkers and customers. It can also support them financially while they dedicate time to their “true” careers, especially if the skills developed during their employment makes them more viable candidates for positions in fields of their choosing.

With this acceptance, they dedicate themselves to challenging but necessary work – whether it be in a classroom or earning a living – while maintaining their responsibility to themselves with much-needed relaxation.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Eternally Waiting

These types can pick up the unhealthy habit of spending their whole lives waiting for the perfect opportunity to arrive. The post-high school period is a time of exceptional personal consequence, and younger Commanders may allow the importance of making decisions to become exaggerated in their minds, sinking them into inaction. There's something better right around the corner, they may think, while letting opportunity after opportunity pass them by. Their Intuitive trait, though a powerful tool, can be used against them here as they imagine perfectly-formed solutions falling into their laps. They're highly vigilant when it comes to opportunities, with none of them being “good enough,” or their costs being too great.

This combination of imagination and rumination manifests itself in Commanders' inaction. These types may wait for the perfect opportunity from the great unknown to dictate their next course of action – a specific perfect situation to become an author, or to go to a certain university. They may spend more time trying to *decide* if something is right, instead of acting to *make* it meet their version of “perfect.” Commanders who spend years agonizing over a course of study or type of employment may eventually find that little was gained from their excessive deliberation, and much perhaps was lost.

Haunted Rumination

Choices that are later seen as “wrong” have a way of haunting these types as well. Living with choices is as necessary for Commanders as making them in the first place, but when they overanalyze both their past and future decisions, this unbalanced view gives them little chance to develop the self-confidence or self-forgiveness to see them through.

What they may not realize is that endless rumination and self-consumption is itself a decision. It's a choice not to act or progress, and a decision that can cost far more time than either attending school or making a more intentional push into the professional world. They may be so afraid of making the wrong choice that they choose none at all, instead falling into a path that doesn't align with their personal values.

Ten years hence, their regret is likely to be that they're no closer to their goals because they never acted to bring those goals forward.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Adjusting Course

Commanders' sense of delay comes from their need to commit once they've chosen a course of action. When nothing can be undone, the only choice is the well-considered decision, and what counts as "well-considered" can be stretched to infinity. The question is whether this deliberation arises out of sensible caution, or a fear of the unknown and the lack of self-confidence needed to step into that abyss.

It's important for Commanders to understand that few decisions are permanent. Changing their mind based on new information isn't only their prerogative, but a sign of maturity. Snap decision-making always feels unnatural to Commanders, but those who err a bit more on the side of rashness – at least compared to their usual resolution – may find that even when they've made a wrong choice, the consequences may not be nearly as irreversible as they feared.

Here are some tips for Commanders adjusting their course, as it's never too late to act:

- Request a tour of a local university (likely through their Welcome Center, should they have one.)
- Visit an organization's Facebook page or a campus website to look at their events calendar and gather information.
- Attend an information walkthrough of a university or local college.
- Request an informational interview with an interesting company or non-governmental organization through their human resources department.

In the end, there's no commitment needed to do these things. Commanders are on fact-finding missions and should feel no pressure to sign up for anything. Hopefully, though, they'll feel the rush of inspiration fill them again, and find they're off on another life chapter.

Commitment with Contingencies

No one can truly convince Commanders to do anything. Any decision they make must be made on their terms. But they can be encouraged to keep the bigger picture in mind. This is a personality type with powerful intuition, even when they're young, and they tend to want to be the best version of themselves – and the best in general.

However, this can lead to a nasty case of over-rumination. Luckily, Commander students who find themselves haunted by past musings can happily remember that nothing is stopping them from making their own blend of education and work experience now. This is a type who rarely suffers from a lack of bold action, and there's no one single way to concoct an amazing learning experience. They can develop a game plan for what they want, and then execute it as they see fit.

To help them with their decision-making, they can try this exercise that evaluates two or more paths they'd like to explore and possibly pursue:

- Decide on two distinct tracks, whether they're in higher education or the workforce. For example, they can put down their desire to pursue an architecture degree from a university, plus their interest in going to work at a construction design business to get hands-on experience.
- Map out coursework and requirements for both the tracks.
- After mapping out the requirements, search for points of interaction between them, such as:

- Shared prerequisites
- Overlap of subject material or interest
- Potential networking opportunities that can get them to their end goals

By doing this exercise, Commanders can find overlapping potential in each of their tracks, some of which may lead to the same point. This way, they'll find it's not possible for at least taking *those* courses of action to be "wrong." They're all valuable in their own right.

Commanders in College

Young Commanders who chafed against the mundane curricula of high school may see college as a place to spread their wings. Although the liberty of higher learning can spell out unlimited freedom to sociable, whip-smart Commanders, college also has its challenges. It isn't that these types won't be able to handle the expectations and workload that comes with university life, it's that there may be too many choices – too many extracurriculars, too many subjects to be explored, and, as always, those "annoying and useless" prerequisites.

College is the prime place for Commander students to prove their mettle. For perhaps the first time in their lives, they're in an arena that, while still limited, pushes them to discover what their passions are. Where they once saw no worthy academic opponents, they'll now see many. But Commanders aren't easily cowed. They both love and thrive on competition.

Commanders can finally explore their Extraversion without the rules they were subject to when they were younger. They may write a revolutionary thesis, or network to find their perfect future career, and partake in keggers every night.

However, this enjoyment won't be without purpose. Commanders are making the social connections they know can help them in the future.

Balanced Approach to College

Utilizing Competitors

College is a time for Commanders to find kindred spirits in the classroom and study groups. When taking a balanced approach, these students welcome those with a similar work ethic or same field of study, and befriend these classmates or mentors knowing that while they may be competing, there's also a chance they'll learn from each other.

Commanders tend to utilize their competitors by seeing who can write a more eloquent paper, or create the most functional program, or carve the best sculpture. They also work with competitors to see the weak points in their own performance, and gain inspiration from others' truly amazing work. When Commanders take a balanced approach to college, they learn how to utilize the talents of others and find how satisfying collaboration and competition can be.

Sprinkling in Fun

Commanders look for systems and interesting implementations of ideas, and they use this ability to choose the right tools for their college careers. Whatever their paths may be, when they take a balanced approach they're able to mix activities that are required, though taxing, with activities that are for sheer fun.

For example, when these Commanders choose Mechanical Engineering as their focus of study, they'll do all the required geometry, fluid mechanics, and simulation modeling work, but they'll also take a night off to upgrade an old car with completely

superfluous parts to make it go much, *much* faster. While they're dedicated to their paths, they also understand the importance of sprinkling their workloads with innovative joy to keep them passionate.

Unbalanced College Life

The Know-It-All

Commanders, unfortunately, can frequently become founts of opinion rather than knowledge. It takes very little actual learning for them to seem wise, as their fertile minds make the best use of information and facts. Those who take an unbalanced approach can have an inflated sense of their knowledge, making them closed off to inspiration from their competitors. This mistake can poison potential achievements and deny Commanders of what could be brilliant collaborations.

Those who decide they already know “enough” can sink themselves into a veritable pit of creativity. Their strong desire to express themselves makes it hard for these types to be humble, but it's truly a shame if they allow their lack of humility to stifle their ability to learn.

If they do decide to work with others, they may still detrimentally let their strong views influence their interests and what they're willing to learn, focusing only on areas they already have interest and experience in rather than broadening their scope. While any learning is good, failing to expand significantly beyond areas they already know won't give these types a chance to grow and fully express their awesome potential.

Overload

In their desire to set solid foundations while in college, it's natural for Commander students to overload themselves. Whether it's the pressures of school requirements or the expectations they pile on themselves, sooner or later, Commanders typically deal with the question of overload. Those who haven't learned the art of self-care can become overwhelmed and stressed.

In high school, Commanders' ability to stress themselves out may not have been as serious, thanks to smaller workloads and fewer expectations. In college, however, Commanders have free rein to express their perfectionism within their chosen courses and activities. They also add stress to their lives by pushing for too much detail and making excessive demands of themselves. These demands may look like they're not cutting themselves enough slack when they make mistakes, pushing themselves too hard to achieve and maintain high grades, and simultaneously pushing themselves to meet high social expectation.

As the pressure becomes heavier and heavier, Commanders tend to continue to press themselves further even as they begin to falter under pressure. Despite their determined brows, the stress can erode not only their effectiveness but also their morale. Instead of a rewarding experience, the college years can soon represent drudgery, regret, and burnout.

Rebalancing College Life

Recognizing the Strength in Others

Commanders can tap into their logic to rebalance any ill-will they have toward competitors and get their minds back to being the wonderful sponges that they are.

To attain a sense of balance, these types can talk to those who are far more advanced in areas in which they have interest. Nothing provides a sense of humility like seeing the vastness of potential accomplishments stretching ahead. This is where Commanders' ego and drive can become assets. They might not know everything yet, but they darn well can if they utilize their competitors' minds.

This process of opening themselves up to new types of knowledge or experiences can push these students to a whole new level of their education. What's key here is accepting that they have a lot yet to learn, and then setting out to vigorously seek knowledge. Where and how to best continue their education becomes apparent when Commanders humble themselves enough to admit that while they may need help that their competitors can provide, it certainly wouldn't hurt them to *want* new perspectives. The following exercise has Commanders work alongside perceived competitors to see how their processes compare. Here's how they can open themselves up to competitors:

- Commanders can create a study group or work session with other students in their courses.
- Invite their perceived competitors to group sessions. Try to invite two or more students who have talents or specialties that Commanders would like to explore further.
- During these sessions, Commanders can pay attention to their competitors' processes.
 - They can take note of differences in the processes.
 - They can take note of similarities in the processes.
 - They can take note of any innovations in the processes.
- Commanders should also be open to sharing their own process.

- Commanders can objectively compare the work of their competitors to their own, and either:
 - Subtract something from their process to create an objectively better piece of work.
 - Add something to their process to create an objectively better piece of work.

In the end, Commanders may either gain inspiration from their competitors or, better yet, inspiration from the work they create under the kiln of competition. Whichever paths they choose, these students are likely to have a better piece of work.

Reshaping Unreasonable Expectations

While Commanders in high school have issues with taking breaks, those in college may be unwilling to deal with the root of their stress – meeting unreasonable expectations. It's important for individual Commanders to define what an unreasonable expectation looks like, and while the answers can be varied, they all come back to a single baseline question that they can ask themselves: "Am I burning out too often?" If they feel that their expectations are leading them to dread their upcoming days, and make them counterproductive by overloading them with stress, then it may be time for these students to make a change.

The first step is to acknowledge they've created an unreasonable situation for themselves by asking, "Would I ask someone else to do all these things? Would I wish this schedule on my best friend?" While they may project their expectations onto others at first, their more rational side is likely to give an objective answer. A realistic assessment is an important step in goal-setting.

Commanders suffer in silence because they believe they should be able to handle everything expected of them. They view meeting expectations, no matter how unreasonable, as a duty; they grit their teeth and bear the pain. However, to be better-rounded people, it's necessary to understand that it's okay not to be okay sometimes. Pain, discomfort, and emotional stress are early warning systems that alert people to change course or suffer further damage to their well-being. Commanders help themselves when they learn to treat their different feelings with respect and heed the information they provide.

Becoming literate in the language of one's own feelings can be as simple as raising awareness. One method involves setting a random alarm on one's phone or watch to go off at unexpected intervals. When the alarm sounds, make a note somewhere with the answers to two questions:

- "What is my current feeling?"
- "What is the feeling telling me?"
- For example, perhaps "discouragement" is the current feeling, and it's foreshadowing an impossible afternoon filled with too many arduous tasks.

Many disciplined Commanders teach themselves to ignore their feelings. Bringing emotions back into the conversation can help them deal better with unreasonable expectations and consider their own well-being more often. Commanders can prevent burnout by recognizing their basic needs, learning how they may not be fulfilling them, and then addressing them. Once they've taken care of themselves, they can once again attend to their brilliant ideas.

Lifelong Learning

Lifelong learning goes beyond the rigors of school, though a return to academia is certainly an option. Older individuals who have embraced themselves fully are better able to give the benefit of the doubt to areas of study or schools of thought that might have struck them as irrelevant or not worth their time in their younger years.

Of all the personality types, Commanders are among those who feel most comfortable with the prospect of lifelong learning, the notion that education isn't a thing that one may possess, nor something one must get from some institution, but is instead a never-ending journey that can always satisfy. They know that they can never truly fulfill their hunger for knowledge, just as they can never sate their yen for innovation and efficiency, and find joy in that knowledge.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Finding Joy in Learning

Understanding there's beauty in a clumsy first effort – just as there's beauty in a child's excitement when they first learn that red and yellow make orange – Commanders who take a balanced approach to lifelong learning pursue many things that some people only attempt in childhood. They grant themselves permission to find joy in their learning, whether it be playing a new instrument, speaking another language, taking up a dance style, joining in an unfamiliar sport or game, discovering metal making, or learning about nature. Their pursuits can include anyone and anything that brings them joy and fulfillment.

Many contented Commanders continue to learn throughout their lives, not to prove something to someone – least of all themselves – but for the joy of trying something

and getting better at it. They tend to do something because it's fun, not because it serves some greater purpose (though that's by no means off-limits). Engaging the world around them with no agenda but curiosity resonates with Commanders' drive to always be inspired.

Enjoying Learning Over Improvement

Self-improvement is important, but enjoying oneself in the process is even more so. Commanders who decide to take a more balanced approach to lifelong learning try to appreciate the lives they've developed for themselves, as well as praise themselves for the skills they've learned. By taking time to practice appreciation, Commanders gain a certain self-awareness that lessens the fear that they're not learning anything at all, or that they're "stuck in the mud." What comes with this is also the ability to separate learning a new skill from needing to perform it *well* the first time around.

In fact, these types may separate learning new skills from their self-image completely. They feel accomplished when they succeed at something, but don't base their self-worth on what they've learned (or failed to learn). This is a personality type who accepts themselves as they are, but who also strives to learn when they can.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Stubborn Worldviews

From an early age, Commanders tend to formulate a cohesive set of opinions about the world. Those who refuse to adjust these ideas when appropriate may find themselves lacking. They focus on subjects they already have an affinity for, rather than diversifying their learning. When they do deepen their understanding with this mindset, they often only pursue knowledge that supports their fundamental views.

This limits their growth, and even solidifies their ignorance, as they focus on one thing without truly having an open mind to others.

Unfortunately, while some Commanders recognize and compensate for their certitude, knowing that different perspectives bring forward different and equal truths about the world, others just allow their beliefs to congeal into an impenetrable ideological mass. This can conflict with their perception of themselves as fundamentally correct in their worldview. While the planet changes around them, these Commanders may be reluctant to learn about new technologies, philosophies, or methods, always considering their own to be better than the rest.

Making the Magnificent the Mundane

Aside from the diminishing returns of a too-narrow focus, those who refuse to work at diversifying their learning and self-exploration risk growing weary of the very obsessions that once inflamed them. An over-serious approach to knowledge robs them of the joy of learning and discovery – unable to divert their attention from their mission, whether fixing the world's inefficiency or exercising their inventiveness, the pure pleasure of a day off to learn a light-hearted skill can become perverse and selfish in their eyes.

This unrelenting, adamant nature can hold these types back as powerfully as it once propelled them forth. Once just one strong argument away from changing the world, those suffering a severe case of burnout may be equally certain that no such argument exists – or if one does, it's everyone else who's too stubborn and apathetic to make it. Where an early cynicism has its disadvantages, the late-blooming cynicism that can grip the heart of older Commanders may be particularly devastating. With

nothing to replace their former passion, they can quickly become despondent, so certain are they that every alternative course was ruled out in their youth.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Broadening Scope

It's important to note that, while their formative years might be well-spent becoming authorities in their chosen careers, as Commanders mature they might find at least some of their time better spent attaining a greater breadth of knowledge. Seemingly unrelated topics could yield fresh insight into their principal areas of concern.

Being “set in your ways” isn't inherently bad. However, there's always room for improving on existing routines. Commanders can begin this by picking a contrary opinion. Take, for example, a supportive opinion on the merits of learning about their town's local political climate, when Commanders prefer to stick to what they already know. Here are some steps they can follow:

- Rather than immediately dismissing an argument, Commanders can choose to take time to understand the other side. Even a small variation can loosen up the tight grip existing routine has on life and begin to open new vistas of learning. The things they can consider are:
 - How their own stance may appear to others.
 - Some benefits of what the other side may be proposing.
 - Perhaps “trying on” the contrary opinion themselves for a few minutes by switching roles with their discussion partner.
- Based on these small excursions, Commanders can then adjust their routines based on what they liked or disliked.

There's always new experiences to have and new things to learn. They don't have to be earth-shaking or life-changing. Learning can benefit life without being too disruptive.

Once they rediscover the joy in learning something new, Commanders might choose to stretch their experience even more. They may find the benefit of continued learning far outweighs any risk.

Connecting Mundane to Magnificent

Commanders' greatest peril is that learning becomes a joyless process, and this is because they tend to get carried away with the scope of learning new things. If they're practicing the violin, for example, they may think, "How can I possibly compare to a master violinist? There's just so far to go." Learning stops being fun and starts being something that seems burdensome.

To rebalance this, however, these types can connect the mundane to make it magnificent once more. Learning, rather than being something they ruminate upon, can become an opportunity to reconnect with their friends, family, and community. It's a reconnection with what makes humanity beautiful, and that upwelling of pure, positive emotion can breathe new life into the darkest struggles. A good way Commanders can do this is through simple mindfulness exercises. Here are a few steps that they can follow:

- Find an object to focus on. It can be:
 - A plant
 - A cup
 - A body of water
- Take a few minutes to focus on the simplest aspects of the object:

- What colors are there to it?
- What is the texture of its surface?
- Does it have a scent?
- What are its physical features?

Doing this simple exercise only takes about five minutes, and does a very good job of pulling Commanders out of a bad headspace and into the reality around them. They can focus on what's in front of them in that moment.

Conclusion

Students of Life

Education means a lot of things to a lot of people. For Commanders, it's a way to advance in life to achieve not only goals for themselves, but goals for humanity at large. Commanders' challenge isn't so much in the hard work of learning. It's more about managing expectations and finding a reasonable pace so that learning doesn't become a soulless drudgery or an overwhelming burden, but a rewarding experience that adds to life. For these types, balance involves blending their determination and heart with pragmatism and realistic expectations – a balance that's quite achievable.

Taking time aside for their own needs, setting plausible expectations for themselves, finding meaning and merit in the mundane, understanding that an 'A+' doesn't equate to self-worth, and allowing themselves room to fail and to be wrong, allows Commanders to celebrate their failures right alongside their accomplishments as acts of learning.

In the end, it's important to note that people are never truly balanced or unbalanced. All of us, as a collective, are going back and forth, evolving and devolving. Balance is

more akin to seasons as they come and go, cycling gracefully (or not so much) forever. The trees are taller, people are wiser, all of us advancing in our way. Progress comes in the form of learning how to deal with those seasons and is an extension of Commanders' journeys toward personal growth.

Professional Development



This chapter explores how Commanders can be successful in professional arenas and offers guidance on potential career paths. Commanders typically are most comfortable in fields that allow them to create or contribute to rational efficiency. Once they discover a job that fulfills this need, their sense of personal pride propels them to do the best work possible. If a position doesn't fit at first, this dynamic type works to change the environment little by little – or a lot. Eventually, the job may come closer to matching their personal standards. Commanders are unlikely to be passive about their approach to work.

We'll start by looking broadly at the ways Commanders approach working life, including their strengths and the challenges they face. Next, we'll see how people with this personality type can apply their dedicated efficiency to getting the job they want. Then we'll briefly review fields that are potentially good matches for Commanders. However, with this ambitious type, it's shortsighted to limit the definition of a "good match," as they are likely to make anything they commit to fit.

The final sections will offer a detailed look at how Commanders interact with each of the four Role groups on the job. But this is not merely theoretical or academic. We hope these practical insights will help Commanders improve everyday work interactions, troubleshoot problems, correct blind spots, and build dynamic partnerships to make their workplace experiences more successful.

Excellent Leaders

To say that Commanders are influential leaders isn't just a feel-good sentiment. People with this personality type have excellent leadership skills and an inborn love of knowledge. They loathe incompetence, laziness, and inefficiency. This makes them strict and demanding – but also practical and objective managers. They believe that everyone should do their best to complete tasks to the highest possible standard and can't tolerate individuals who are incompetent or rely on their connections instead. Commanders have high standards, especially with their work, and they are likely to apply an extraordinary amount of effort to their jobs.

Commanders love turning their ideas into plans. This is one of their most important characteristics when it comes to working. They focus on the future and hold an air of self-confidence rarely seen among other personality types. These traits make Commanders excellent executives, entrepreneurs, and corporate strategists. But they are not relegated solely to upper-echelon, white-collar positions. They have enough drive and determination to push specific ideas forward even when many obstacles block their path. Their systemic focus and insight can play out at all employment levels and in all fields. For example, a Commander mechanic who has a comprehensive overview of a machine is likely to find solutions that might evade those who just learn how to fix things in a step-by-step manner.

Commanders can be excellent communicators (especially verbally) and enjoy structure and order, making them well-suited to leadership roles. Ideal Commander careers involve at least some management opportunities. It's unlikely that people with this personality type will remain happy as low-level employees for long. Some of their positive professional traits may surface only when they have enough power to use them.

Need for Challenge

Commanders rely on their intelligence, and they apply themselves more when a job tests their problem-solving skills. Problems are inherently novel – or someone already would have solved them. Commanders are likely to crave stimulating challenges and to shun routines and repetitive tasks. They enjoy digging deeply to understand a problem, deconstructing the reasons it's problematic, and then building a system around their understanding to provide a solution.

If a system needs rethinking or has a chronic issue, Commanders are among the best to address it. They aren't afraid to work through a Gordian Knot of a problem – in fact, they're likely to rate their job satisfaction higher when there are enough issues to keep a job interesting. For people with this personality type, intellectual challenges are the lifeblood of their existence, and leading others to realize solutions brings them fulfillment.

Habitually Pondering

Commanders' fondness for planning, strategizing, and substantial pondering makes them ideal for jobs where they can encourage others to explore innovative ideas. Even in jobs that don't require creative thinking, Commanders often consider new

perspectives anyway. The constant brainstorming feeds their preference to lead others to meet challenges.

Employers who request feedback get thoughtful summaries from Commanders, but only if they allow enough time for thorough analyses. Commanders, typically thoughtful and responsible in their approach, dislike having to assess something without fully considering everything first. However, in many cases, they may have been playing with ideas and considering possible improvements all along. It can be hard to catch people with this personality type by surprise; they are always looking for solutions and continually interacting with others to get a better handle on things.

Finding Opportunity

Knowing Commanders' general attitude toward work that's fulfilling and how they approach it, we can now turn to what they do to get there in the first place.

Marshalling Self-Awareness

As with everything else, Commanders approach the career journey with strategy. They are likely to build careers rather than just find jobs. They may not see each detail involved in a desired position before applying, but they likely have a good idea of how the position can feed into their broader career goals. Commanders do their homework and approach the job search knowledgeably. Consequently, their certainty gives them focus and confidence as they explore their choices.

Commanders know what they know – and they know what they don't know. This self-awareness provides them with an oxymoronic bold humility. They can be hard on themselves while simultaneously impressing others with their confident assertions. They're competent yet aware enough of their limitations, which makes them

moldable and valuable assets in entry-level jobs, as well as other jobs with a learning curve.

People with this personality type are ambitious, and they enter the workforce with determined intentions. Once they adopt visions or plans, they marshal all of their resources to fulfill them. Even from the beginning of their careers, they work on fortifying the foundations that support their goals. Such focus makes for serious employees. If Commanders can display their seriousness without overwhelming hiring teams with their intensity, they likely will win them over.

Making Contact

Although Commanders possess a gregarious, fun side, they also are serious. They're likely to meet their potential employment contacts at conventions or other meetups where focused interests are central. Trying to meet the right contacts at purely social cocktail parties isn't their style.

For the types of jobs that attract Commanders, the most effective emails and introductory phone calls center on their knowledge and interests rather than pleasantries and personality. Personal characteristics such as enthusiasm and reliability are always essential in an interview, but they may be secondary for specific jobs. They still need attention, but aptitude and understanding are critical for Commanders' presentations.

For an excellent first impression when applying for jobs that suit them, Commanders must be their best selves: knowledgeable, direct, friendly, and rational. Those characteristics, or even just a few of them, are likely all it takes to impress others at a first meeting. If they show they grasp an idea or a system, displaying an ability to navigate relevant subjects well, they're likely to impress interviewers. Commanders

can charm their interviewers, and charisma can work in small doses. But showing competence is their stronger suit for the jobs that will bring them satisfaction.

Outside Interests

Not all interviewers ask candidates about their more extensive interests, but organizations rarely seek one-dimensional employees with no life apart from work. Commanders might want to consider their hobbies and recreational activities and include that information on their résumés or mention it during an interview. There are plenty of opportunities to expand their areas of interest – they can hone in on a chosen art form, take a course to broaden their knowledge base, or finish writing a short story. Commanders needn't force it, but if becoming a more appealing candidate partially inspires them to take on an exciting hobby, all the better.

Such projects need not relate to the job, either. Anything that shows Commanders as creators can go on a résumé. This presents them as more attractive and versatile candidates and gives breathing room during interviews. Answering a question like, "Describe a situation where you used your problem-solving skills," is much, much easier with projects and anecdotes ready for discussion.

People with the Commander personality type may want to build ties with their communities and often provide leadership there. If they gain experience with volunteer, community, or student organizations, they can highlight that during their job searches. If Commanders take leadership roles in such undertakings, those related management skills can serve as a sturdy centerpiece in the job application process – especially if they are new to the job market.

Preparing for the Interview

Commanders can spend time improving their presentation skills, whatever their natural ability. Although they are outgoing enough, they may not always read their audiences well or anticipate what's important to their listeners. Their style can be a little blunt; at times, diplomacy would serve them better. Commanders may want to role-play with an objective and honest friend to practice listening more carefully and to smooth out any rough edges.

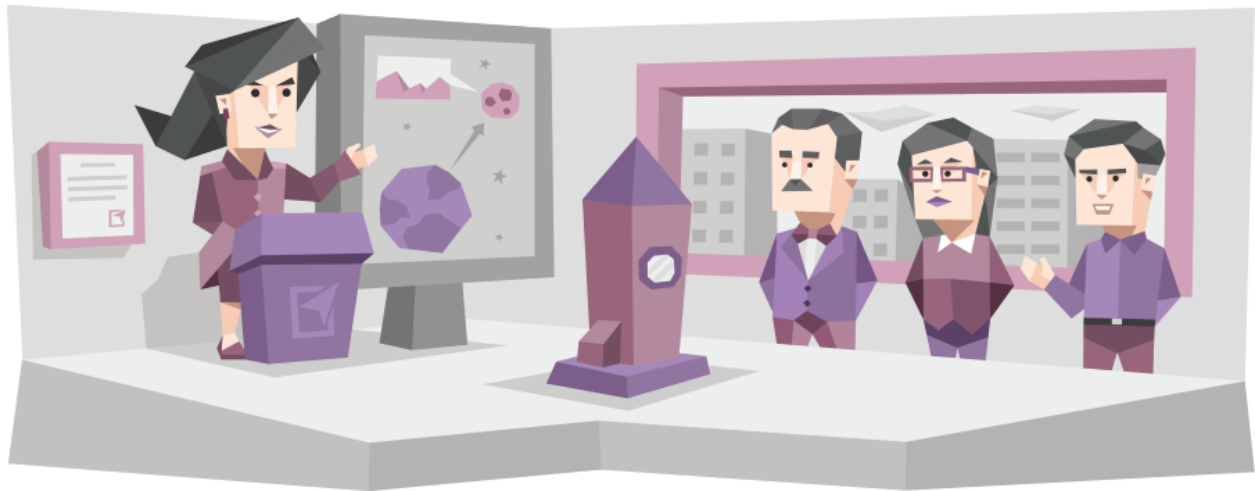
Also, when they have an interview coming up, Commanders can radically overanalyze, trying to prepare for every imagined scenario. Overthinking is a trap most Intuitive types fall into easily. However, they can't possibly prepare for everything, but they can exhaust themselves ahead of the interview, undermining their chances.

Commanders' preference for original ideas can lead them to ignore more common interview questions. They may be caught off-guard by a typical question, such as "What's your biggest weakness," and fall back on a clichéd answer, such as "perfectionism." But when an interviewer is looking for self-awareness and introspection, responses that appear "canned" might kill the deal.

Therefore, it's crucial to anticipate template questions, especially in the preliminary stages of a job search, and to prepare to approach them with something near enthusiasm. Sometimes recruiters don't even know much about the roles and responsibilities. They may simply go through generic checklists. This can seem unchallenging and unproductive to Commanders, who may even have an impulse to take over during such a meeting. If they go in expecting well-worn questions, regardless of their personal feelings on the efficacy of such an approach, they are

more likely to prevent confidence from clouding their judgment and disillusionment from overshadowing a good interview.

Jobs and General Skill Sets



Let's look at some specific jobs that fit Commanders well. This list is by no means comprehensive, as Commanders can succeed in any career they choose. Similarly, even "suitable" careers won't be ideal for all Commanders. Everyone must decide what career fits them best, meets their needs, and brings them fulfillment and personal satisfaction.

For Commanders already employed, this may serve as a confirmation or an explanation why they're happy or unhappy in a role. We can't tell anyone exactly how to succeed or be happy, but we hope to offer some insight for Commanders making personal career decisions.

Innovation and Design

Engineering and design are broad categories of disciplines that use science, math, design techniques, and ingenuity to create machines, structures, or systems. People

in these fields create new products, improve old ones, and find new applications for existing products. Such careers allow Commanders to tap into their creativity, a trait that many overlook but which plays a key role in Commanders' overall happiness.

Commanders have a knack for spotting trends and revealing fine points amid the noise of irrelevant details. They relish taking their observations and using them to improve existing organizational or technical methods or to build better alternatives. Their curiosity and need for efficiency make them excellent candidates for engineering and design roles. Although many engineers and designers labor alone over a drafting table, a computer, or a workbench, these fields also provide opportunities in leadership, teamwork, and project management.

Research and Science

Commanders need to discover how everything works. They love unearthing patterns through research and observations. Commanders enjoy exploring uncharted territory and finding novel approaches to old disciplines on their own initiative. Researchers and scientists with the Commander personality type admire others with similar drive and abilities. They collaborate most successfully when they feel they're dealing with equals – or those of superior ability and experience whom they can look up to. However, that doesn't mean that they don't also enjoy mentoring less experienced people, as long as the relationship is clearly defined. Fields that involve research and science can fulfill Commanders' need for forward-looking potential and can provide them opportunities to take the lead in projects.

Strategy

It's no accident that Commanders are part of a Role group called Analysts. Commanders see and manipulate systems, mentally dissecting them, identifying

areas for improvement, then rebuilding them so they will be more useful. Calling this section “Strategy” is cheating a bit. Everything Commanders do is strategic, but not all strategic jobs fit neatly into categories. That said, some positions that fit under this heading where Commanders can excel and feel fulfilled include business administrator, management consultant, project manager, military officer, educational consultant, and investment analyst.

Challenging Career Qualities

In modern society, we spend a great deal of time at work, and we also tend to need our jobs to give us meaning. We must be careful not to get stuck in situations that don’t suit us, as that can cause all manner of difficulties. Following are some characteristics of positions that may not be suitable for Commanders.

Some professions or jobs may be less suitable or comfortable for Commanders and may obstruct their success and happiness. Commanders shouldn’t discount any career merely on face value because when these adaptable individuals put their minds to it, they can do anything. A job with challenging features should be seen less as a “stop” sign and more as a “caution” sign. Commanders must objectively evaluate specific jobs against their own needs, values, and limits. Such probing is essential to good decision-making. To aid Commanders in searching for job opportunities, let’s look at some career characteristics and circumstances that present prominent challenges for people with this personality type.

Unhelpful Leadership

Commanders are natural leaders and often insist on things being “right.” They show little tolerance for error or sloppiness. If those in charge are rigid with their concepts,

or if the structure doesn't allow for employees to be heard or leaders to emerge from the ranks, Commanders may have problems. People with this personality type accept rational arguments that are counter to their views, but if they determine that a position is based on "Because I'm the boss and I said so," they may begin to look down on their employers.

Commanders need an objective rationale for anything they think or do. They need room to create and inspire. If their management structure doesn't allow for this, they most likely will feel unfulfilled. In such situations, when they think their employers are in error, Commanders may not be able to overlook it – and they do like to take a stand.

Social Aspects of Work

Not being highly empathetic, Commanders probably won't respond well to any job that requires a significant amount of emotional intelligence. This is a somewhat unique trait for an Extraverted personality, but Commanders do tend to be somewhat reserved, especially in situations that don't revolve around their interests. People with this personality type tend to do fine with coworkers and clients when conversations are about their work, but they have little tolerance for much else while on the clock and just don't understand small talk.

Also, where there is social interaction, there eventually is emotion and drama. Such displays of feelings cause discomfort for Commanders, and they may even lose their bearings temporarily, not knowing how to respond. They may not enjoy business dinners or social events, which can be important in some industries.

Commanders most likely would struggle as, for example, marriage counselors. Feelings and emotions aren't their strong suit. Although they may enjoy interacting

with others, it must be on a more intellectual level. A strong appeal to feelings, whether in life or an argument, turns off Commanders. On top of that, they often misread the emotional cues of others. Even though people with this personality type share the same emotions as anyone else, empathy included, they aren't comfortable dealing with that realm – particularly in the workplace. Jobs that demand a high level of compassion would likely be frustrating for them.

Lack of Intellectual Stimulation

Commanders need a great deal of intellectual stimulation and challenge to be satisfied. Unlike some other personality types, they never actually satisfy their curiosity, and they're always looking for new puzzles and pursuing new angles on unsolved problems. For them, many career paths may feel unsuitable, as they may feel as though their employers underutilize their key skills.

Their minds are both their greatest gift and their most significant curse. When a work environment is a good fit, people with this personality type are quickly noticed and appreciated. If not, they may feel endlessly frustrated by inefficiencies and missed opportunities. Commanders tend to have many transferable skills and shouldn't hesitate to promote them – or even look for greener pastures when a job isn't a good match.

It's imperative that Commanders learn to find ways to use their strategic thinking skills whenever and wherever they can – even in positions that may be unstimulating. If they see that a role is unsuitable, they won't be able to shake the gnawing feeling that they're in the wrong place, no matter how well-paid or stable the position may be.

Alternative Options

Sometimes Commanders won't be able to advance at their current workplaces – either because their employers don't value their unique traits or because there just isn't room for growth. Aside from changing employers, there are alternative options – some of them unexpected – for Commanders who find themselves in this situation.

People don't need to be employed in the traditional sense to live comfortably. We live in an age of possibilities, and selling time to a corporation isn't the only way to generate income. Commanders are imaginative, bold individuals, and thanks to their ability to create new ideas and make complex connections, they can thrive in self-employment and as entrepreneurs.

Self-Employment

Many people find the notion of self-employment to be quite scary, but these days, even traditionally employed people rarely have job security or guarantees of advancement. Consequently, working for oneself can be a viable option, and it offers many benefits that align with Commander values, including flexibility, independence, and personal vision.

Furthermore, self-employment eliminates a significant hurdle Commanders encounter in traditional work environments: a lack of control over their duties. Although nobody has complete control over the tasks they must perform when making a living, self-employed people have more power than those following orders. Self-employed people still have administrative duties and certain obligations, but at least they have more of a say in how they handle all of it and whether they can delegate less-desirable tasks.

The self-employed route also appeals to Commanders' sense of self-determination. Once they put their mind to something – acquiring more clients, diversifying their work, increasing their expertise in their chosen field – Commanders are formidable forces. They may have the same amount of work or even more, but the reward is that they are their own bosses.

Entrepreneurship

Of course, there is no point in trying to start a business without a good idea. This is where Commanders' ability to come up with unusual connections and spot early trends enables them to shine. Anyone can think up a product, but it takes an imaginative mind to come up with an idea, product, or solution that could grow into an innovative business venture.

If Commanders decide to try their hand at entrepreneurship, they will need to rely on their creativity and strategic thinking skills to devise an interesting way to fulfill an existing need (or create one), all while not being afraid to experiment. Commanders can be excellent entrepreneurs, having both the imagination necessary to develop a good business model and the sheer drive and energy to keep going in difficult times.

Capitalizing on a Hobby

Commanders often pursue hobbies that could turn into sources of income in the future. The hobby can be anything, such as crafting innovative woodwork, building custom personal computers, making music, or consulting to improve communities. Some Commanders want to change the world, whereas others focus on local or personal matters. When people with this personality type enjoy a hobby, and if they can retain the safety net of regular employment, they might create the next “big

thing.” If they are able to divert some financial resources to the hobby, so much the better.

This approach is common among Commanders, especially those in positions that are well-paid but not intellectually challenging. The right hobbies provide Commanders with opportunities to do things that truly excite and inspire them, without the constraints of employer-employee relationships. If they create value, they likely can find a way to become profitable in time and can tick another vital box on their happiness checklist – independence.

A side note for ambitious Commanders: People with this personality type are bound to overthink things and get bogged down trying to determine the path that’s right for them. They should take time to think and reflect – but try not to obsess over details. Commanders usually are at their best when they’re relaxed and confident in their skills.

When it comes to the professional world, it doesn’t matter which path Commanders choose, as long as it works for them and is a source of inspiration. Although this is an idealistic perspective for many people, if any type can devise a system that makes one thing adapt to the purpose of another – transforming a hobby to an income generator, for example – it’s Commanders.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Next, we will dig a little deeper to determine how Commanders can best cooperate with their coworkers from all four Role groups, including other Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. Where do Commanders and colleagues of various personality types sync most easily? Where might they experience friction or

incompatibility? From those insights comes specific advice for dealing with issues likely to arise from their differences, as well as how their likenesses can create synergy and successful collaboration.

Commander-Analyst Cooperation



The shared Intuitive and Thinking traits make Commanders part of the Analyst “family.” And there are family resemblances. Even with their similarities, they have plenty of nuances and differences, which can be positive or negative in a professional environment. The results depend as much upon Commanders and what approach they decide to take as they do on the behaviors and attitudes of their colleagues.

Balanced Commander-Analyst Cooperation

Lofty and Logical Language

Commanders and other Analysts often find themselves “speaking the same language.” They both make rational arguments and engage in conceptual discussions. Although they draw on facts, their focus is on big-picture ideas. As puzzle-solvers, Commanders and other Analysts explore systems and concepts,

engaging in “what if” discussions with each other. They share their ideas for improving any enterprise they come across. Small talk does not interest either party, and they may find each other relief from the tedium of water-cooler chat.

Commanders and other Analysts can be a perfect match when it comes to bouncing ideas off each other. Brainstorming sessions between these two are likely to extend into a series of discussions, as both take time to ponder the different facets of an idea. In the workplace, such interactions yield many benefits. For example, others might be able to feed a problem to this duo and pull out a solution a few minutes later. Analysts and other Commanders delight in being a sort of black-box solutions generator, fueled by their affinity for ideas mixed with potential solutions.

Covering Each Other's Bases

Commanders are adept at reverse-engineering any system; they can take a deconstructed methodology and apply or cut concepts until a system runs optimally. This type is not one for flourishes, instead preferring minimalist approaches focused on effectiveness, simplicity, and elegance. When it comes to problem-solving, Commanders are masters at fixing issues that have long-term implications in a broader structure, and they can be resolute, even stubborn, once a decision is made.

Other Analysts can back them up and “check their work.” If they’ve earned a Commander’s respect, they can serve as safeguards against errors and wrong ideas. Because they are Intuitive, Commanders also are typically open to the potential that can lie in alternate perspectives, and other Analysts usually can supply those in abundance. Rather than resist, Commanders and other Analysts are open to different angles.

Unbalanced Commander–Analyst Cooperation

Constant Competition

One pitfall Commander and Analyst coworkers may face is the potential for constant competitive tension. Because Analysts are somewhat rare, Commanders may not have had experience with other Analysts in the room. Such new encounters can be uncomfortable – especially if they come across other Analysts who share their specific specialties. In career settings with a high concentration of Analysts, the competition can be extreme. Although Commanders and other Analysts aren't prone to drama in an emotional sense, their one-upmanship can cause extensive damage if it spills too much into the workday.

If Commanders and other Analysts become competitive with each other, they can become entrenched in opposing ideas or unrelenting criticism of each other. Analysts are prone to freely show scorn for others' mistakes or displays of flawed logic. Terse remarks can ratchet up the heat as their egos become strongholds they must defend. Instead of a generous synergy of ideas that can take place between Commanders and other Analysts, they may develop a destructive rivalry designed to bring the other down in a display of intellectual superiority.

There also is a chance that the two will unite their competitive spirit against others. Commanders' desire to trample competitors can quickly turn toxic in the workplace. When another Analyst fans the flames, a situation can go from bad to terrible.

A Quagmire of Cleverness

Commanders and other Analysts who nurture their collaborative spirits can find themselves in a quagmire of genius. They could produce too many great ideas while

brainstorming together. With each new plan requiring resources and entailing opportunity costs, Commanders and other Analysts may become trapped in their cleverness, unable to move any objective forward with the competence they so value. At some point, they may need to pull in fewer theoretical and more hands-on people to lend a practical perspective and to get things moving outside of the realm of the imagination.

Personality theories often refer to Intuitive types, like Commanders and other Analysts, as “open-minded.” They are open-minded in that they can see many options, giving them the appearance of flexibility that may not always be present. However, Commanders and other Analysts can be as stubborn or rigid as anybody with ideas and obsessions – perhaps more.

Such stubbornness can be especially true when Commander and Analyst coworkers believe a pet argument is unassailable. But even when they are right about an idea, it doesn’t mean it fits all situations. Remember the adage, “When one only has a hammer, everything becomes a nail.” Rather than getting stuck pushing ideas that aren’t relevant to a work situation or aren’t accepted by the powers-that-be, Commander-Analyst teams may need to give up the designs they hold dear in the name of broader institutional goals.

Rebalancing Commander-Analyst Cooperation

Healthy Competition

Competition isn’t necessarily bad, and its negative impact depends on the level of hostility. For Commanders and other Analysts, it’s more about the tone of the rivalry. It’s reasonable to believe that good ideas and outcomes can arise when coworkers try to outdo each other – if they can keep it goal-oriented and thwart the need to

make it a zero-sum game. If competition persists for a lengthy period, it can become a distraction. So, tone, attitude, and level of efficiency all determine the value of competition.

Self-awareness is one of the first steps for Commanders who wish to transform toxic work competition with other Analysts into a healthier version. Being more aware of their aggressive tendencies can help Commanders moderate their voices. They can choose to be contrary to confirm their sense of their own superiority, or they can choose to offer opposing viewpoints and new information to add significant new dimensions to work plans. Self-awareness provides choice and freedom and diminishes the power of compulsive competitiveness.

Setting up a system that fosters such insight can be a powerful tool for keeping toxic competition in check. The following method recognizes that the need to be right is not in and of itself a terrible thing – if used in moderation, it can motivate Commanders in healthy ways. However, the more exclusive the focus is on being right, the less likely it is to contribute in a wholesome manner. The following exercise is designed to increase mindful awareness of attitudes:

- Find an index card that's small enough to fit in a pocket or planner. It's helpful to have something physical and straightforward to anchor the process and to keep you from overthinking it.
- Draw a line across the index card. On one end of the line, write, "Winning." On the other, write, "Contributing."
- Set a random alarm app on a cell phone or set some other type of randomized reminder. Each time it goes off, take out the index card and ask, "Where do my thoughts and focus fall on this continuum at this moment?" (Obviously, this is a forced dichotomy. The goal is not to label every part of every day perfectly,

but rather to ask yourself a question to raise your awareness. Avoid concretizing it into a system that demands an “efficient” answer. The goal of this mindfulness exercise is to stop, to think, and to become more aware. Nothing more.)

- Do this for a week to build a habit.

Keep the card as needed in the future. If an interaction feels tense and adversarial, take out the card and think about the motivation fueling the sense of competition.

If the personal need to triumph hinders measurable goals or decelerates progress, it is objectively damaging. A focus that falls somewhere in the middle of the line can be acceptable, and a wish to win may also be motivational. Remember, reasonable competition can be useful. However, if Commanders discover that “winning” motivates them more often than not, they may want to adjust their approach to ensure their value in the workplace. It starts with awareness.

Opening the Echo Chamber

At work, Commanders and other Analysts who share rational sensibilities can offer each other intellectual stimulation without having to wander too far from their comfort zones. With each reinforcing the other, they can create a sense of confidence or legitimacy around their ideas that isn’t always deserved. That an opinion is well-reasoned doesn’t necessarily make it useful, and Commander and Analyst coworkers can become stuck supporting notions that are worthless outside their bubbles.

People often ignore theories that don’t have clear and measurable results. This is especially true in for-profit settings. Although lofty thoughts can be fun for Commanders and other Analysts to toss back and forth, they can be detrimental if they become a focus or are mistaken for useful. In certain situations, Commander

and Analyst coworkers may need to recognize when they're stuck in a loop of their own mental indulgences, then discover ways to break the cycle.

Some fundamental questions they might ask themselves:

- What concrete and measurable results are likely to result from this line of thinking?
- How does this idea align with our organization's established vision or mission statement? If it doesn't, is the group seeking to modify its overarching goals?
- How much resistance is the idea likely to receive? Rank it from 1 (received with joy and fanfare) to 10 (likely a deal-breaker when it comes to keeping this job). If the number is low, the idea may be worth pursuing. If the number is moderate, it may just be a matter of selling the idea correctly or tweaking it slightly to improve the rating. If the number is high, perhaps the idea should be shelved.
- Has the idea been reviewed by management or peers for its relevance? Do others appear to be on board with the concept? Who has the authority to decide such things?

If reflections from the above questions reveal that the idea should not move forward, use the following suggestions to let go.

- Recognize that shelving an idea doesn't say anything about the quality of the idea, nor does it measure your worth. Plans are adopted when they are in the right place at the right time.
- Give opposing or alternate views a fair hearing.

Similarly, adopt a "Beginner's Mind." Beginner's Mind is a Zen principle of approaching everything with a fresh set of eyes. It forces its practitioners to drop

preconceptions – an obvious step for letting go when stuck in an unproductive cycle. Ask yourself, “If I was approaching this situation for the first time, what might I notice about it?” But that doesn’t mean you need to abandon your experiences. Beginner’s Mind involves using your experiences in a new way based on new perceptions or revised circumstances.

Jeffrey McDaniel wrote, “I realize there’s something incredibly honest about trees in winter, how they’re experts at letting things go.” Commanders are not always so good at releasing their pet notions. However, letting go is a useful skill they can develop to gain much benefit. Letting go can save time spent on futile endeavors, conserving personal energy and mental capacity. It also may help Commanders when they find themselves trapped with Analyst coworkers in an echo chamber of ideas.

Commander–Diplomat Cooperation



Commander and Diplomat coworkers share the Intuitive trait, which provides them a place to connect regardless of any differences they may have. A kinship emerges from their collective ability to see beyond the obvious. Their differences are as likely

to offer wholesome balance as they are to create conflict – it depends on their willingness to work together and to appreciate one another's gifts and preferences.

Balanced Commander-Diplomat Cooperation

Some Common Methods

Commanders and Diplomats both prefer discussing the “big picture” over individual details. Small talk may bore even the most social among them. Both absorb new knowledge almost subconsciously and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of Intuitive understanding. Both exercise an often intense and unexpected imaginative and creative ability to connect the dots.

These similarities, along with their shared love of unconventional thinking, give Commanders and Diplomats plenty of common ground and opportunities to combine their talents. Both groups are statistically rare, and they are likely to recognize that they are not like most of their coworkers – depending on the job. Some positions attract more Intuitive people than others. However, in the average random workplace, Diplomats and Commanders may find they enjoy the conversations they have with each other and discover a stimulating level of compatibility. Although they may focus on different things while brainstorming, they both are typically adept at producing copious novel ideas when called on to do so. They are likely to quickly identify each other as “idea people,” like themselves.

Complementary Perspectives

Commanders are comfortable with systems and puzzles, and they value innovation over all else. They excel at working things out, at least to the extent that they offer theories toward that end. Diplomats add to Commanders' offerings by bringing

humanity to their ideas, providing “soul” to any system that Commanders devise or innovate. It would be a cartoonish portrayal to say that Commanders lack humanity and Diplomats are bereft of analytical skills. But when Commanders enthusiastically push an idea forward, Diplomats may be there to remind them that people need adjustment periods before they can accept innovation. Commanders, on the other hand, can help Diplomats move more efficiently through the drama that often occurs on the job.

In a workplace, this might play out as a wholesome push-and-pull between the logical and the compassionate. A great product without sensitive customer service is likely to gain a bad reputation. Then again, what is the point of outstanding customer service if the product or service isn't viable?

Unbalanced Commander–Diplomat Cooperation

When Efficiency Hinders Support

As much as their Intuitive trait binds them, Commanders and Diplomats still have pronounced differences. Each brings a different emphasis, and if they add inflexibility and intolerance, these coworkers can have problems. Commanders' rapid-fire ideas may not always consider how others might react as they plow ahead trying to implement their concepts. However, concerns over how an aggressive push might affect others is likely a prominent blip on Diplomats' radars, which can cause them to automatically feel at odds with their Commander colleagues. Without looking for some middle ground that honors efficiency and innovation yet also considers the feelings, sensibilities, and esteem of those involved, the two may retreat to their own corners and stubbornly insist that the other is wrong.

For example, Commanders may see projects as hindered by those who are slower to accept change, believing that the best approach is to force them to move forward or remove them from the loop entirely. Passionate focus on their current ideas may pull Commanders away from a more sensitive and patient plan that allows time for personnel to adjust on a psychological level. On the other hand, Diplomats may spend too much time worrying about the feelings and concerns of others, bogging down progress. Cue a lot of impatience on both sides.

Blunt and Gentle Expressions

Commanders and Diplomats may find that their outward expressions are also points of contention. When dealing with people who don't see things their way, Commanders can be brusque and impatient, causing Diplomats frustration and disappointment. Diplomats tend to avoid conflict, and they may disengage if Commanders come across as too harsh or condescending. Diplomats need not even be the target for this problem to arise; in some instances, Diplomats may take a stand if they believe Commanders' attitudes are hurtful to others' feelings or welfare.

To be clear, Commanders aren't uncaring people, and their bluntness is often delivered in a spirit of support. But they rarely see the point of sugar-coating their solutions or objections just to spare others' feelings. Their version of truth or reality comes before such things. This can easily create tension between them and people wearing the label of "Diplomat." Commanders' hearts may be in the right place, but they don't always come across that way. As rationally intelligent as Commanders strive to be, and as social as they are, they're notorious for lacking emotional intelligence. Whereas Commanders have no problem with (or even enjoy) criticism and debate, Diplomats are acutely sensitive to contentious words and may shut down.

Rebalancing Commander–Diplomat Cooperation

Starting with Understanding

Commanders who hope to sync better with Diplomats at work may want to discover what values are essential to Diplomats. Learning what motivates them can bridge the gap of understanding. That doesn't mean they must surrender their styles or positions – it simply involves the intention to learn about their Diplomat coworkers. The approach draws on that which Commanders value: acquiring information to draw conclusions. To do this, however, Commanders may need to deliberately open themselves to such information rather than assume that they already have a read on their compassionate colleagues. It's easy to stereotype those who are different – perhaps in this case as “bleeding hearts” – and to go no further in understanding them.

Commanders and Diplomats may reconnect if they remember that they both want to make a difference. Their methods and desired results may be dissimilar, but these innovative people share a desire to improve anything they're involved with – even if in different ways. Once they understand their shared wish for improvement, they can explore the details by employing the journalistic questions: “who,” “what,” “when,” “where,” “why,” and “how.” The answers can help these coworkers reach a deeper level of appreciation for each other's opinions and ideas. It's essential to understand that acceptance and support don't always require agreement or approval. It's okay to disagree, and with their diverse styles, Commanders and Diplomats may work together best if they agree to disagree on some issues. But that shouldn't excuse either from making attempts to understand the other with the goal of having a better working relationship.

Those who are interested in better understanding can try a five-minute time-out from judgment. Commanders can do the following simple exercise on their own, without necessarily discussing it with their Diplomat coworkers, or they can set it up with their Diplomat colleagues if the situation is comfortable enough.

- Pick a mutual work topic to ask questions about.
- Establish a short period of time during which judgment will be suspended (e.g., five minutes).
- Start a discussion as if you are a non-interfering anthropologist or sociologist who is trying to collect information without influencing the direction of the native population. Or perhaps take on the persona of an objective journalist. Remember that the goal of the exercise is simple, non-judgmental data collection.

Borrow heavily from the journalistic questions and fire away. Statements are not allowed, nor are questions that make your Diplomat coworker defend their position. For example, “Do you really think that is the right approach?” is a forbidden question.

After the time is up, take a moment to write an objective, nonjudgmental paragraph describing the Diplomat’s position. If the Diplomat is in on the exercise, perhaps ask them to review the description for accuracy.

Those who execute this five-minute time-out from judgment will experience two things. First, Commanders will gain a focused, purer understanding of their Diplomat coworkers’ opinions or ideas, free from interpretation and their own filters. From there, any arguments and disagreements will be based on complete understanding. Second, the Diplomats will feel they have been heard and that their ideas are valued – thus strengthening the working relationship.

Learning the Language of Diplomacy

There is nothing Commanders can do to change the nature of their more sensitive coworkers. They even may do themselves and their organization a service by accepting that Diplomats' sensitivity has value, even in the most impersonal workplaces. Learning to soften their sometimes-blunt speech can go a long way toward supporting coworkers who bring a more human element to the table. It's not necessarily that Commanders aren't aware of social graces. They are and can use them when they choose to. It's just that, at times, they may forget that others aren't as laser-focused on what is effective to the point that they forget the feelings and egos of others.

Commanders who learn to put a social buffer around their starker offerings take giant steps toward simpatico work relationships. Just as a car may need time to warm up on a cold morning, Commanders can understand the importance of investing in a friendly connection before getting down to brass tacks. When Commanders show more social grace and positivity to Diplomat colleagues, rather than taking a challenging or contentious stance, much more productive communication and cooperation are likely to blossom. Although none of the following gestures may be new to the average Commander, still, at times, they may need a gentle reminder of effective social niceties.

- Greet coworkers with a smile.
- Ask how their day is going.
- Give them a few moments to talk about themselves before replying.
- Pick some aspect of their response and reply complementarily. If they talk about what they've been doing, something like, "Wow, that's cool!" is about

right. If their response is a complaint, reply with something like, “Ugh, that really sucks!” or “I know that must be rough for you.”

- Instead of giving “me” or “I” statements, even if related, stay focused on what *they’re* saying.
- After sharing some interest in their day, make a “gotta get back to it” excuse and move on with work.

When there’s a work matter to bring up, use a short version of this, rather than immediately launching into business.

It’s essential for Commanders not to view themselves as deficient just because they don’t place as much emphasis on socialization in the workplace – their way has its merits. However, practicing skills that let them relate better to Diplomats will create the efficient communication this type craves. A pinch of sugar can keep ideas and facts flowing freely, getting Commanders and Diplomats back to their shared creative ground.

Commander-Sentinel Cooperation



Commanders and Sentinels have fundamental differences in their intent and methods. Commanders love to experiment with the potential of a system, whereas Sentinels attend to straightforward business in the here and now, performing practical tasks and building order that supports established goals. When a job suits them, Commanders and Sentinels may gravitate toward different, but often complementary, roles. Both seek effectiveness and results, and when they marry their approaches cheerfully and respectfully, they can move mountains.

Balanced Commander–Sentinel Cooperation

Implementing Solutions Together

In some ways, this is a perfect workplace match, as Commanders often need others to help them carry out their visions, and Sentinels tend to be efficient actors. Commanders are masters of thought and theory, but partnering with Sentinels can help them refine their ideas into practical plans that yield results. When Commanders reveal a novel approach, Sentinels cautiously start examining the applications – and costs – in the real world, nicely balancing Commanders’ often passionate embrace of the new. Commanders are among the more practical of the Analysts, and Sentinels can help anchor them even more.

Translating broader ideas into specific realities is reversible, in that Commanders’ creative approach can hold solutions to conventional problems as well. When Sentinels run up against a roadblock, Commanders may offer original thinking to get things back on track. Their imaginations can be the tonic that cures outdated or ineffective practices – something both Commanders and Sentinels rail against. When both accept how each other’s unique approaches can contribute to productivity and draw on their respective strengths, they can become invaluable partners.

Planning

Another area of balance these two offer each other on the job is future thinking and planning. Commanders virtually live in a realm of possibility, always thinking about what the future can be crafted into. Sentinels try to control the present, creating stability in the face of the unknown. They plan for the future but mostly in the context of how they can act in the present to bring it about. When Commanders share their own forward-looking views, Sentinels see more possibilities than they might on their own. Together, they can envision the future and plan accordingly.

Commanders and Sentinels both are more comfortable with the predictable and orderly (even if they define the terms a bit differently), so they are likely to be respectful of each other's approaches, knowing that they are fundamentally grounded in responsible reality. They also are likely to mutually judge their lines of attack as both credible and valuable.

Unbalanced Commander–Sentinel Cooperation

Degrees of Change

There's an old saying: "Nobody likes change except a wet baby." But this isn't entirely true. Intuitive types like Commanders love change (though some prefer more thorough preparation than others). They seek improvement as a matter of course because it represents growth and possibilities to them. Yet, Sentinels adhere to proven standards and traditions, and they like to work within existing norms. Commanders have little regard for the status quo, especially if it gets in the way of improving a system. Sentinels may insist on doing something the "right way," according to how it's always been done; meanwhile, Commanders may insist on doing it a new "right" way, regardless of how it's always been done.

Commanders like radical changes – if they bring them up or a respected person carefully lays out the details, implementation, and consequences. Sentinels, however, prefer incremental change that improves on existing systems in clear ways. The conflict between tradition and change is as old as humanity itself, and it can indeed create problems in the workplace. Between Commanders and Sentinels, this tension can play out in the form of passive-aggressively resisting or discounting each other's contributions.

Rising Resentment

When Sentinels push for short-term specifics or plans that seem too small, Commanders might judge them as unimaginative. In turn, Commanders may find themselves labeled as constant agitators who won't leave "good enough" alone.

In relationships plagued by too narrow of an understanding, Commanders may lose respect for Sentinels' opinions, not consulting them regarding decisions. As a result, they lose the benefit of Sentinels' diligent, detail-oriented approach. Although Commanders may think they're better off without Sentinels' input, their unwillingness to collaborate with these colleagues can cause frustration and headaches when it's time to implement or troubleshoot projects – two areas where Sentinels excel.

To communicate more effectively, Commanders may need to pull their punches a bit. They would do well to understand that Sentinels may react badly to harsh comments and off-the-cuff negative feedback. Because Sentinels are so invested in doing the work they do, maintaining balance, and ensuring things run well, they sometimes take criticism toward an organization or others very personally.

Rebalancing Commander–Sentinel Cooperation

Understanding How to Change

Nothing makes Sentinels feel better than crossing tasks off their lists, and Commanders, with their continuous stream of ideas, can provide an enormous number of tasks for their Sentinel colleagues to complete. This process is only useful, however, if Commanders understand the concept of sensitive, grounded change.

Change, especially when based only on theories and ideas, can make Sentinels uncomfortable. Commanders can allay their Sentinel coworkers' concerns and hesitation if they link their ideas and theories to practical, specific tasks. When suggesting changes to a current system, Commanders who bring forward ideas based on cutting-edge theories are likely to be met with skepticism from Sentinel coworkers. To counteract this, Commanders can try the following:

- Highlight the objective (for example, increase the number of customers using a particular cutting-edge Internet presence to build a community).
- Create a roadmap that shows how the idea will be incorporated into the current structure, as well as what it will look like in one month, three months, six months, and so on.
- Provide a date for when the new idea will be fully integrated into the system.
- Highlight practical tasks and smaller steps, as well as deadlines, increasing the odds of expected results.
- Allow plenty of time for change to take place so Sentinels can feel more comfortable with the transition and be more knowledgeable of any technical aspects of the change process.

Moving beyond the status quo may seem a noble pursuit to innovative Commanders, but Sentinels who prefer to uphold tradition may feel that their views have been overlooked and unappreciated. Commanders should remember that overeager criticism or impatience elicits resistance from even the most supportive Sentinels.

The remedy for this potential pitfall is to focus on patience, gratitude, and sincere respect for the many strengths that Sentinels bring to the workplace. Specifically, Sentinels' attention to detail is an incredible benefit to Commanders. It has been said that Commanders (and other Analysts) create the trains, but Sentinels keep them running on time. Awareness of the symbiotic nature of their workplace relationship fosters mutual respect and appreciation.

Practicing Patience and Awareness

Disagreement can overwhelm Commander–Sentinel relationships in the workplace, but this pair has immense potential for productive, positive interaction. Awareness is essential – especially when it comes to competitive urges, which can trigger stonewalling or unduly harsh criticism.

This doesn't mean that Commanders and Sentinels always agree with each other or come to the same conclusions. Both should practice patience and allow each other to prove – or fail to prove – their points of view in their own time and in their own way. Disagreements are bound to take place as Commanders push their visions and Sentinels resist in favor of the tried and true. Nothing sidelines a project faster than a drawn-out discussion about innovative concepts versus concrete traditions between Commanders and Sentinels. When faced with a situation like this, Commanders can try the following:

- Make the decision to put a “pin” in the conversation or save it for later.

- Tell your colleague that the issue can be discussed further when the schedule is less pressing: after work hours, for instance, or on another workday.
- Regularly ask your Sentinel colleague for advice on how to translate ideas into concrete terms, as this is their strong suit. Solicit feedback regarding which aspects of a plan should be more specific or actionable.
- If suggesting a change, support your argument by outlining tangible rather than intangible benefits.

By bridging the gap between their grandiose ideas and specific goals, Commanders can win over Sentinels and pave the way for success. To communicate effectively with Sentinels, Commanders can ground their use of abstract terms like “vision” and “innovate” with concrete details. This might entail outlining specific benchmarks they’d like to hit, as opposed to reciting a mission or vision; or perhaps they can discuss the tangible upsides of a novel approach rather than the intangible benefits.

Commander-Explorer Cooperation



Though there may seem to be little common ground between Commanders and Explorers, one only need dig deeper. They share a fascination with discovery that

drives personal achievement. They both value independence and discovery over rules and tradition. They especially enjoy turning a fixed idea on its head, creating a whole new perspective. Their shared perspectives enable Commanders and Explorers to work together as innovators.

Balanced Commander-Explorer Cooperation

Combining Vision with Action

Both Commanders and Explorers enjoy searching for answers. Although Commanders enjoy theorizing about ideas and systems, Explorers would rather solve problems in a hands-on fashion. Commanders prefer to think through potential outcomes before acting, whereas Explorers can't wait to start. At their best, the two can embark on a two-step process. Commanders can create ideas, then ask Explorers to join them in a partnership to make the ideas reality. Because people with the Commander personality type can struggle with implementation due to fixation on details, Explorer colleagues who are more action-oriented can help move projects along.

Consider the story of *Apollo 13*, a NASA space mission in 1970. After a mechanical mishap, the nation wasn't sure whether the three U.S. astronauts on board the spacecraft could make it back to Earth alive. The ground control team in Houston can be thought of as Commanders (or any Analyst type). The Commander ground control team members calculated all the numbers and worked out a trajectory that could get the astronauts home.

The astronauts on board the spacecraft served as Explorers, doing the hands-on work and carrying out the details the Commanders had provided, and they eventually got the capsule home. Communication between the ground control team and the

astronauts was vital to the success of the *Apollo 13* rescue. The analogy shows how Explorers' and Commanders' contrasting roles and styles can work together to fulfill the same goal.

Appreciating Levity

Between Commanders and Explorers, the biggest issue may be the former's issue with the latter's seeming disregard of consequences. To Commanders, Explorers can appear as though they're only around to have fun, with very little care for the end game. However, when Commanders decide to appreciate Explorers' strengths, particularly in the workplace, wonderful things can happen.

As colleagues, Commanders can help keep things on track, lending focus to their Explorer coworkers, and Explorers can lighten the mood of sometimes excessively serious Commanders. When working, Commanders can model a more focused and energetic attitude, while also keeping in mind that Explorers can help them to relax a bit – even the most serious Commanders need a break.

Unbalanced Commander-Explorer Cooperation

Strategic Meets Impulsive

Although Commanders and Explorers can work together well, the combination presents some potential problems. Explorers' focus on the present may annoy Commanders, who may see constant attention to the immediate as uninteresting and mundane. With Commanders, there always are bigger fish to fry, and they may lose patience if they feel bogged down in current, hands-on details. Commanders often feel condescending toward people they don't think mix well into their world of strategic design and complex future notions, and they may see those who deal

mostly in hands-on solutions as somehow inferior to visionaries such as themselves. When they voice their disdain as direct criticism, communication with their Explorer coworkers can quickly shut down.

If Commanders' way of thinking is too theoretical for too long, it can lead Explorers to see them as unrealistic, unintelligible, and disengaged from "real life" in any practical way. Explorers aren't known for impulse control, and when their frustration hits a high mark, they may suddenly lose patience, either dismissing Commanders and withdrawing their support or just criticizing them outright. When the two become unhappy with each other, Commanders may resort to displays of smug arrogance. Meanwhile, Explorers typically move forward however they see fit, merely ignoring Commanders if they need to. Dysfunction ensues.

Misaligned Priorities

In stark contrast to Commanders, Explorers often downplay consequences. Given a choice between a bird in the hand or two in the bush, Commanders will choose the two in the bush – though, with the benefit of retrospect, they may regret passing up one in hand. Explorers, on the other hand, tend to shy away from long-term planning and prioritize immediate gains.

In the workplace, this can manifest as priority misalignment. Commanders tend to focus on building lasting relationships with clients and upholding their word, whereas Explorers often favor risky ventures with big payoffs. If communication breaks down, Commanders may judge their Explorer colleagues as shortsighted or trigger-happy. Meanwhile, Explorers may dismiss Commanders as impractical or uptight. If they don't collaborate, Commanders can miss out on exciting opportunities, and Explorers may lose sight of the big picture.

Rebalancing Commander–Explorer Cooperation

Respecting Distinct Types of Genius

Despite their differences, Commanders and Explorers can achieve success in the workplace. Balancing their very different styles begins with mutually understanding each other's strengths and weaknesses, as well as their own.

Often, Explorers can bring ideas to life in ways Commanders would never have thought possible. Genius comes in many forms, and Explorers' genius relies on adaptation and execution. Commanders' focus on facts may seem tedious to Explorers – not because Explorers want to blatantly reject Commanders' style, but because it doesn't occur to them to behave in such an exact manner or to analyze a situation into the ground.

Commanders are notorious for explaining their ideas in abstract, theoretical ways, but Explorers are likely to become bored with long-winded, conceptual matters. Instead of theoretical diatribes, Commanders can ground and “concretize” their sometimes-interminable approaches using methods like the following:

- Focus on sharing a quick overview of your idea, complete with the intro and the conclusion – but skipping most of the body.
- Be aware that not everybody connects to thorough discussions. Look for any chance to stop explaining.
- Take a step back from your Explorer colleague and respect the need for space. They are generally independent and prefer to find their way. Honor that to the degree you can.
- Check in with your Explorer coworker from time to time and *briefly* make sure you're both on the same page.

Although Commanders often are brilliant problem-solvers, they may become paralyzed if they get mired in detail. Because many Explorers thrive under pressure, Commanders benefit from having such teammates, to whom they can turn when circumstances overwhelm their abilities. Both Commanders and Explorers are focused on efficiency, with the former addressing the “why” and the latter addressing the “how.” Each can benefit from the other’s strengths when addressing a problematic situation, becoming helpful allies once they understand the useful qualities each brings to the table.

Understanding Priorities

In difficult working relationships with Explorers, Commanders may choose to block out Explorers’ style instead of accepting the differences in their approaches with an open mind. But stonewalling comes at a cost because it often curtails any chance of collaboration. Trying to understand and work with Explorers’ priorities can increase the chances of overall success.

To revive communication, Commanders might consider how much more effective it is to collaborate with, rather than work around, another individual. Once they acknowledge and accept that, it becomes easier for them to relax as Explorers do things in their fashion. With that comes comfort and perhaps even admiration, which may drive a greater collaborative spirit.

- Focus on listening, learning, and asking questions rather than debating or being right.
- Express curiosity about what your Explorer colleagues are doing, asking open-ended questions. However, be careful to make it part of friendly conversation

rather than interrogation. Nobody likes to be grilled, and Explorers are likely to feel put off if questions seem like scrutiny rather than genuine interest.

- Take some time to get know coworkers as something more than beings who work at the same place. You may be tempted to reduce Explorers to their work roles and to judge them entirely by how they fit into your roles, plans, or ideas. A more well-rounded perspective can help you understand how coworkers think and what's important to them beyond your own narrow context. Have lunch or coffee with coworkers on occasion; it's a healthy way to build work relationships.
- Don't be afraid to try it their way occasionally. Growth comes from expanding beyond your own comfort zone, and Explorers certainly can help. Instead of reflexively criticizing, either silently or out loud, be curious and see where Explorers' more kinetic style leads once in a while. Doing so may offer you an interesting and new perspective.

Resourceful and tenacious, Explorers care about getting things done and moving projects forward. If they try to build honest and respectful relationships, Commanders may come to admire the proactive, fearless spirit that Explorer colleagues bring to the workplace.

Conclusion

Designing the Future

Commanders bring innovation, steadfast energy, and necessary efficiency to their positions, qualities that can easily help strengthen an organization. People with this personality type are likely to be on the cutting edge of experimentation, imagining ways to make the workplace the most effective version of itself. The key for

Commanders is allowing themselves to appear warmer at work, as well as learning how to customize their approach to different individuals.

Fortunately, Commanders possess the ability to improve upon all things, especially themselves. They are the ones to turn to when ideas need to be catapulted or reinforced. They create success for themselves through dedication and efficiency-based idealism, and they have the capacity to carry their ideals throughout their entire career.

Most of all, Commanders refuse to let go of the vision they have for themselves, seeking opportunities to work where they feel intellectually stimulated and effective. With work and determination, they can find a place to plant the seed of their professional vision, then feed it and make it grow. In the end, Commanders have all the tools they need for success.

Final Words



Advancement Isn't Always a Battle

Throughout this e-book, we've discussed many ways that Commanders may approach a range of aspects of their lives. We've touched on their impressive qualities, some less-than-ideal tendencies, and some ideas on how they can improve themselves. These types tend to view things in black and white, but it's very important for Commanders to realize that who they are at any stage isn't shameful. Evolving doesn't necessarily mean fighting "bad" parts of themselves, but instead choosing their behavior consciously.

The point isn't to encourage Commanders to discount or disdain any part of their being, but rather to make wise decisions about which parts to feed, and which parts to rest now and then. For example, winning an argument, however thrilling, is old hat for most Commanders, but empathizing deeply with someone may be a valuable undiscovered talent. Change means adding to who they are, and any behavior intently practiced can eventually become a natural component. Commanders can continuously redefine themselves through their actions, and this is a joyful thing.

Figuring out which of their many mental or emotional skills can take any given moment to its grandest potential is an exciting – and logical – way to live.

A Powerful Force for Good

One thing Commanders can keep in mind as they create and express who they are is the concept of pluralism – not everyone wants to think, act, or live the same way, and that’s OK. Commanders can honor such differences as a part of the great experiment of existence; many people trying many things for many reasons and needs. Just as people are responsible for their own lives, so do they earn the right to attempt their own course. Commanders wouldn’t have it any other way for themselves, and can certainly respect the sovereignty of others. These types’ determination and decisiveness create success when they insist on a constructive outlook instead of becoming sidetracked by unproductive criticism – and life is a whole lot more fun.

Of course, respecting others doesn’t mean that Commanders should restrain themselves from engagement – they can’t be truly happy without vigorously advocating for their beliefs, including improving themselves, others, and the world. What’s key to developing such strength is realizing that tolerance and respect don’t replace the proud sharing of ideas and opinions, they *enable* it. When Commanders refine their steely pugnacity into a voice of reasoned encouragement, the world listens, and when their ideas are beneficial to others, the world thanks them. A pointed, rational argument can be a wonderful thing – it all depends on what the aim is, and why.

True strength is the ability to uplift minds and circumstances. Commanders are at their best when their words contain positive energy and solid information, and when

their deeds build something great. Wanting to be powerful is in no way a bad thing, but how that power is used is a serious matter – everyone must choose whether to play the hero or the villain. We hope this e-book makes it clear that Commanders have all the tools they need to be as great as they desire, and that their reaction to all that seems so wrong in the world can be to reach out and make it better.

The Road Ahead

We've covered many different topics in this profile, and we hope that the chapters have offered insight and answered questions about the Commander personality type. We hope that readers will now find it easier to understand other people and their perspectives. This profile isn't meant to be read just once. When trying to understand another person better, or struggling to understand oneself, another read-through can offer fresh insight.

Also, spend some time on our [website](#) – for example, in our [articles section](#), [research zone](#), or the [Academy](#). There is a wealth of inspiring advice and information on the website, and we strongly recommend that you take a look. If you have some spare time, consider lending us a helping hand by contributing to the [translation project](#), taking additional [surveys](#), or simply [sending us a message](#) and sharing your thoughts about this profile or the website in general. We would love to hear from you.

We wish the best of luck to all Commanders. What matters most in Commanders' lives is that their paths through life reflect who they are, deep within. Our lives are often too full of troubles, conflicts, and worries. By working to better understand each other, we can make our relationships, communities, and world more aware, more genuine, and more peaceful.

Until next time.

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